

THE SURVIVING AGE

A Middle Class Journey

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Also by Dolat Khan

The Power of Minor Shift

For every middle-class family in Pakistan

that earns just enough to dream

and loves more than enough to keep going.

And for my cousin Muzamil Khan —

who taught me that education is not a privilege

but a refusal. A quiet, daily, unbreakable refusal.

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Chapter One

Beginning Life in the Middle Class

Birth to Ten

Nobody announces the middle class. You don't get a letter in the mail or a ceremony at the district office. It announces itself quietly, in the way your father winces when the school sends home the annual fee slip. In the way your mother folds the grocery list twice before she takes it to the shop. In the way the word "later" becomes the answer to so many questions that you stop asking some of them altogether.

This is the life that millions of Pakistani families are living right now. Not the very poor, who have their own brutal literature. Not the wealthy, who have their own comfortable blindness. This is the life in the middle — educated enough to know exactly what they are missing, proud enough to never say so out loud, and resilient enough to keep going every single morning even when the mathematics of the month simply do not add up.

The story starts before the child is born. It starts at a kitchen table, or on a charpoy in the courtyard, or in a small rented room in Quetta or Karachi or Rawalpindi where two people are sitting together, very late at night, trying to decide if they can afford a baby.

They are not young in the irresponsible way. They are young in the middle-class way — which means they have been careful, they have been saving, they have been waiting for the right time. And still, when they look at the numbers, the right time seems to keep moving. The hospital charges alone — a normal delivery in a private hospital — can eat three to five months of a government servant's salary. Then there are the first-year costs. Vaccinations. Formula or the supplements the doctor recommends. A cot. Clothes the child will outgrow in four months. Diapers, enough of them to fill a small room.

They look at each other across the table. One of them says: "We'll manage." And they both know that managing is not the same as having enough, but they also know that the alternative is a life where they never begin, where they keep waiting for a comfort that will never arrive fully. So they say yes. They decide to love someone they haven't met. And the middle-class story, with all its beauty and all its cost, gets another chapter.

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Quetta, 2009 — The Month the Salary Came Late

Sadia Baloch was thirty-one years old and seven months pregnant when her husband Farooq told her the salary had been delayed. He worked as a junior officer in the Balochistan Public Works Department. His monthly salary was forty-two thousand rupees. He told her on a Thursday evening, standing in the kitchen doorway with his shoes still on, which meant the news was too heavy to wait.

Sadia didn't say anything for a moment. She was stirring a pot of dal. She kept stirring it.

"How long?" she asked.

"They said ten days. Maybe fifteen."

She did the calculation the way middle-class women always do — silently, rapidly, invisibly. The rent was due in four days. The private doctor she'd been seeing for the last seven months, the one who actually showed up to appointments and knew her case,

charged three thousand rupees per visit and she had one scheduled next week. She had around nine thousand rupees in the house. She had her mother's number saved under "Ammi" and she had not called it to ask for money in four years. She was not going to call it now.

"Okay," she said. She reduced the flame under the dal. "Go wash your hands, dinner is almost ready."

That was it. No argument, no tears. This is what middle-class endurance looks like from the inside — not dramatic, not heroic. Just a woman standing at a stove, doing the math, saying okay, and continuing to cook dinner. The crisis was real. The stoicism was real. And somewhere behind both of them, barely visible, was the love that made the whole equation worth solving.

Sadia went to a government hospital for that last month of her pregnancy. She didn't tell anyone from her neighborhood. The government hospital was fine — the doctors were capable, the staff was mostly decent — but in Quetta, as in every Pakistani city, there is a specific shame attached to being seen at the government hospital, a judgment that follows you home. You went there because you had to. And everyone who sees you there knows you had to.

Her daughter was born healthy. Small but healthy. They named her Zara. The delivery cost twelve thousand rupees in informal charges — money that goes to the ward boys, the nurses who slip you things you're not officially entitled to but desperately need, the man who finds you a private room when the ward is full. No receipt. Just cash, quietly exchanged, and nobody looks at each other.

Farooq's salary arrived eleven days late. They were fine. They had managed. And Zara grew up not knowing any of this, the way most middle-class children grow up — on the surface of a life that their parents built underneath them, invisibly, at considerable cost.

Lahore — The Calculator at the Dining Table

Across the country, in a three-bedroom apartment in Gulshan-e-Iqbal, Karachi, a twelve-year-old boy named Saad Siddiqui had recently made a discovery that he didn't know how to process.

His father was an accountant. Which meant his father understood numbers the way some men understand prayer — deeply, privately, with a kind of devotion that excluded outsiders. Every night after dinner, his father would sit at the dining table with his salary slip, the utility bills, the school fee receipts, and the little notebook where he tracked everything. Saad had seen this ritual his whole life without understanding it. He'd assumed it was just what fathers did. Fathers sat at tables with papers. It was part of being a father.

But one evening Saad came home from school early and walked into the dining room without thinking and saw his father's face before his father had time to arrange it. The face of a man doing arithmetic that doesn't balance. Not panic — his father was too controlled for panic — but something older and quieter than panic. Something that looked like carrying a weight in a place where other people couldn't see it.

His father looked up, saw him, and smiled. "Aagaye? Chai piyoge?" He closed the notebook.

Saad said yes to the tea and went to his room and sat on his bed for a long time. Something had shifted. He couldn't name it. He was twelve, and twelve-year-olds don't have the vocabulary for what he'd seen. But the image stayed with him — his father's face, unguarded, carrying something — and from that evening onward, Saad started paying a different kind of attention to his house. To the gap between what was said and what was meant. To the price of things. To the weight his parents were moving through the world with, quietly, every single day.

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Two Schools, One Street

In Quetta's Satellite Town — a neighborhood that is neither rich nor poor, that balances on the exact line the middle class is always balancing on — there are two schools within four minutes' walk of each other.

The private one has a freshly painted blue gate. English signage. A guard who sits on a plastic chair and looks important. The fee for Class Five is six thousand rupees a month. The building is real concrete. The bathrooms work. The teachers come every day because missing a day has consequences. In the morning, a line of motorcycles and small cars stretches down the lane as parents drop off children in pressed uniforms.

The government school, four minutes away, has a gate that doesn't fully close. The sign is faded Urdu on a board that hasn't been painted since the second Musharraf term, by the look of it. There is no guard. The monthly cost is a few hundred rupees in informal fees — officially free, which means it costs whatever the teachers decide it costs that month. The classrooms have forty-five children in them. Some are sitting on the floor. The ceiling fan works on one speed: furious.

Pervez, a daily wage laborer in Satellite Town, sends his nine-year-old son Imtiaz to the government school. Not because he doesn't understand the difference. He understands it perfectly. His neighbor's son goes to the private school and comes home reading English sentences that Imtiaz cannot. Pervez understands what this difference will mean in ten years.

"I know," he says, when asked about it. He is sitting outside his house on a plastic chair, eating his dinner at six in the evening because he's been up since four. "I know the private school is better. What do you want me to say? I earn four hundred rupees a day when there is work. There isn't always work. Six thousand a month in fees — I can't. I just can't."

He goes quiet. There is no anger in it — or rather, the anger has been lived with so long it has become something else. Acceptance that contains, if you look carefully, a certain grief.

Imtiaz is a bright child. His teacher at the government school — a woman named Nasreen who has been teaching Class Four for seventeen years on a salary that has increased by eleven

thousand rupees in that entire time — says he is one of the best students she has had in years. Quick. Curious. Asks too many questions, which she says with a smile that tells you she doesn't actually think it's a problem.

"The problem is not the child," Nasreen says. "The problem is that I have forty-four other children in the same room, and the building hasn't been repaired since 2017, and I haven't been given new textbooks in three years. I give him what I can. He takes everything I give him. But I am limited. The system has made me limited."

This is the reality that no politician mentions in a speech and no television anchor debates with real urgency: that the quality of a child's mind is not what determines the quality of his education in Pakistan. What determines it is his parents' bank balance. And the middle class — that vast middle ground of families who earn too much to qualify for anything free and too little to afford what they actually need — pays the highest price for this gap.

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What the First Ten Years Actually Cost

Let's put numbers to it, because the middle class lives in numbers even when it doesn't want to.

In urban Pakistan — Quetta, Peshawar, Lahore, Karachi — the first year of a child's life costs a family somewhere between three hundred thousand and five hundred thousand rupees when you add everything honestly. Hospital delivery. Post-natal care. Formula and feeding costs for twelve months. The cot, the clothes, the vaccinations that aren't covered by the government program in adequate supply. The unexpected expenses — a fever that sends you to a private clinic at midnight because the government hospital emergency is forty minutes away and the child is burning.

That is, for a family earning sixty to eighty thousand rupees a month, five to seven months of total income. Before the year is over.

By the time the child reaches school age, the family has typically either recovered this deficit or learned to live inside it. School fees begin. In a midrange private school, that's four to eight thousand rupees a month. A hundred thousand rupees a year, roughly. Plus uniforms — new ones every two years, sometimes every year if the child grows fast. Plus stationery, books, the notebook fees that are somehow always announced two weeks before they're due. Plus the exam fees, the picnic fees, the function fees, the extra coaching that the school itself tells you your child needs but that costs separately.

A family in Quetta with one child in a private school and one parent working a government job is spending, conservatively, thirty to forty percent of their monthly income on that child's education alone. This leaves the remaining sixty to seventy percent for: rent, food, utilities, transport, clothing, medical costs for the whole family, any savings at all, and every unexpected thing life throws at them — which, in Pakistan, is considerable.

And yet they do it. They stretch the budget until it is almost transparent and they hold it up to the light and they find the places where it can still give. Because what is the alternative? The alternative is the government school, and the government school is — for many families — a grief they cannot afford to put their child through.

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Quetta — What the Mother Carries

Mariam was thirty-four years old when I spoke to her. She lives in Quetta's Jinnah Town in a three-room house she rents with her husband Farrukh, who drives a school van. Together they earn approximately sixty-five thousand rupees a month. They have two children: a daughter in Class Six and a son in Class Three.

She keeps a notebook. Not a digital one — a physical notebook, green cover, bought from a stationary shop for forty rupees. In it she records every expense. Not because she enjoys accounting. Because, she explains, "if I don't write it down, the money disappears and I don't know where it went. When I write it

down, I know where it went. It doesn't hurt less, but at least I know."

I asked her what the hardest part of these early years was — not the hardest practically, but emotionally.

She thought about it for a moment. She was sitting cross-legged on the floor — her daughter was doing homework on the charpoy behind her, earbuds in, pencil moving. The television was on low.

"When my daughter was in Class Two," she said, "her best friend had a birthday party. At a hotel. Balloons, a bouncy castle, a DJ. My daughter came home and she was—" Mariam paused. "She wasn't sad, exactly. She was trying not to be sad. She was seven. She was trying so hard to be okay. She said, 'Ammi, it was nice. But our birthdays at home are nicer because you make my favourite cake yourself.' And I knew she was saying it to make me feel better. A seven-year-old. Protecting me."

She looked at her hands. "That is the hardest part. When they learn to protect you from the truth of your own limitations."

Farrukh, her husband, came in from the other room as she said this. He'd heard it. He sat down on the chair near the door and didn't say anything for a few seconds. Then he said: "They are good children. They understand more than we realize."

Yes. That is precisely the point. They understand more than we realize. And the understanding — the early, quiet education in what a family can and cannot do — is part of what makes the middle-class child. It is not all bad. Understanding the value of things because you've seen what they cost your parents is not nothing. It builds empathy. It builds an awareness of sacrifice that children from wealthier families sometimes never develop.

But it also costs something. It costs childhood a portion of its lightness. It asks children to be small adults before they are ready. And the middle class, which loves its children ferociously and can never give them everything, carries this cost in silence — in notebooks with green covers, in bedtime conversations that circle around the same truths without quite landing on them, in a mother who smiles when her daughter says the birthday was fine.

The Small Wars of Childhood

There is another front on which the middle-class child fights, and it is the one that nobody prepares him for: the social front.

Between the ages of five and ten, Pakistani children learn to read each other with a precision that would embarrass adults. They learn it not from cruelty, necessarily, but from proximity and attention. Children notice everything. They notice whose shoes are new and whose are carefully polished to look new. They notice who has the branded lunch box and who has the plastic one from the Sunday bazaar. They notice who is picked up in a car and who walks home. They file all of this information away without knowing they are filing it.

In a Class Four classroom in Satellite Town, Quetta, there is a boy named Hamid who has understood, by the age of nine, that he is somewhere in the middle. Not the poorest in his class — there is a boy whose father is a daily laborer and who sometimes comes to school without having eaten breakfast, and Hamid knows this and is kind to him in the particular way that children are kind when they sense something painful. But not the wealthiest either. The wealthiest is Arsalan, whose father owns a pharmacy and who has a mobile phone in his school bag even though they're technically not allowed.

Hamid exists in the middle of this hierarchy with a careful, low-key competence that he has developed without being taught it. He is good at football, which helps — football costs nothing and makes you valuable. He is funny in the right measure, enough to be liked, not so much that the teachers notice. He has figured out that the best way to exist in his position is to be useful to everyone without being dependent on anyone.

He is nine years old. He has already developed a professional-grade survival strategy for navigating social hierarchies. This is the middle class producing its children.

His mother, a school teacher named Rukhsana who earns twenty-two thousand rupees a month — a salary that has not moved significantly in six years — watches this and feels two things simultaneously: pride at how well he manages, and a low, persistent sadness that he has to manage at all.

"He never asks for much," she says. "Other children his age ask for things all the time — new shoes, a video game, money for the canteen. Hamid rarely asks. He knows the answer before he asks. I taught him that without meaning to. Just by my face, I think. By the way I look when I open the fee envelope."

She looks out the window for a moment. The lane outside is dusty. A donkey cart is passing.

"I wish he would ask more," she says. "I wish he didn't already know."

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The Performance of Adequacy

Middle-class parenting in Pakistan has a public dimension that is exhausting to maintain and impossible to abandon. The family must appear fine. Not wealthy — that would be suspicious and also unattainable — but fine. Decent. Managing comfortably. The children must be clean and well-dressed. The home, when visitors come, must reflect a certain standard. The school the child attends must be one that can be named without embarrassment.

This performance is not dishonesty. It is dignity. In a culture where financial difficulty is read as personal failure — as a sign that the man is not working hard enough, that the woman is not managing properly, that the family has some fundamental inadequacy — maintaining appearances is a form of self-protection. It is the refusal to let the world's judgment land on you and stick.

But it costs energy. The energy that goes into appearing fine is energy that isn't going somewhere else. The father who spends an hour choosing which social gathering to attend and which to decline — because the one he declines will require an explanation

but the one he attends will require money he doesn't have — is spending psychological resources on a problem that shouldn't exist.

Tariq is a schoolteacher in Quetta, thirty-two years old, father of a six-year-old son. He tells me about the first time he attended a parent-teacher meeting at his son's private school — a school he is sacrificing significantly to keep his son in — and found himself seated next to a man who, within three minutes of conversation, had mentioned his car (imported, relatively new), his property in Islamabad, and the overseas university he was considering for his son.

"I was sitting there thinking: my son is in this school because I don't sleep properly, because my wife does tutoring in the evenings after her own job, because we haven't bought new furniture since we got married seven years ago. And this man is—" Tariq stops. He doesn't finish the sentence. He drinks his tea. "I smiled and nodded," he says. "What else do you do?"

What else do you do. This is the middle-class philosophy stated in its most compressed form. You smile. You nod. You go home and you open the notebook and you do the math again and you figure out how to make it work for one more month. And then another. And then another.

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What These Years Give

It would be dishonest to write only about the costs. The first ten years of a middle-class life in Pakistan also give things that are not nothing.

They give the child an education in empathy that cannot be taught in any classroom. When you grow up in a house where money is thought about carefully, you understand from early on that things have weight — that the shirt on your back represents hours of someone's labor, that the meal on the table was chosen over other things that were not on the table. This is not a lesson that comes with suffering, necessarily. It comes with attention.

And children raised in middle-class homes are, by necessity, attentive.

They give the child a model of resilience that is specific and daily, not abstract and inspirational. He does not see resilience in a poster on the wall. He sees it in his father going to work on a day when the bus fare has to come out of the grocery money. He sees it in his mother remaking a meal out of leftovers and making it taste like a choice rather than a limitation. These are not dramatic acts. That is precisely their power. They teach the child that endurance is ordinary, that difficulty is a condition to be navigated rather than an exception to be horrified by.

In Quetta, in Lahore, in Karachi, in the small towns where middle-class families live their careful, loving, stretched lives — the children who come out of these first ten years are, more often than not, equipped. Not with money. Not with connections. Not with the easy confidence of those for whom things have always worked out. But with something more durable: the knowledge, absorbed before they had words for it, that problems can be outlasted. That families hold. That you can want more than you have and still be okay.

That knowledge is worth something. It will be tested — hard — in the years that follow. But it is real. And in the middle of everything this life costs, that is one thing it gives back.

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Where the Story Begins

In Quetta's Satellite Town, little Zara — born in the government hospital, twelve thousand rupees in informal charges, father's salary eleven days late — is now eight years old and in Class Three. She is, by her teacher's account, exceptionally good at mathematics. She likes to organize things. Her mother's notebook with the green cover sits in the kitchen drawer, and Zara has once or twice picked it up and looked at the columns of numbers without fully understanding them.

One day she will. One day she will look at those columns and understand exactly what they mean — what each entry cost, what was given up to make room for it, how much love looks like on paper when it is expressed in rupees carefully accounted for.

In a house in Lahore, Saad Siddiqui is sleeping with his schoolbag already packed for tomorrow, because his mother packed it for him after he fell asleep, quietly, the way middle-class mothers do things — without announcement, without credit, just done.

And somewhere in Quetta, in a house that will enter this story more fully in the chapters ahead, a boy is growing up who will one day stand in front of an audience at one of Pakistan's most prestigious universities and speak with authority and clarity about the world he came from. He doesn't know this yet. He is still a child, and his life is still mostly a series of hardships that nobody has given him a map for.

But he is paying attention. He is learning. He is deciding, in the wordless way that children decide the most important things, who he is going to be.

The first decade ends. The harder decade begins.

Chapter Two

Dreams vs Reality

The Foundation Years — Eleven to Fifteen

There is a specific moment — it happens to almost every middle-class child in Pakistan, and it happens only once, and it cannot be undone. It is the moment they understand, with sudden and complete clarity, exactly what kind of family they come from.

It doesn't always arrive as a single dramatic scene. Sometimes it builds over weeks, a slow accumulation of small observations that one day tips into understanding. Sometimes it arrives in an instant — a comment made at school, a classmate's birthday party, a number overheard in a hushed conversation between parents. However it comes, it comes. And after it does, the child is never quite the same. Something lifts from their vision, the way fog lifts from a road, and they see the landscape they are actually standing in.

Most of the time, this happens somewhere between eleven and fifteen.

It is the age of comparison. The age when a child stops looking at his own life from the inside and starts measuring it against the lives around him. The age when he notices, perhaps for the first time, that his shoes are different from the shoes of the boy sitting next to him. Not worse, necessarily — but different in a way that carries information. And he is old enough now to read that information.

This chapter is about those years. The years when the comfortable fog of childhood burns off and the middle-class child begins to see, with uncomfortable sharpness, the world he has been born into. It is not a comfortable sight. But it is not without beauty either. And the way a child responds to it — whether he turns inward or outward, whether it hardens him or sharpens him, whether it makes him ashamed or determined — will shape almost everything that follows.

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Karachi — The Morning of the Shoes

Zainab was eleven years old and in Class Six when it happened to her.

It was a Monday morning in the second week of the new school year. She was sitting in the second row of her classroom in a private school in North Nazimabad, Karachi, waiting for the English teacher to arrive. The girl who sat beside her — her name was Maryam, her father owned two pharmacies in Gulshan — was wearing a new pair of shoes. They were white leather, with a small logo on the side that Zainab didn't recognize but understood instinctively to be important. They were the kind of shoes that said something.

Zainab looked down at her own shoes. They were brown leather, polished carefully — her mother had polished them the night before, she had watched her do it, sitting on the kitchen floor with a cloth and a small tin of polish that smelled like petrol and something sweet. They were good shoes. They were clean. But they were from last year, and the right sole had been glued back once, and they were not white, and they did not have a logo.

She looked at Maryam's shoes. She looked at her own. She looked away.

Nothing was said. No one pointed. No one laughed. The English teacher arrived and the lesson began and the morning moved forward the way mornings do. But something had lodged itself in Zainab that would not dislodge.

When she came home that afternoon, her mother asked how her day was. Fine, she said. She went to her room, put her bag down, sat on the edge of her bed. She wasn't sad, exactly. She was trying to organize something in her mind that didn't want to be organized — a feeling that her life had a particular shape and she had only now seen it fully for the first time.

Her mother called her for lunch. She washed her hands and sat at the table and ate her roti. She didn't mention the shoes. Her mother was a woman who worked two tuition sessions a day after her own morning teaching job to pay for this private school. Zainab understood this in the way children understand things — not in complete sentences but in accumulated images: her mother at seven in the evening still teaching, her father going through the fee receipts with a particular careful attention, the way the word "later" arrived quickly whenever she asked for certain things.

She had understood all of this before. But on that Monday, sitting at the lunch table with her polished brown shoes on, it assembled itself into a single clear picture. And the picture told her: you are in the middle. Not at the bottom — you know what the bottom looks like, there are children in your city who beg at traffic signals. But not at the top either, not at the Maryam level, not at the level where shoes have logos and nobody pauses before saying yes.

You are in the middle.

This is the awakening. Painless, mostly. But permanent.

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Lahore — The Weight Behind the Words

Saad Siddiqui had been watching his father at the dining table his whole life. But it took until he was twelve to understand what he was watching.

His father was an accountant at a textile company in Lahore. He earned eighty-five thousand rupees a month — which sounded like a large number to Saad until he started, around the age of eleven, to pay attention to what things cost. The school fee

alone was seventeen thousand. The electricity bill last summer had been fourteen thousand because the heat had been relentless and the AC ran without stopping. The motorcycle had needed a new engine part. His sister needed new books for the new grade. His mother needed medication for her knee, the chronic kind, the bottle you buy every month.

He had started doing this arithmetic without being asked to. Something in him just began tracking. He would hear his father mention a cost and he would file it away and add it to the other costs and at some point in the evening he would find himself doing rough calculations with numbers that didn't quite fit into the eighty-five thousand container.

One night — he was twelve, it was a Tuesday in November — he came home from school early because the afternoon period had been cancelled. He walked into the dining room without thinking and saw his father sitting at the table with the bills and the salary slip and the little blue notebook, and he saw his father's face.

His father was not crying. He was not even, exactly, distressed. But he had that look — the one he only had when he thought nobody was watching. A look of a man doing a calculation for the hundredth time that still does not come out right. A man who is not defeated but who is very, very tired of this particular problem.

He heard Saad and looked up and his face rearranged itself in under a second. "Aagaye? Chai piyoge?" He closed the notebook.

Saad said yes to the tea and went to his room and sat on his bed and looked at the ceiling for twenty minutes.

After that he stopped asking for things. Not completely — he still asked for what was necessary, what the school required, what couldn't be avoided. But the extra requests, the casual wants, the "Baba can I have" that children fire off without much thought — those became rarer. He learned to filter himself before he spoke. He learned to read the month — early in the month was better, just after salary day. The last week was bad. He could tell from the way his father held himself at the dinner table.

This is the particular education that no school provides but that middle-class children across Pakistan are quietly receiving, every day, in the dining rooms and kitchens of houses like Saad's. An education in reading people, in timing, in the economics of family love. In how much things actually cost. In what it means to carry responsibility without letting anyone see the weight.

By the time Saad was fourteen, he had become, without consciously deciding to, a careful person. He did not waste. He did not demand. He watched and he learned and he stored away what he observed for a future use he couldn't yet name.

Later, much later, when he was in his twenties and working his first real job and managing his own budget for the first time, he would understand that his father at that dining table had taught him more about financial discipline than any textbook ever could. Not through a lecture. Through a face, unguarded, seen once, never spoken about.

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Rawalpindi — The Battery Lamp and the Extra Tutor

Amna Khan was fourteen years old, and she studied by the light of a battery-operated lamp during load-shedding, which in the summer came for six hours a day, sometimes eight.

She lived in a neighborhood in Rawalpindi where the power cuts were inconsistent and therefore particularly maddening — not the reliable kind you can plan around, but the kind that arrive at exactly the wrong moment, when the question you are working through is still half-formed, when the diagram you are copying from the book is half-drawn. She had learned to keep the lamp within reach at all times. She had learned to check the battery before she sat down to study.

Her father, Imran, was a government employee who earned fifty-eight thousand rupees a month. He had two daughters — Amna in Class Nine, Hira in Class Seven — and a son in Class Four. All three were in private schools. The combined fees were thirty-one thousand rupees a month. He had borrowed money

twice that year — once in March, when the school sent home a bill for the annual science practical charges that nobody had warned him about, and once in July when Amna's tutor informed them that she needed additional coaching in Chemistry if she was going to score well in the Board exams.

The tutor's fee was four thousand rupees a month. Imran had said "theek hai" and gone home and sat quietly for an evening and then found a way to make it work. He didn't tell Amna about the difficulty. He just told her: your Chemistry tutor starts Thursday.

Amna knew, the way Saad knew, the way Zainab knew. She knew without being told. She had watched her father's face when the school fee reminder arrived. She had seen the brief, controlled expression — contained but real — that passed over him before he composed himself and said, "I'll get a bank transfer done tomorrow."

She studied hard. Not just because she was bright, though she was. But because she understood, in the wordless language of a middle-class child who has been paying attention, that each percentage point in her exam score was connected to something her parents had given up. The tutor's fee was a debt. The battery lamp was a small sacrifice. The combination — study hard, don't waste what has been paid for — was a kind of contract she had made with herself without anyone asking her to.

"She never complains," her mother, Sana, tells me. "Other children her age — my sister's children in Islamabad, they go to tuitions and they complain about the teachers, about the homework, about how tired they are. Amna never complains. She just does it." She pauses. "Sometimes I wish she would complain. Just a little. Just so I know she's still a child."

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The Social Life of Envy

Between eleven and fifteen, the social world of a Pakistani middle-class child becomes a place of enormous complexity.

Friendships form and fracture along lines that have more to do with money than anyone likes to admit. The geography of who sits with whom at lunch, who gets invited to whose birthday, who owns the kind of phone that makes you matter — all of this rearranges itself constantly, and the middle-class child must navigate it without any clear map.

In Quetta, in a school in the Jinnah Town area, there is a thirteen-year-old girl named Nadia whose mother hand-sews her shalwar kameez to match, as closely as possible, the branded clothes her wealthier classmates wear. Her mother — Fareeha, the same woman who works two jobs and keeps the green expense notebook — has learned to identify the styles from a distance and replicate them at a fraction of the cost. She is skilled at this. Sometimes Nadia can't tell the difference herself.

But Nadia can always tell. There is a difference in the fabric, in the small details, in the way a handmade outfit carries itself versus one produced in a factory to a precise specification. She doesn't say this to her mother. Her mother's effort is an act of love so large and so particular that criticizing it would be a kind of cruelty. So she wears the clothes and she goes to school and she performs a confidence she does not always feel.

At her school, the birthday parties have become an arms race that nobody announced but everybody is fighting. In Class Seven, the parties were at homes, with samosas and a cake and some games. By Class Eight, they were in restaurants. By Class Nine, one girl's party was at a hotel in Quetta's Serena, with a DJ and a dessert table and fairy lights draped across the walls. Nadia did not attend that party. She said she was ill. She was not ill.

"I can't ask my parents for the outfit to wear to something like that," she says, matter-of-factly. She does not say this with bitterness. She says it the way she says most practical things — as a fact to be managed, not a wound to be nursed. "And even if I had the clothes, I would spend the whole party worrying about whether someone noticed they weren't the right brand. It's easier not to go."

This is what the comparison machine does to a child by the time she is thirteen. It doesn't just hurt — it teaches a survival strategy based on withdrawal. Avoid the situations that expose the

gap. Opt out gracefully before you are excluded ungracefully. Become skilled at the quiet, face-saving exit.

The problem with this strategy is that it also means opting out of life. The parties, the gatherings, the easy social infrastructure of adolescence — these are where friendships are made and confidence is built. The middle-class child who learns to withdraw is protecting herself from one kind of pain while walking into another.

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Islamabad — One Laptop, Three Children

The house in G-10, Islamabad, has one laptop. It is a Dell, four years old, with a hinge that needs to be held at a specific angle or the screen goes dark. Bilal is fourteen, his sister Anum is twelve, his younger brother Asad is nine. All three are in private schools that have, over the past three years, moved more and more of their homework online. Assignments submitted via Google Classroom. Research projects requiring internet access. Video presentations. Group chats where class announcements are made.

Their father, Zahid, earns one hundred and twenty thousand rupees a month working as a mid-level manager at a telecom company. He has done the math repeatedly. Three separate laptops would cost, for anything usable, around two hundred and fifty thousand rupees. That is two months' salary. With rent, school fees, groceries, fuel, his mother's medical expenses in Peshawar, and his sister's wedding contribution he is still paying back — there is no version of the budget where three laptops fit.

So they have one. And every evening, when all three children come home with things that need to be done online, the negotiation begins.

Zahid has instituted a system. Homework first, in order of deadline. Then Anum gets the laptop for her art project research. Then Bilal for his essay. Asad, who needs it least, goes last. It is a fair system. It is also, for a fourteen-year-old who is trying to do a

group project with classmates who are messaging him in real time and expecting responses, deeply insufficient.

"My group has a WhatsApp chat," Bilal tells me. "They discuss things in the evening. By the time I get the laptop, sometimes it's nine o'clock, and they've already made all the decisions. I just agree to whatever they decided." He shrugs. "It's fine. I don't make a big deal of it."

He says it's fine in the tone of someone who has said it enough times that he has almost convinced himself. But there is something in his posture — a slight stiffness, the shrug that comes a beat too quickly — that suggests the cost of this "fine." The cost of being perpetually slightly behind. Of always catching up to a conversation that moved without you. Of learning, at fourteen, to minimize your own inconvenience in the telling of it.

Zahid knows about the group chat. His son hasn't told him — Bilal protects his father from this particular guilt with the same careful love that Amna in Rawalpindi protects hers. But Zahid works in tech. He understands what one shared laptop means for three children navigating an educational system that has migrated online without providing the infrastructure to support it.

"I am trying to save for a second device," he says quietly. "It might take six months." He looks at his hands. "Six months is a long time when you are fourteen and you have projects due."

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Peshawar — The Cricket Bat with the Repaired Handle

Hassan's cricket bat had been repaired three times. The handle had been rewrapped twice with fresh grip tape. The edge had a hairline crack that his father had filled with wood glue and then sanded smooth. The bat was four years old and had outlasted what bats are supposed to outlast because Hassan treated it with a care that other boys reserved for phones or bicycles.

He was fifteen and he was, by the account of every coach who had seen him play, genuinely talented. Not "good for his age"

talented — actually talented. His footwork was instinctive. His timing was clean. He read length earlier than boys two years older than him, and he had a cut shot that his coach at school, a man who had played first-class cricket in the nineties and still talked about it with the reverence of a religious experience, described as "a gift, not a skill."

The cricket academy in Peshawar that could develop him properly charged fifteen thousand rupees a month. Plus transport costs. Plus the equipment they required — a new bat, pads of a certain specification, gloves, helmet. The full investment, if you were starting from nothing, would be somewhere around forty to fifty thousand rupees to set up and fifteen thousand a month thereafter.

His father, Akhtar, earned ninety thousand rupees a month as a bank officer. He had done the math. With three children, a rented house in University Town, his wife's medical costs, and the school fees that consumed roughly thirty percent of his income, there was no room. He had looked for room the way middle-class fathers look for room — carefully, methodically, turning the budget this way and that to see if a different angle changed anything. It didn't.

He told Hassan: "Beta, your studies come first. Cricket can wait."

Hassan nodded. He understood. He was fifteen and he had been middle-class his whole life — he understood the language of "can wait" perfectly. It meant: probably never, and I am sorry, and I love you, and there is nothing I can do.

He kept playing for the school team. He kept repairing the bat. He watched YouTube videos of professional players — specifically their footwork, specifically their cut shots — and practiced the movements in the small corridor outside his bedroom at night, shuffling sideways in his socks on the tile floor, playing imaginary deliveries until his mother called him to stop the noise.

There is a particular kind of discipline that grows in a child who loves something deeply and knows it will not be fully supported. It is not the discipline of ambition exactly, not the kind

that gets rewarded in school assemblies. It is quieter than that. More private. It is the discipline of not letting go of the thing you love simply because no one is going to pay for it.

Hassan carried his bat to every practice in a cloth bag he had sewn himself — his mother had taught him how, using scraps from an old dupatta. The other boys had proper kit bags, the kind with the brand name down the side. His cloth bag had his initials embroidered on the front in green thread, small and careful, the letters slightly uneven.

He was not ashamed of the cloth bag. He was proud of it, actually, in a way he couldn't quite explain.

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What School Teaches That Isn't in the Syllabus

The academic pressure between Class Six and Class Ten in Pakistan is, for middle-class families, a particular kind of relentless. The private schools that these families sacrifice to send their children to have, over the past two decades, developed a culture that treats exam scores not as measures of learning but as the entire point of learning. By Class Eight, the child is already being prepared for the Board exam. By Class Nine, the entire year is organized around the anxiety of what will happen in Class Ten.

The tutorial system feeds on this anxiety with extraordinary efficiency. Schools tell parents that their children need extra coaching to perform at the level the school itself expects. The parents pay, because they have already committed so much — financially, emotionally — to this particular school, this particular trajectory, that the cost of stopping now feels higher than the cost of continuing.

In Lahore, Saad's father spent fourteen thousand rupees a month on his son's after-school tutoring — on top of seventeen thousand in school fees. Thirty-one thousand a month, out of eighty-five thousand income, for the education of one child. He had one other child. He did the same for her when her time came.

He never discussed this openly. It was just a fact of the life they were living.

But the pressure does not fall only on the parents. It falls — with considerable force — on the children.

Fourteen-year-old Fatima in Faisalabad has learned to manage her parents' expectations with a precision that would impress any project manager. She knows that mentioning a school expense works best in the days just after salary arrives. She knows that framing a want as a need — "the teacher said we should have this book" rather than "I want this book" — increases the probability of yes. She knows that asking for two things at once is always a mistake; ask for one, wait, then ask for the other.

She is fourteen years old and she has developed a sophisticated strategy for navigating adult financial psychology. This is not manipulation — not in any sinister sense. It is the entirely understandable adaptation of a child who loves her parents and does not want to cause them unnecessary pain, who has learned that the word "want" can hurt someone you love if that someone is already stretched thin.

The sad irony is that this kind of emotional intelligence — reading people, timing requests, understanding what can be asked and what cannot — is exactly what good managers, good negotiators, good human beings need. The middle-class child acquires it early. Through the wrong kind of circumstance, but in a way that leaves them genuinely equipped.

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Quetta — The Lane Behind the School

There is a lane behind the private school in Satellite Town, Quetta, that tells you everything about the economics of Pakistani education in two hundred meters.

At seven forty-five in the morning, the lane fills with cars. Not expensive cars — these are the middle-class vehicles, the Mehrans with the sun-faded hoods, the aging Cultuses, the motorcycles carrying a father and a child who sits sideways on the

petrol tank because there is no room behind. The parents park where they can and walk their children to the gate and say goodbye with the particular expression of people who know exactly what this costs and are choosing to pay it anyway.

At the same time, one lane over, the government school opens its gate. No line of cars. Children on foot, most of them, from the streets nearby. Some of the younger ones are brought by older siblings. Their uniforms are the same color — white shalwar kameez — but the fabric is different, the shoes are different, the bags are different. These are the things that children notice. The things that adults pretend not to.

Khalil is a father who sends his twelve-year-old son, Tariq, to the government school. He is a carpenter who makes between eight and twelve thousand rupees a week depending on how much work comes in. He is not middle-class — not quite — but he lives near the middle class and watches it with an attention born from proximity and longing.

"That school over there," he says, gesturing at the private school gate. "My son's friend goes there. Same age, same street, different school. Already their English is different. Already they speak differently. In five years, when they are looking for jobs, my son will be competing with that boy and they will not be competing from the same place."

He says this without anger. Which is more devastating, somehow, than if he'd said it with anger. He says it the way you state a physical fact about the world — the sky is this color, the mountain is that height. He has accepted it. Which is not the same as being okay with it.

Tariq is a bright kid. His teacher, Nasreen — who has been teaching at this government school for seventeen years and whose salary has increased by eleven thousand rupees in that entire time — says he is one of the most naturally curious students she has taught. "He asks questions that make me think," she says. "Real questions. Not just the questions from the textbook."

She pauses. She is grading papers. Her desk is in a corner of the staffroom that she has claimed through longevity — the senior teacher's corner. On the wall beside her desk is a calendar from

two years ago that no one has replaced and a child's drawing, framed, from a student who graduated years back.

"The question is not whether Tariq is smart enough," she says. "The question is whether the system will give him enough time to show it."

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What Eleven to Fifteen Feels Like From the Inside

A child of this age in a middle-class Pakistani home is carrying more than adults tend to realize. The academic pressure is visible — the exam scores, the tutor fees, the Board exam looming like a verdict. The social pressure is visible — the clothes, the parties, the phones. But there is an interior life running beneath both of these that is harder to see and that shapes the person the child will become.

At night, in the hour before sleep, the middle-class child thinks about the future with an urgency that is not typical of childhood. He thinks: I need to do well in exams. I need to do well so I can get into a good college. I need to get into a good college so I can get a good job. I need a good job so I can help my parents. So I can not be a burden. So I can prove that the school fees and the tutor fees and the battery lamp and the repaired cricket bat and my father's face over the bills — that all of it was worth something.

This is a heavy set of thoughts for a thirteen-year-old. They are not the thoughts of a child, not really. They are the thoughts of someone who has already, in some essential way, begun to grow up.

In a household in Quetta where three children share one bedroom, the eldest — Nadia, thirteen — keeps a notebook under her pillow. Not a diary, exactly. More a list. Things she wants to do when she is older. Things she will buy her mother. Places she will go. She doesn't show it to anyone. It is private in the way that hope is private when it lives inside a constrained life — because if you show it to someone and they respond badly, or with pity, or with

the particular well-meaning cruelty of adults who say "realistic," it stops being hope and becomes something else.

So she keeps it under the pillow and she reads it sometimes before sleep, and it does what hope is supposed to do — it keeps you moving. It keeps the future feeling like something you are moving toward rather than something that is happening to you.

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What Is Built Here

The years between eleven and fifteen are brutal in a particular way that doesn't produce the kind of scars you can show someone. They produce a different kind: the early loss of lightness, the premature arrival of self-consciousness, the careful withdrawal from anything that might expose the gap between what you have and what the world around you seems to have.

But something is also built here. Something that is genuinely worth having, even if it arrives at too high a price.

These children learn to read situations before they enter them. They learn to plan — not just in the practical sense, but emotionally, socially. They learn the mechanics of delayed gratification not as a lesson from a book but as a daily lived experience. They learn that you can want something deeply and not have it and still be okay, still go to school, still sit at the dinner table, still laugh at the right moments.

This is not nothing. In a world that increasingly promises instant satisfaction — where the culture is organized around the idea that to want something is to deserve it immediately — the child who has learned to live inside the gap between wanting and having is carrying a kind of endurance that will serve them in ways they can't yet imagine.

Saad, sitting on his bed at twelve years old, having seen his father's unguarded face and deciding quietly to stop asking for extra things — he was absorbing something. Not just about money. About what it means to love people who are carrying things they don't show you. About how dignity operates. About the

difference between what you say you can handle and what you actually handle, every day, in private.

Amna, studying under her battery lamp with Chemistry notes and a tutor she knows was paid for at a cost she doesn't want to think about — she was learning something about commitment that has nothing to do with Chemistry and everything to do with who she will be in twenty years when her own life gets hard.

Nadia, with her notebook under the pillow, her handmade outfit, her practiced excuses for the parties she doesn't attend — she was learning something about interior life. About the necessity of keeping certain things private and sacred. About how hope functions when it doesn't have the luxury of being loud.

And Hassan, in Peshawar, shuffling sideways on his tile floor at night in his socks, practicing a cut shot that no coach is watching and no academy is developing — he was learning something about love. About what it means to love something for its own sake, without the apparatus of encouragement and reward that privilege provides. About doing the thing because the thing matters, not because anyone is applauding.

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The End of the Beginning

By the time the middle-class child reaches fifteen, they are already, in many of the ways that matter, formed. Not finished — nobody is finished at fifteen — but formed. The foundation is laid. The values are in place, even if they haven't been named. The strategies are developed. The interior life is running.

What comes next is harder. The decisions get larger. The costs get higher. The exams that seemed enormous at fourteen will look modest against what waits at sixteen, eighteen, twenty. The social pressure that felt unbearable around a classmate's shoes will seem gentle compared to the pressure of careers and marriages and choices that close off other choices.

But the children who make it through these foundation years with their ambition intact, their family's love received and

returned, their sense of self not fully shattered by the comparison machine — they go into the harder years with something. A ground to stand on that was built from small sacrifices and quiet endurance and the kind of love that gets expressed in polished shoes and battery lamps and repaired cricket bats and notebooks kept under pillows.

In Quetta, Nadia closes her notebook and puts it back under her pillow. In Lahore, Saad's mother packs his school bag quietly after he falls asleep. In Rawalpindi, Amna finishes the last problem in her Chemistry set and turns off the battery lamp and lies in the dark for a moment before sleep.

In Peshawar, Hassan puts down his invisible bat and goes to bed.

Tomorrow they all have school. The bus fare is ready. The shoes are polished. The notebooks are packed.

The foundation years are almost over. The harder ones are about to begin.

Chapter Three

When Education Ends Early

The Dropout and the One Who Refused

The morning a child stops going to school does not usually announce itself. There is no ceremony. No door slammed for the last time, no backpack hung up in a particular way that signals finality. It happens softly, the way most permanent things happen in poor and middle-class households — through a series of small compromises, each one sensible on its own, that add up to something that cannot be undone.

It might begin with a week missed because the family needs help during a crisis. Then two weeks, because the crisis hasn't resolved. Then a month, and by then the child has fallen so far behind in the syllabus that catching up seems harder than starting a new life. And then one morning the father says: you'll start again next year, when things are better. And both of them know, without either saying it, that next year is not coming.

Pakistan loses hundreds of thousands of children from education this way every year. Not all at once, not dramatically — just one morning at a time, one quiet goodbye at a time, one family that had no choice at a time.

This chapter is about what happens at that crossroads. About the children who are pulled out — and what becomes of them. About the families who make the decision with breaking hearts. And about the rare, stubborn ones who look at everything asking them to stop and simply refuse.

One of those rare ones grew up in Quetta. His name is Muzamil Khan. But before we get to him, we need to understand the world he was refusing.

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How the Decision Gets Made

Ask any parent who has pulled a child from school and they will not speak easily about it. There is a particular quality of shame that attaches to this decision — not entirely fair, given how often it is made under conditions of genuine desperation, but real nonetheless. The shame comes from knowing what education means. From having told the child, for years, that school is the path. From having believed it yourself. And then standing in front of that belief and being forced to set it aside.

In Quetta's Pashtoonabad neighborhood, there is a mechanic named Gul Rehman who pulled his eldest son from school when the boy was thirteen. His son, Wahid, had been in Class Eight. He was doing well — his teacher had written a note home once, in shaky Urdu, saying that Wahid had an exceptional grasp of mathematics and should be encouraged. Gul Rehman still has this note. It is folded into the back of the files he keeps by his bed.

The year Wahid left school, Gul Rehman's workshop had lost two major clients — both had moved to a newer garage on the main road with better equipment. The household income had dropped from around forty thousand rupees a month to sometimes twenty, sometimes less. There were four children. The eldest three were in school. The bills for books and fees and uniforms were, between the three of them, nearly twelve thousand rupees a month.

"I sat with my wife for three nights," Gul Rehman says. "Three nights. We kept trying to find another way. We went through everything. Every option. And there was no other way." He turns the tea glass in his hands slowly. "Wahid was the eldest. He understood. He didn't cry. He just nodded and he asked me what job he could do."

That last sentence — he just nodded and asked what job he could do — carries inside it an entire education in what it means to grow up middle-class in Pakistan. A thirteen-year-old boy, told his schooling is over, asks not why, not how this could happen, not what about his future. He asks: what job. He is already thinking practically. He is already rearranging himself around the new reality. He has absorbed, from every year of watching his father, that the correct response to a wall is not to shout at it but to find another route.

This is both the tragedy and the quiet dignity of the middle class. The practicality is real and it is admirable. And it costs something enormous.

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Lahore — Kamran's Roads

Kamran Hassan was nineteen when his life took the turn that almost ended it.

He had grown up in a one-room apartment in a working-class neighborhood of Lahore — the kind of neighborhood where four families share a courtyard and the water pressure drops to nothing after eight in the evening. His father had been sick for two years, the kind of sickness that takes a man slowly and expensively. His mother worked in a garment factory on a twelve-hour shift, six days a week, and came home with hands that smelled of chemical dye and a face that had forgotten how to be unworried.

Kamran had been in and out of three schools. The first one he was pulled from when he was eleven — the family couldn't manage the fees. The second he attended for two years before the family had to move. The third he was asked to leave after he had missed too many days helping at home during his father's worst periods of illness. By the time he was sixteen, he had dropped out entirely with an incomplete Class Eight education and no clear path forward.

What followed were three years that Kamran now describes simply as "when I got lost." Not dramatically — he is a measured speaker, precise with his words in the way of someone who has spent time thinking carefully about what happened and why. He did small jobs. Deliveries. Errands. Some of the people he worked for were not the kind of people a family in his position would have chosen for him. But families in his position do not always get to choose.

The deliveries became riskier. The money got better, briefly, which is how these things work — the money gets better exactly long enough to make you dependent before the risk catches up. It caught up with Kamran during a delivery that went wrong in a back street near Shahdara. He doesn't describe the details. He says: there were police, and there was the other side, and he was in the middle, and by some extraordinary luck he came out of it alive and uncaught but shaking so hard he had to sit in a doorway for an hour before he could walk.

He went home that night and sat in the dark of the one-room apartment and his mother was asleep and his father was in the hospital for that stretch and Kamran sat there alone for a long time thinking about the note his second school's teacher had written on his Class Six report card. He hadn't done anything with it when he'd seen it. But he had kept it. It was in the pocket of his old school bag. The note said: Kamran shows genuine ability. He should not give up on his education.

He found the note. He read it three times. He cried, which he says was the first time he had cried since he was twelve. Then he went to sleep.

The next week, through a connection at the mosque, he found out about a rehabilitation and vocational training program in the area — one of those community organizations that operates quietly and without fanfare, run by people who had themselves come from similar places and understood the specific geography of a young man who has been lost for a few years and is trying to find the road back.

The program gave him a skill — basic electrician work — and something else that he says was harder to name but more important: a structure. A reason to be somewhere at a specific

time. A set of people who expected him to show up. After three years of days that had no shape, this was not a small thing.

He is twenty-four now. He works as an electrician. He has his own small set of tools in a bag he bought himself. He earns between thirty and forty-five thousand rupees a month depending on how much work comes in. He is supporting his mother. His father died eighteen months ago. He is saving, slowly, to get a proper electrician's certification that will let him work on larger projects.

When I ask him what he would say to a younger version of himself — the fifteen-year-old who had just dropped out and was beginning to drift — he thinks for a long time.

"I would say: the road closes and you think that's it. But it doesn't close forever. There's always another road. You just have to still be alive to find it."

He says the last part quietly, without drama. Still be alive. He means it literally. He knows he was lucky. He knows most people who drift the way he drifted don't come out of it with a bag of tools and a plan. He carries that knowledge with him. It is part of why he goes to work every day.

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Back in Quetta — What Happened to Wahid

Wahid, Gul Rehman's son from Pashtoonabad, is now twenty-two. He has been working in his father's garage since he was thirteen. He is a skilled mechanic — his father says he has a feeling for engines that some men never develop, a sense of what a machine is doing that goes beyond what can be taught.

He is not unhappy. This is important to say, because the story of a boy who left school is not always a tragedy in the simple sense. He has income. He has work he is genuinely good at. He is engaged to a girl from the neighborhood and the wedding is being planned for next year. He is, by the measures available to him, building a life.

But Gul Rehman, his father, is not entirely at peace. He has a second son who is now fifteen and in Class Nine, still in school, and he is burning with a determination to keep this one enrolled that is almost frightening in its intensity. He took a loan this year to pay the fees. His wife said: we'll manage. He said: yes, we will.

"I think about Wahid," he says. "Not every day. But I think about him. He doesn't complain, so I can't complain for him. But sometimes I look at him under the car, his hands black with oil, and I think — what else could he have been? What did we not find out? What did the world lose, and what did he lose, because I couldn't hold on for two more years?"

He finishes his tea. He doesn't say anything else for a while. The fan above us turns slowly and the light in the garage is yellow and greasy and the engines of the cars lined up outside are quiet.

These are the questions that middle-class families carry. Not the loud ones. The quiet ones. The "what else." The "what if." The "I tried." The love that was not enough not because it wasn't real but because love does not pay school fees.

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Hanna Urak to Quetta — The Boy Who Refused

Muzamil Khan was born in 2004 in Hanna Urak, a valley that opens itself about twenty kilometers south of Quetta, where the mountains of Balochistan begin and the air is different — thinner, cleaner, carrying the smell of pine and rock. It is beautiful in the spring. In the other seasons it is cold and sparse and the roads can become uncertain.

His father was a clerk in the Social Welfare department. A government job — which in the calculus of middle-class Pakistani families is the equivalent of a fixed star, something to navigate by, not dazzling but reliable. His father was not a wealthy man. He was a working man with a salary and a small family and the modest, specific ambition of a man who wants to give his children a better start than he had.

The complication was the family itself.

Muzamil's father had been born from a different wife than his brothers. In a household governed by a strict patriarch and a set of rules about loyalty and blood that were old and rigid, this made him something adjacent to an outsider. The grandfather was a man who made decisions the way a judge pronounces sentences — finally, without revision. The uncles — eight sons from the second wife, a household within the household — had grown up with a different understanding of who belonged to the family's future. And Muzamil's father, the clerk who went to work every morning and came home to his small family and asked for nothing, had never been fully included in that future.

The conflict had been building for years, the way structural damage builds before a collapse — invisible from the outside, felt only in small signs that most people don't think to read. Then, when Muzamil was somewhere around ten or twelve — he was young enough that the exact age blurs in memory, which is itself a kind of mercy — the family made it formal. They were expelled from the house.

That word — expelled — is brutal when applied to a family. It means: you do not belong here anymore. Your presence in this space, which you believed was yours, has been revoked. Take your things and go.

They went first to relatives. This is where families go when their own family has closed a door — they knock on the next nearest door and they are let in because the people inside are decent, because culture demands it, because you cannot turn away a family with children. But they stayed with an awareness of their own precariousness, their own guest-status, that never fully lifted.

Then they moved to Quetta. The city. A place where nobody knew their history, which was both a relief and a kind of isolation.

Muzamil was a child through all of this. Children experience displacement differently from adults — they don't have the full vocabulary for what is happening, but they absorb the atmosphere of it completely. He absorbed the tension of the extended family's politics, the quiet shame of the relative's house, the particular unease of arriving in a city that doesn't know you yet and has not decided whether to accept you.

What he also absorbed was his father. A man who put on his clerk's clothes every morning and went to work. A man who, despite having been thrown out by his own family, despite the reduced income and the unfamiliar city and the wife and children who depended on him, did not collapse. He just kept going. Not heroically — there was nothing dramatic about it. He woke up and he went to work and he came home and he tried. Day after day.

Children notice this. More than we think.

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The Brother's Hands

Muzamil had an elder brother. The brother left school.

It happened the way it always happens — with practical necessity, without ceremony, without a conversation that felt like a conclusion because no one wanted to have the conversation that would make it a conclusion. The family needed income. The father's salary stretched only so far. The elder brother was old enough to work. And so he worked.

He was a child doing labor. Not in a factory with machinery — simpler than that, and somehow because of its simplicity more plain to see. The kind of work that is everywhere in Quetta's lower neighborhoods: loading, carrying, assisting, running. The kind of work that requires a body and a willingness and not much else, which means it pays accordingly.

Muzamil was younger. He could have used the brother's departure from school as permission for his own — as proof that this was what the family needed, that education was the luxury and work was the reality. Many boys in his position would have read it exactly that way.

He didn't.

Something in him had already decided. He couldn't have articulated it then — he was too young for articulation — but it was there, hardened and clear as the rock of the mountains he had grown up near. He was going to stay in school. Not because

anyone was pushing him. The world around him was, if anything, nudging him gently away. The finances were tight. His brother was out. The voice that says be practical was louder than usual.

He stayed anyway.

In Quetta's government schools, staying means something different from what it means in a private school in a comfortable neighborhood. It means showing up to classrooms with too many students and too few working fans and textbooks that are two editions behind. It means having teachers who are sometimes excellent and deeply committed and sometimes simply absent — not physically, but in the way a person can be present in a room while the light has gone out of them. It means doing homework in a house where there is no quiet corner reserved for you, where the evening has other demands, where your mother needs help and your father is tired and the space for being a student has to be claimed rather than assumed.

Muzamil claimed it. Every day he claimed it.

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The Language That Changed Everything

He finished his Matric. This alone, in the circumstances he was working within, was a non-trivial achievement. Plenty of boys from families in far more stable situations drop out before Class Ten. Muzamil sat his exams in a government school in Quetta, with the weight of the family's displacement and its financial strain as context, and he passed.

Then he decided to learn English.

This decision requires some context to understand fully. English in Pakistan is not simply a language. It is a gate. It is the thing that separates certain conversations from others, certain rooms from others, certain futures from others. In Balochistan — in Quetta specifically, a city with deep Pashto and Balochi roots where Urdu is the lingua franca of commerce and English is the language of advancement that many people can see but fewer can access — learning English well, truly well, is not a matter of

attending a few classes. It is a project. It is a commitment. It requires materials, time, discipline, and a particular kind of faith that the investment will pay off when you don't yet have any evidence that it will.

He found an English academy. He went alongside everything else — alongside the pressures at home, alongside the voices that told him to be practical, alongside the daily reality of a family that was still finding its footing in a city that had not yet fully accepted them. He was not on a scholarship. He was not sponsored. He went and he studied and he worked on himself with the same quiet, specific determination he had brought to everything else.

People told him to stop. Not enemies — people who cared about him. Family. Neighbors. The kind of well-meaning adults who look at a young man studying in circumstances that seem unpromising and say: bhai, be realistic. Your family needs money. You can earn. You can study later. The later never came for most of the people offering this advice, but they offered it sincerely.

He didn't argue with them. He just didn't listen. There is a difference. Arguing would have required energy and attention and would have disrupted the thing he was building inside himself. He learned to hear the advice and continue moving.

He advanced through the English courses. His English got good — then genuinely strong. And then the academy offered him something he had not expected: a position teaching English. He was young. He had no formal teaching degree. What he had was command of the language and a clarity of communication that the academy recognized as useful.

He started teaching.

This moment deserves to sit for a second. A boy who had been expelled from his ancestral home, who had watched his brother leave school to carry loads for money, who had been told repeatedly to give up, who had studied in government schools with broken fans and borrowed textbooks — he was now standing in a classroom teaching other people.

He was becoming stronger. Not metaphorically. Actually — in skill, in confidence, in the tangible sense that he was accumulating abilities that were his own and that no one could take from him the way a house can be taken, the way a family can close a door.

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The First Position

He completed his Intermediate. Then he applied to the University of Balochistan and took admission in BS Mass Communication and Media.

The university was not a small thing. The University of Balochistan is the largest public university in the province — a serious institution, with the weight and history and competition of a place that produces the province's engineers, doctors, lawyers, journalists. For a boy from Hanna Urak who had gone through government schools and taught himself English through sheer determination, sitting in those classrooms was both a destination and a beginning.

In his first semester, he secured first position with a 4.0 GPA.

Let that register. Not in the middle of the class. Not comfortably passing. First. Maximum grade. In a university where every student in his department had been working toward this entry for years, had tutors and resources and family support and in many cases the advantage of better schools than the ones Muzamil had attended — he came first.

There is something in this result that is not just about intelligence, though he is clearly intelligent. It is about the specific quality of attention that hardship builds in a person who refuses to be destroyed by it. When you have studied by fighting for the time and the space and the resources to study, you do not take a seat in a university classroom for granted. Every lecture is earned. Every exam is approached with a seriousness that is not anxiety but

focus — the focus of someone who has walked a long way to be in this room and is not going to waste the journey.

He was now in his fifth semester. Still first-class. Still building.

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Karachi — The Scholarship and the Stage

Then came UNICEF.

He was awarded a scholarship — a recognition from one of the world's most significant international organizations working on child welfare, youth development, and education. The selection is competitive. It is not given to the merely adequate. It goes to young people who have demonstrated both ability and, usually, something more specific: a life that gives them firsthand knowledge of the issues they will be working on.

Muzamil had that in abundance.

The scholarship took him to IBA — the Institute of Business Administration in Karachi. IBA is, without exaggeration, one of the most academically rigorous and socially elite institutions in Pakistan. Its graduates fill the country's corporate boardrooms, its diplomatic corps, its media leadership. Walking into IBA as a student or invited speaker is not something that happens to most people from Quetta's government schools.

He walked in. He delivered lectures. He spoke about the things he knew from having lived them: displacement, financial hardship, educational persistence, the specific texture of growing up middle-class in Balochistan in circumstances that pushed back. He spoke to rooms of students who had, many of them, grown up in circumstances of considerable advantage — and he was not intimidated. He had prepared for rooms like that, in the same way he had prepared for every other room that life had put him in: by knowing what he was talking about and trusting that.

He is not yet graduated. He is still in the middle of his degree. His plan, when he finishes, is to go abroad — to study

further, in a country that will give him resources and access that Pakistan's system, for all his love of it, has made him fight for every single step.

He is not running away. He is continuing. There is a difference, and Muzamil understands it clearly.

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What This Story Is and Is Not

Muzamil's story is remarkable. I want to be honest about that — it is not the average story. The average story of a middle-class child in Quetta who faces displacement and financial hardship and a family structure working against them does not end with a UNICEF scholarship and a lecture at IBA. The average story ends somewhere quieter and more contained. Maybe with a decent job found after difficulty. Maybe, like Wahid, with competent hands and a life that is livable but narrower than it might have been.

Muzamil's story is not the rule. But it is not a miracle either. It is the result of specific things: a father who modeled persistence, a personal refusal that was not naive but clear-eyed, a decision to keep going made daily for years in the face of everything saying stop. These are not things you are either born with or not. They are things that get built. Slowly, wrongly sometimes, then righted, then built again.

The reason his story belongs in this book — in this chapter, specifically, the chapter about when education ends — is because he is the proof of what education could be doing for every one of those boys and girls whose schooling stops. Not all of them would become Muzamil. But all of them had the same starting material: a mind, a family that loved them, a country that needed them. What they lacked was not the raw material. What they lacked was time and space and money and the structural support to keep going.

This is the real tragedy of the dropout. Not that they couldn't have made it. That the system couldn't hold them long enough to find out.

Karachi — Zara's Machines and Her Evening Books

Zara was thirteen years old when she sat at a sewing machine for the first time professionally. Not her mother's machine at home, the one she had learned on — a proper industrial machine in a small garment workshop in Orangi Town, Karachi, a machine that ran faster than anything she had touched before and that required a specific, sustained physical attention to operate correctly.

She was the eldest of five children. Her father was a daily wage laborer. The family's income was not reliable — it was the kind that fluctuated with weather and work availability and the state of the local economy. When Zara left school, it was not a decision made in a single conversation. It was the slow accumulation of all the months when the money had been tight, when the school fees had been stretched to breaking point, when one more child working meant one more week's food.

The workshop paid her three thousand rupees a week. It was not enough for a person. It was enough for a girl, in the calculus of informal labor. She worked eight-hour shifts. She came home with hands that ached and a neck that had developed a persistent stiffness from looking down at the fabric.

But she was still learning to read. She had not stopped.

There was a community center three streets away — one of those organizations that operates without glamour, funded partly by a foreign NGO and partly by the donations of people from the neighborhood who had done slightly better and wanted to hold a door open. It offered evening classes for working youth: basic literacy and numeracy, a condensed secondary curriculum, and what the organizers called life skills, which was their way of saying: the things school was supposed to give you but didn't or couldn't.

Zara went three evenings a week after her shift. She was exhausted. Her hands hurt. She sat in the plastic chair in the small room and she opened the books and she studied. Other girls from

the workshop came too, sometimes — the ones whose families allowed it, the ones who could manage the hours. On the evenings she went alone she didn't mind. She had learned, at thirteen, that doing the right thing for yourself is often a solitary activity.

Four years later, she completed her secondary education through the community program. A scholarship for working youth allowed her to enroll in a vocational training course in digital marketing — a skill that did not exist as a formal profession when her mother was her age, that the garment workshop could never have given her access to. She took to it with the same focused practicality she had brought to the sewing machine and the evening classes and everything else.

She works now in a small digital agency in Karachi. She earns thirty-five thousand rupees a month. Her younger siblings are in school. She pays part of their fees. Her mother still asks her sometimes if she is tired — she can see it in Zara's face at the end of certain weeks — and Zara always says: a little, Ammi. Just a little.

She says it honestly. She is a little tired. She has been a little tired since she was thirteen. But it is the tiredness of someone who has been building something, and that has a different quality from the tiredness of someone who is just enduring.

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The System That Makes This Normal

We should be angry about this. I want to say that clearly before the chapter ends, because there is a risk in writing about resilience and individual determination — the risk of making the system's failure sound acceptable, even beautiful. It is not.

Wahid's father spent three nights trying to find another way. Kamran drifted for three years into situations that almost killed him. Zara sat at an industrial sewing machine at thirteen with hands that ached. Muzamil had to fight for every piece of ground that should have been given to him — not as charity, but as

a right, the basic right of a child in a country to be educated without having to be extraordinary to deserve it.

None of these stories should have required the level of personal determination they required. The government school that serves Wahid's neighborhood should have been good enough to make his future feel worth staying for. Kamran should have had a support structure that caught him before he drifted, not after. Zara's school should not have been a financial burden her family could not sustain. Muzamil should not have had to outperform every disadvantage the system placed in his path in order to reach the same rooms that students with money and connections walk into as a matter of course.

The fact that some of them made it — that Muzamil stands in front of audiences at IBA, that Zara pays her siblings' school fees, that Kamran has a bag of tools and a plan — is a testament to them. Not to the system. The system failed all of them. They refused to fail with it.

That distinction matters. The resilience of individuals should never be used to let a broken system off the hook. The middle class produces people who are good at surviving inadequate circumstances. That doesn't mean the circumstances are acceptable.

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The Road That Stays Open

Kamran said: the road closes and you think that's it. But it doesn't close forever. There's always another road. You just have to still be alive to find it.

This is true. And it is not enough. "Still be alive to find it" is too low a bar for a country to set for its children.

But until the bar is raised — until the system is rebuilt to hold every child rather than only the extraordinary ones — we work with what we have. We tell the stories. We look at the Muzamils and the Zaras and the Kamrans who found roads back

and we say: see. See what a child can do when someone, or something, or just their own stubborn refusal, keeps them moving.

In Quetta, in Lahore, in Karachi, in Orangi Town and Pashtoonabad and Hanna Urak, the story continues. Children go to school and come home with notebooks. Fathers fold teacher's notes. Boys stand at industrial sewing machines because the family needs it and read in the evening because they refuse to let the machine be all they are.

And in a university in Balochistan, a young man from a valley twenty kilometers outside Quetta is finishing his degree. First position. UNICEF scholar. A boy who was displaced, whose brother left school, who was told to be practical, who refused.

He is still refusing, in the best possible sense. He is still moving.

The chapter ends here. The road doesn't.

Chapter Four

The Pressure Years

Sixteen to Twenty

By sixteen, the middle-class child has already completed two educations. The first is the official one — the syllabus, the exams, the Board results. The second is the one that runs parallel and silent beneath it, funded not by school fees but by attention and proximity: an education in what his family can afford, what they cannot, what they are hoping for, and what it will cost them if he fails.

Both educations have been building toward this moment. The moment when the question of what comes next stops being abstract and becomes urgent. When the next five years stop being childhood's extension and start being the runway on which the rest of the life will either lift off or run out of road.

Between sixteen and twenty, the middle-class young person in Pakistan lives under a specific kind of pressure that has no clean name. It is not poverty — they have food and shelter and love. It is not wealth — they have none of the cushions that make mistakes reversible. It is the pressure of the middle position: high enough up the slope that falling is genuinely terrible, and not high enough that there is any margin for error.

The family's hopes are explicit. The path is narrow. Engineering, medicine, the civil service. These are the three doors that a middle-class Pakistani family of a certain generation understands, and if you don't go through one of them, you have some explaining to do. Not because the parents are cruel — they are not. Because they are afraid. Because they have spent sixteen

years investing everything they have into this child and they do not have the vocabulary for a future that doesn't look like the futures they were told to believe in.

This chapter is about those years and what they do to a person. The academic grind. The career decision made under pressure that will shape decades. The silence in which mental health struggles are buried because there is no space to set them down. And the night — somewhere in these years, for many young men in particular — when the body says: I cannot carry this anymore. When the chest tightens and the heart races and the room contracts and everything that has been stored up for years arrives all at once, without warning, with nowhere to go.

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The Race That Nobody Chose to Enter

The first thing you need to understand about this period is the sheer volume of it.

A student sitting his Intermediate exams in Pakistan is not simply taking tests. He is sitting the cumulative exam of his family's last sixteen years of sacrifice. Every tuition fee, every repaired school uniform, every meal that was simpler than it could have been so the school fees could be paid — all of it arrives at the exam hall with him. The invigilator calls time, and the boy sits down, and somewhere behind his eyes the entire weight of the household's investment is pressing forward.

In Rawalpindi, there is a coaching center on a main road that runs FSc preparation classes. It opens at seven in the morning and closes at nine at night. The boys who come here — and it is mostly boys, though some girls too — have typically already attended their regular college in the morning and come here in the afternoon for the additional preparation that everyone in their social world has agreed is necessary. They are seventeen years old and they are in their second school of the day.

One of the instructors at this center, a man named Azhar who has been teaching Chemistry for eleven years, says he can

identify within the first two weeks which students are there because they want to be and which are there because their parents have decided for them.

"The ones who are there because of pressure — they sit differently," he says. "Not badly, not lazily. But with a kind of heaviness. Like they are carrying the chair. The ones who actually love Chemistry, or at least find it interesting, they lean forward. Small difference. But I see it every year."

The heaviness he describes is the weight of a decision that has not yet been made but is already closing around the student like a room growing smaller. Engineering or medicine. Medicine or engineering. Or the third option, chartered accountancy, which gets less prestige than the first two but is viewed as practical in a way that arts, humanities, or social sciences are not — fields that families say you can study "later" with the same comfortable vagueness with which they say the cricket can wait.

Seventeen-year-old Usman, in Lahore, wanted to study journalism. He had been writing since he was fourteen — not school essays, real writing, observations and stories about the neighborhood, about his relatives, about the things he saw at the bus stop every morning. His writing teacher in Class Eleven had told him, privately, that he had a voice. That the writing was good. That he should keep going.

He told his father he wanted to study mass communication.

His father, a bank manager who had worked his way up from a clerk over twenty-five years, listened carefully. Then he said: beta, mass communication doesn't pay. Not at first. And we don't have the years to wait for it to pay. His tone was not dismissive. It was the tone of a man explaining a mathematical reality, the way you explain that a bridge won't hold a certain weight — not with cruelty, but with the gravity of something that is simply true.

Usman enrolled in pre-engineering. He was not unhappy exactly. He was practical — the same practicality that the middle class breeds in its children as reliably as it breeds resourcefulness and quiet endurance. He did his degree. He got a job. His writing notebooks are in a drawer.

He doesn't open the drawer much now. He is twenty-eight, and the days are full.

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Quetta — The Son Who Said Yes to Everything

Shahid Mengal is twenty years old and in his second year of pre-medical in Quetta. He is studying to be a doctor. He has always been studying to be a doctor, in the sense that this was decided before he had developed a strong personal opinion about it. It was decided the way many things are decided in middle-class Pakistani families — by accretion, by the slow build-up of expectation until it has the force of fact.

His father is a pharmacist who owns a small shop in Quetta's Liaquat Bazaar. His mother was a schoolteacher who left work after Shahid's younger sister was born. The family is middle-class in the specific, particular way of families that are one bad year away from not being middle-class — the shop's income fluctuates, the rent went up last year, there are two children in private schools whose fees together take up a third of the monthly income.

Shahid is the family's plan. Not cruelly, not consciously, but completely. The plan is: Shahid becomes a doctor. A doctor earns. A doctor has respect. A doctor can, in fifteen years, anchor the family in the economic zone where they will not spend every month doing the arithmetic of adequacy.

He is a good student. He has always been a good student — methodical, careful, excellent at memorization, which is what pre-medical in Pakistan largely demands. He is not passionate about medicine. He does not lie awake thinking about physiology. He does not read medical journals for pleasure. But he does his work, and he does it well, and he has never said to anyone in his family that there is something else he would rather be doing.

What he would rather be doing is architecture. He discovered this at seventeen when his uncle's house was being extended and the architect came to discuss the drawings. Shahid

sat in the corner of the room watching the man talk about structure and load and light, watching the way he moved his pencil across the paper to explain a concept, and felt something in himself lean forward the way Azhar the Chemistry teacher describes — the real interest, the involuntary kind.

He never said this to his parents. He calculated, with the same precision he applied to his Biology practicals, that saying it would cause more pain than keeping it quiet. His parents had already told their extended family that their son was becoming a doctor. His mother had already incorporated it into her prayers. His father had already started planning, in the back of his mind, the trajectory: degree, house job, specialization, clinic.

To say: actually, I want to draw buildings — this would not just be a career change. It would be a kind of demolition.

So Shahid studies medicine. And at night, sometimes, he draws. Small sketches in the margins of his anatomy notebook. Floor plans of houses he invents. The proportions of imagined rooms. He is precise about it — the measurements are always thought through.

Nobody sees these drawings. He makes sure of that.

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Lahore — When the Daughter Pushes Back

Amira Hassan was the first person in her family to say no.

She was eighteen, and her family had assumed — with the confidence of people who have never had to examine an assumption — that she would study medicine. Her older brother was in his third year of MBBS. Her mother was a schoolteacher who had quietly planned this outcome since Amira was in Class Eight and started excelling in Biology. Her father, a civil servant, had not explicitly demanded medicine but had praised it in the consistent, specific way that amounts to the same thing.

Amira wanted to build a technology company. Not in an abstract, youthful, I-want-to-be-an-entrepreneur way. In a

specific, researched, thoroughly thought-through way. She had been building small software tools since she was fifteen. She had read about women in technology. She had a specific idea — an educational platform, a way of making tutoring accessible to students in smaller cities who couldn't afford the coaching centers that students in Lahore and Karachi took for granted. She had written six pages of notes about it.

She showed the notes to her father one Sunday evening after dinner.

He read them carefully. He turned the pages slowly. He is not a stupid man — he is thoughtful and he loves his daughter — and so he read everything before he spoke.

Then he said: Amira, beta, this is very good thinking. But a company takes years. It needs investment. It needs connections. What will you do in the years before it works? Who will support you?

She said: I will support myself. I'll freelance. I'll build it on the side while I work.

He said: medicine is a guarantee. Technology is a hope.

She said: medicine is a guarantee for you. I want to build the hope.

The conversation that followed lasted three weeks. Not continuously — it surfaced and submerged in the way that family arguments do, appearing at dinner, disappearing for two days, returning during a car journey, going quiet again when her mother got a headache. It involved aunts, which made it worse. Aunts who said: Amira, think about your future. Think about what a doctor-daughter means for this family. Think about a good rishta.

Amira did not win the argument. Nobody exactly won it. What happened was something more Pakistani — a negotiation, a compromise that preserved everyone's dignity without fully satisfying anyone. She enrolled in a computer science degree rather than medicine. Her father accepted this on the condition that she also prepared for the CSS exams as a backup — a civil

service career, which in his understanding was the other form of guaranteed security.

She agreed. She started the CS degree. She never prepared for CSS.

She is twenty-four now. The company she imagined at eighteen exists — not exactly as she drew it on those six pages, but recognizably descended from that idea. It has three employees, including her. It is not yet profitable, not in the way that gives a father full peace of mind. But it is real. It is hers. And when she sits with her laptop in the morning and opens the code she was working on the night before, she has none of the heaviness that Azhar the Chemistry teacher sees in the students carrying chairs.

Her father has stopped mentioning CSS. He brought clients to her recently — two school principals from his district who needed a digital platform for student management. He didn't announce this as a concession. He just forwarded their contact numbers with a one-line text: these people need what you do.

That one-line text was the closest thing to an apology and a blessing that Amira was going to get from a man of his generation. She understood this. She saved the text.

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Karachi — The Night of the Dinner Table

Imran Ahmed was nineteen years old, second year of engineering at a private university in Karachi, eldest son of a government employee, when everything arrived at once.

The signs had been building for months, the way a wall develops a crack — small at first, dismissible, the kind of thing you tell yourself is nothing. He had started sleeping badly in October, three months into his first year. Not insomnia exactly — he could fall asleep, but he woke at two or three in the morning with a chest that felt wrong, a tightness that he told himself was from lying in the wrong position and tried to ignore by rolling over.

By January he was waking every night. The headaches came around the same time — persistent, low-grade, the kind that live behind the eyes and color everything slightly wrong. He told his mother he thought it was screen time. She agreed and told him to take breaks from the laptop, and he said he would, and he didn't, because the assignments were due and the exams were coming and there was no place in the schedule to insert a break.

His grades were still good. This is the thing about high-functioning anxiety — it often coexists with apparent performance, at least for a while. The work gets done. The exams are sat. The scores are maintained. The cost of maintaining them is invisible from the outside.

He had stopped going to his friend Bilal's house on Friday evenings — their habit since school, five or six boys sitting on the roof talking and eating and being young in the uncomplicated way you can be young in a friend's house. He stopped because the thought of the bus ride, the social energy of the evening, the journey home after dark — it all felt, in his body, like more than he could do. He told Bilal his parents needed him on Fridays. Bilal believed him.

By March he had lost four kilos without trying. His mother noticed and mentioned it twice. He said he'd been busy. She cooked extra portions and placed them in front of him and watched him eat and said nothing more, but her watching had a quality to it that he recognized and that made him, for reasons he couldn't fully explain, feel worse.

The night of the dinner table was a Thursday in April.

It was an ordinary dinner. His father home at the usual time, the usual news on television in the background, his younger sister talking about something that had happened at school. His mother had made daal and chapati and a salad. Nothing different. Nothing that should have been the last straw, except that he was already holding so much that there was no room left.

His father said, during a pause in the conversation: Imran, have you thought about which specialization you want to do after graduation? The good electrical engineering programs fill up fast.

It was not an unreasonable question. His father was being attentive, thinking ahead, doing what fathers do when they are trying to be helpful. He was not applying pressure in any exceptional way. He was asking the kind of thing that gets asked at dinner tables across Pakistan every evening.

But something in Imran's chest locked. Not gradually — instantly, like a door slamming. The air in the room, which had been normal a second before, became wrong. Not thin, not hot — just wrong, in a way he could not describe except by saying it didn't feel like air anymore. His heart began to move at a speed that was wrong too, too fast, disconnected from any physical exertion. His hands went cold. The light in the room seemed to flatten.

He stood up from the table. He said: excuse me. He walked to the bathroom and locked the door and sat on the edge of the bathtub and put his head between his knees.

His family didn't know what was happening. He could hear them through the door — his mother saying his name, his sister quieter than usual, his father's chair scraping back. His mother knocked once, gently. He said: I'm fine. I'll be out in a minute.

He sat on that bathtub edge for twenty-two minutes. He counted them on his watch. The feeling did not go away cleanly — it receded in stages, like water draining slowly. By the time he came back to the table, something was over. Not just the dinner. Something larger.

He couldn't pretend anymore.

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The Long Days After

His father's first response was, as these things go, predictable. Not cruel — his father was not a cruel man — but shaped by a generation's understanding that psychological difficulty is a matter of willpower. Imran needed to be firmer with himself. To focus. To remember why he was working this hard and

what it was for. His father had worked through difficulties too. Everyone had difficulties.

His mother was different. She had watched him for months with that specific watching that mothers do and she had understood, before the dinner table, that something was wrong in a way that was not about willpower. She said nothing against the father's prescription. But she found, through a colleague at her school, the name of a counselor at a mental health clinic in Clifton that operated on a sliding scale — meaning the cost adjusted to what you could pay.

She told Imran about the counselor in the kitchen one morning, early, before anyone else was awake. She didn't present it as a solution to a problem. She presented it as a thing she had found that he might want to look at. The distinction mattered.

He went. Not easily — the first appointment required an effort of will that exhausted him before he arrived, the effort of believing that going was not an admission of weakness, not a betrayal of his family's investment in him, not a sign that he could not handle what was expected. He sat in the waiting room of the clinic for ten minutes before his appointment wondering if he could leave without anyone noticing.

He didn't leave.

The counselor, a woman in her forties who spoke to him in a mixture of Urdu and English and who did not, crucially, treat him like a problem to be solved, helped him understand over the course of several sessions what had been happening. The anxiety had been building since at least his second year of school, probably earlier — a pattern of high performance sustained at the cost of an interior life that was never allowed to surface, in a household where love was abundant but the space to be anything less than capable was narrow.

He was not broken. He had been carrying too much for too long with nowhere to set it down. These are different conditions, even if they feel the same from the inside.

His father came around slowly. Not through argument but through proximity — through watching his son over the months

after the dinner table, seeing the gradual return of something he had not noticed was gone until it returned. The ease in the morning. The occasional laugh at a television show. The willingness to sit at the dinner table without that quality of coiled tension that, looking back, had been there for a year.

His father never said: I was wrong. He said, six months later, while they were sitting together watching cricket: you look better. That was the full sentence. You look better. But the way he said it — the weight he gave the two words — was his version of something longer.

Imran understood. He said: I feel better. And it was true.

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The Silence Around Mental Health

Imran's story is not rare. It is, in fact, so common that its commonness is part of the problem — the very ordinariness of the middle-class pressure-cooker means that the signs are easy to dismiss as simply what this age looks like, what this life looks like, what it costs to become something.

In Quetta, a psychiatrist named Dr. Khalida Naseem who operates a small private practice describes the patients she sees in their late teens and early twenties as falling into two categories. The first are the ones who come voluntarily, usually pushed by a single event they could not manage — an exam failure, a relationship ending, a panic attack. The second are the ones brought by a parent or sibling who noticed something long after it started and is frightened enough to override the cultural script that says this is private, this is weakness, this is not the kind of thing you go to a doctor for.

"The majority of the people I treat for anxiety or depression in this age group have been managing it alone for between one and three years before anyone brings them in," she says. She is sitting in a small office with pale blue walls and a plant on the windowsill that is real and alive and well-tended. "Three years is a long time to manage something alone. Three years is long enough for a

person to reorganize their entire life around avoiding the thing that frightens them, which means when they come to me the problem is not just the anxiety — it is all the habits built to contain it."

She pauses. "The cultural piece is real. I don't want to be dismissive of it. These families love their children. The silence around mental health is not indifference — it is a different belief system about what strength means and where difficulty should be carried. Understanding that doesn't make it less damaging, but it changes what the work looks like."

The work, in her understanding, involves both the patient and the family. Because in the Pakistani middle-class context, the pressure does not exist in isolation — it exists inside a web of relationships, expectations, and love. The father who says pull yourself together is not the villain of the story. He is a man who was told the same thing by his own father and who survived it and who believes, with genuine care, that this is how difficulty is meant to be handled.

Changing that belief system takes time. But Dr. Naseem, who has been doing this work for fourteen years in Quetta, says it can be changed. "Families are more willing than people think," she says. "Once they understand what is actually happening — not weakness, not failure, but a body and mind under sustained pressure that needs support — most parents want to help. They just needed someone to give them the framework."

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Quetta — Omar and the CSS Form He Didn't Submit

Omar Kakar was twenty and in his final year of BSc when his father handed him the CSS application form across the breakfast table.

The CSS — the Central Superior Services exam — is the examination through which Pakistan recruits its civil service officers. The most prestigious career pathway in the country for those who believe in public institutions, it also represents, to a

certain generation of middle-class Pakistani fathers, the peak of what a son can become. An officer. A person with power, with respect, with the word Sahib permanently available for attachment to his name.

His father had been building toward this moment for years without saying so explicitly. The way he talked about government officers when they appeared on television. The way he described his own colleagues in the bureaucracy with a particular reverence. The way he had, over the past year, started mentioning casually that Omar's grades were good, that his English was strong, that he had the kind of disciplined mind the CSS needed.

Omar took the form. He said he would fill it out. He put it in his room.

The form sat on his desk for three weeks. He looked at it every morning when he opened his laptop. He opened it once and read the first page and closed it again. He didn't know how to explain to himself, let alone to his father, the feeling that arrived every time he looked at it — a feeling not of fear exactly, but of wrongness. Of this-is-not-the-direction.

What Omar wanted to do was teach. Not at a university — at a school. Secondary school, specifically, the age group between fourteen and seventeen that he felt, based on nothing more scientific than a profound personal instinct, was the most important and the most ignored. He had been tutoring since he was eighteen, neighborhood children in the evenings, and he had discovered that this was the thing — the actual, specific thing — that made him feel present in the world in a way that other activities didn't.

Teaching was not, in his father's vocabulary, a destination. It was something women did when they couldn't find anything else, or what men did on the side when the real job wasn't enough. It was not what you worked toward CSS-level grades to do.

Omar did not submit the CSS form. He told his father, after three weeks, that he had missed the deadline. His father was disappointed in a way that he expressed through silence rather than words, which Omar found harder to navigate. The silence

lasted, with occasional interruptions for ordinary domestic communication, for about two months.

Then Omar passed his final exams with distinction and was offered a teaching position at a school in Quetta's Jinnah Town — a private school, decent pay for a new teacher, proper work. He told his father. His father looked at him for a long moment and said: are you sure?

Omar said: yes.

His father nodded. He didn't say anything else. But at dinner that evening he told Omar's mother what had happened, and his tone — not warm exactly, but no longer the silence — told Omar something had shifted.

He has been teaching for two years now. His students know that he will not give up on them. The school principal told him last year that his Class Nine students had the highest average improvement in English from September to June that the school had recorded in five years. Omar printed out the principal's email. It is the only piece of paper on his bedroom wall.

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The Father in the Room

This chapter keeps returning to fathers because fathers, in the Pakistani middle-class story of these years, occupy a specific and complicated position that is worth naming directly.

The middle-class father of a sixteen-to-twenty-year-old is, in many cases, a man in his mid-forties or early fifties who has spent twenty-five years doing the right things — working, saving, not wasting, providing. He has, through significant personal sacrifice, brought his family to the position they are in. He has maintained their dignity. He has kept them in the middle, which is harder than it sounds and which he is acutely aware of every month when the salary arrives and the bills are calculated.

He loves his child with a completeness that he does not know how to express fully, and this unexpressed love tends to flow

through the channel of ambition — I want more for you than I had, I want your future to be secure in ways mine never was, I want the twenty-five years of careful living to have meant something. The career expectations are not about control. They are about the only vocabulary he has for love under pressure.

But his child is a different person in a different world, and the career map that made sense in his generation has shifted substantially. Engineering still employs people, but the field has changed. Medicine is still respected, but the path is longer and the personal cost higher than it was. The civil service is still powerful, but its culture has not kept pace with the expectations of a generation that grew up watching the world online.

The collision between the father's map and the child's territory is the defining conflict of these years. It is not malicious on either side. It is the collision of two genuine loves — the parent's love for security, the child's love for self-determination — that don't yet have a common language.

The fathers who find a way through this collision — Amira's father texting her the school principals' contact numbers, Omar's father sitting in silence and then showing up for dinner — are not capitulating. They are learning. Slowly, imperfectly, at the pace of men who were not raised to be flexible but are trying to be anyway because their child's happiness matters more than their own certainty.

That effort is not nothing. It deserves to be named.

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What This Period Actually Asks For

Sixteen to twenty asks the middle-class young person in Pakistan for almost everything, at a time when almost everything has not yet fully formed.

It asks for academic performance at a level that will determine college admission, which will determine career options, which will determine income, which will determine whether the family's investment was worth it — a chain of causation so long

and so loaded that sitting down to study for an exam can feel like bearing the weight of every link in it simultaneously.

It asks for a career decision to be made with full commitment at seventeen or eighteen, when most people in the world who have the luxury to wait don't fully understand what they want until their mid-twenties. The middle class doesn't have the luxury to wait, which means its children are often locked into paths before they have lived enough to know whether the path fits.

It asks for emotional stability while providing almost no support for emotional instability. The mental health infrastructure for this age group in Pakistan — in Quetta, in Lahore, in small cities across the country — is thin. The cultural framework treats psychological struggle as weakness. The family, which loves the child, is also the source of much of the pressure the child is struggling under. There is nowhere obvious to put the weight down.

And it asks all of this at the same time. Not sequentially — simultaneously. Exam stress and career confusion and family expectation and the beginning of romantic feelings that can't be talked about and the first real confrontation with what adulthood is going to cost — all of it, at once, in the body of a person who is still, technically, a child.

The ones who make it through these years intact are not the toughest or the most disciplined or even the most talented. They are usually the ones who had at least one adult — a parent, a teacher, a counselor, sometimes just an older cousin — who noticed the weight and helped them set some of it down. Not carry it for them. Just helped them see that setting it down was allowed.

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The Other Side

Imran is in his final year of engineering now. He still sees the counselor once a month — not because he is in crisis, but because the maintenance turned out to be worth more than he expected. He has chosen a specialization, not based on which one

will pay the most but on which one he found himself reading about voluntarily on a Thursday evening when he had nothing due. It is a modest-sounding basis for a life decision. It is also the truest one available to him.

Shahid is still drawing floor plans in the margins of his anatomy notebook. He tells himself that after his MBBS he will find a way to incorporate architecture into his life somehow — hospital design, perhaps. Whether this becomes real or whether it stays in the margins is a question the future will answer. He is not unhappy. He is a little bit somewhere else, always. But he is managing.

Amira's company has its third client now. She sent her father the email confirming the contract. He replied with a thumbs-up emoji, which is not the most expansive form of praise but from him carries considerable weight.

Omar is teaching Class Nine English in Quetta and his students know that he will give them his full attention for the hour they are in his classroom. The CSS form that he didn't submit is still, technically, on his desk. He has not thrown it away. He doesn't know why. Perhaps because throwing it away would feel like closing a door, and he is not yet ready to close anything. He is twenty-two. The doors can stay open a while longer.

These are the pressure years. They are hard. They are not, in the end, the worst years — the worst years have a way of being the ones that come later, when the consequences of these decisions become clear. But they are the years that shape the direction of everything. They deserve to be taken seriously, handled carefully, and — occasionally — questioned out loud, at the dinner table, even if the conversation that follows lasts three weeks.

The question is worth asking. The answer, whatever it is, is worth giving the time to find.

The Weight of Expectations

What Fathers Cannot Say and Sons Cannot Ask

There is a conversation that has never happened in thousands of middle-class Pakistani households. It is not a conversation that was prevented by cruelty or indifference. It was prevented by love — by the specific, constrained, pressure-formed love of a father who worked his whole life to give his son something and a son who spent his whole life trying not to waste it.

The conversation would go something like this. The father would say: I am afraid. Not of you, not for you exactly — but of the gap between what I have given you and what the world will ask of you, and whether what I have given is enough, and whether the things I could not give — the connections, the ease, the cushion that makes mistakes survivable — will cost you in ways I cannot protect you from.

And the son would say: I know. I have always known. I saw it in your face at the dining table when the salary slip was out. I saw it in the way you held yourself at school functions, precise and proud, making sure nothing showed. I saw it in every early morning and every late evening and every birthday that was smaller than you wanted it to be and every time you said later in the voice that meant I wish I could say yes.

Neither of them says these things. The father says: how are the studies? The son says: fine. The father says: work hard. The son says: I will. And both of them mean the longer thing, and both of them know that the longer thing is being said, and neither of them finds a way to say it in words. Because in the middle-class Pakistani household, between a father and a son, the language for this does not exist in any form that either of them was taught to use.

This chapter is about that gap. About what lives in it. And about what happens to both of them when it is never crossed.

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Lahore — The Forty Years and the Twenty

Khalid Mehmood had been working for forty years. He said this not as a boast — he was not a man who boasted — but as a statement of fact, the way you state the dimensions of a room you have lived in long enough to know precisely. Forty years. He had started at twenty-two as a junior clerk in a textile company. He was now sixty-two and the head of the accounts department of a different textile company, having moved twice in four decades, both times for salary rather than ambition because ambition, in his understanding, was a luxury that men with families and fixed expenses could not afford to indulge at the cost of stability.

He had a son. Danish, twenty-three, finishing his final year of an engineering degree at a private university in Lahore. Danish was — and Khalid said this with a care that suggested he had spent time considering the exact word — capable. Not brilliant, not exceptional in the way that produces prodigies, but capable in the deeper and more durable sense: hardworking, honest, the kind of person who finishes what he starts even when finishing is uncomfortable. Khalid was proud of this. He was proud of it in the private way of fathers who have learned not to say these things directly because the saying of them produces in the son an expectation and in the father a vulnerability that neither of them knows what to do with.

They lived in the same house. Had lived in the same house for twenty-three years. Shared a dinner table every evening when Khalid was home at a reasonable hour, which was most evenings because Khalid had understood early in his working life that the office would always have more to offer if you stayed later and that the house had a finite and irreplaceable supply of the evenings he had not yet missed.

In twenty-three years of shared dinner tables, Khalid and Danish had never had a conversation about what Khalid was afraid of.

This is not unusual. It is, in fact, so common as to be the norm. The Pakistani middle-class father and his son exist in a relationship that is structured almost entirely around the future — around the preparation for it, the investment in it, the anxiety about whether it will arrive in the form it was planned for. The present — the feeling of the present, what it is like to be inside it, what it costs and what it gives — is not the primary subject. The primary subject is always the next thing. The exam, the grade, the university, the job, the marriage. The present is a corridor. You move through it. You do not stop to describe it.

Danish understood this. He had grown up inside it. He had learned to orient himself toward the future the way a plant orients toward light — naturally, continuously, without being asked. He studied because the studying was the corridor. He performed because the performance was the corridor. And when he felt, in the second year of his degree, that the corridor was too narrow — that he was pressing against its walls in ways that were beginning to show in his sleep and his appetite and the quality of his attention — he did not mention this to his father.

He managed it alone. The way the corridor taught him to manage everything.

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The Architecture of a Father's Fear

What Khalid Mehmood carried, in the forty years, was not only financial. The financial was the visible part — the salary, the budget, the school fees, the decision to not change jobs when a riskier move might have meant more money but might also have meant a period without income during which the household would have had to be told something he didn't want to tell it. These were real calculations, made carefully, over decades, and the choosing of stability over ambition was not cowardice. It was love expressed as risk management.

But underneath the financial carrying was another carrying that had no line in the household budget and no entry in the accounts ledger that Khalid maintained with such precision. It was the carrying of a question that arrived sometime in Danish's early teenage years and had not left since: have I given him enough of the right things?

The right things were not money. Khalid understood this, even if he could not always act on the understanding. The right things were the things money cannot purchase — confidence that is not contingent on performance, the ability to fail without it feeling like the collapse of everything, a relationship with risk that does not default to paralysis. These were things that a life of managed stability, however loving, does not automatically produce. A father who never took risks in front of his son — who always appeared to have the situation under control, who never showed the fear — produces a son who may not know that fear is manageable. Who may not know that you can be afraid and go forward anyway, because he has never seen his father do it.

Khalid had never shown Danish the fear. He had shown Danish the management of the fear. He thought these were the same thing. They are not.

He is not unique in this. The middle-class Pakistani father as a type — the man who has worked without stop, who has provided without complaint, who has shown up every morning with the salary and the stability and the school fees paid — this father has, in many cases, given his son everything except the sight of his own interior life. And the interior life is what the son needs most. Not to be protected from it. To see it. To understand that the man who appears to have things under control is also, sometimes, not sure. That uncertainty is not a character flaw but a condition of being human. That it is possible to carry things you are not sure you can carry and discover, in the carrying, that you can.

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Karachi — What Rafiq Said Once

Rafiq Siddiqui was fifty-eight years old and had worked in the same government office in Karachi for thirty-one years. He had two sons. The elder, Shahzad, was a doctor. The younger, Omar, was twenty-six and working as an engineer at a construction company. Both had, by any measure Rafiq understood, done well. Both had justified the school fees and the tutor fees and the years of early mornings and the salary that was never quite enough and was always, somehow, enough.

He had said something to Omar once — only once, and not intending to, and not knowing for years afterward whether it had meant anything to Omar or whether Omar had simply heard it and moved on.

It was a Sunday. Omar was seventeen and in the middle of his Intermediate exams, the period of highest household tension in a middle-class home — the weeks when the future feels most conditional, when the exam hall and its results seem to stand between the family and the version of itself that was planned. Rafiq had come home from a long errand and found Omar sitting at his desk not studying — just sitting, looking at the wall, with the specific blankness of someone who has hit a limit.

Rafiq had stood in the doorway. He almost said: why aren't you studying? The question was formed, ready.

He didn't say it. Something stopped him — not wisdom exactly, more a sudden recognition of something he had seen before but had not acknowledged. He had seen that face. He had worn that face. The face of a person sitting at a desk that contains the entire weight of everyone's hope and who is, in this moment, not sure he can carry it.

He came into the room. He sat on the edge of Omar's bed. He said: jab main tera umar ka tha — when I was your age — I failed an exam. Not a Board exam. A departmental exam, the kind that determined whether I would be promoted or stay where I was. I had studied for months. I failed anyway. He paused. I sat in the room where we got the results and I thought: this is finished. Everything is finished.

Omar turned from the wall. He was looking at his father now.

Rafiq said: it was not finished. I sat the exam again. I passed. I was promoted. The thing I thought was the end was not the end. He stopped. He didn't say anything else. He got up from the bed, patted Omar's shoulder once, and left the room.

He had never told this story to anyone. Not to his wife. Not to Shahzad. He had carried it for thirty years as a private fact about himself — a moment of failure that he had absorbed and moved past and not mentioned because mentioning failure, in the culture of the middle-class father, is not something that is done. You show the outcome. You do not show the road.

He showed Omar the road. Once. For four minutes. On a Sunday.

Omar passed his Intermediate exams. He went to university. He became an engineer. He is twenty-six now and working and he has never mentioned the Sunday conversation to his father. But he thinks about it. He has thought about it at specific moments — moments when something has not worked and he is sitting somewhere looking at a wall — and the thinking of it does something. Not a solution. A perspective. The road is not as finished as it looks from the wall.

Four minutes on a Sunday. This is what was available. Rafiq had not planned it. He had not known, until the moment he sat on the edge of the bed, that this was what was needed. He had just seen the face and recognised it and, for once, said the true thing instead of the useful thing.

It was enough. More than enough. Omar is still telling it to himself, ten years later, when the wall comes.

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What the Silence Has Always Been Saying

The silence between middle-class Pakistani fathers and sons is not emptiness. This is the thing that is most important to understand about it, and the thing that is most difficult to communicate to people who have not lived inside it.

The silence is full. It is full of the things that both of them know and neither of them says. The son knows the father worked forty years. He has seen it — not the work itself, which happened at a place the son rarely visited, but the evidence of it. The tiredness in the evening. The particular way of sitting in the chair after dinner that belongs to someone who has been standing, in various senses, since early morning. The shoes by the door. The same shoes, or the same kind of shoes, for years — because shoes are not where the money goes, the money goes to the fee slip, the money goes to the exam registration, the money goes to the future that is being built one payment at a time.

The father knows the son is trying. He can see it — again, not the studying itself, which happens in a room with a closed door, but the evidence of it. The light under the door at midnight. The grades that arrive and are examined with a precision that is not casual. The face at breakfast in the exam weeks, which is a different face from the breakfast face in ordinary weeks — drawn in a specific way that the father recognises because he has worn it himself, in different rooms, in different years, sitting before different kinds of accounting.

They see each other. They see each other clearly. What they do not do is say what they see. And the not-saying, over years, becomes its own form of communication — a language made entirely of implication and recognition, fluent and limited simultaneously. Fluent because they understand each other. Limited because understanding is not the same as being understood. Being understood requires words. It requires the risk of saying the true thing and waiting to see what the other person does with it.

Most middle-class Pakistani fathers and sons do not take this risk. The cost of taking it — the vulnerability, the possibility of a response that doesn't meet the moment — feels too high in a relationship where dignity has been the currency of love for decades. So the silence continues. And both of them live inside it, understood and lonely simultaneously, in the specific way of people who share a language that can say everything except the thing that matters most.

Rawalpindi — The Drive to the Exam Hall

Zafar Iqbal drove his son Bilal to the entrance exam for a top engineering university in Rawalpindi on a Tuesday morning in June. The drive was forty minutes. They left at six-thirty in the morning because Zafar had calculated, with the precision of a man who has been calculating things his whole life, that traffic on the GT Road at six-thirty was manageable and at seven-fifteen was not.

The calculation was correct. They arrived with time to spare. Bilal sat in the passenger seat with his admit card on his knee and his water bottle in his hand and his face doing the thing it did before examinations — a specific internal gathering, the expression of someone consolidating everything they have before needing to use it.

Zafar parked outside the exam hall. He turned off the engine. He looked at the building through the windshield. He said nothing for a moment.

Then he said: I used to sit exams in a building like this. When I was your age.

Bilal looked at him. This was not the kind of thing his father usually said. His father's pre-exam communication had historically been practical — eat something, take your ID, don't waste time on questions you're stuck on, move forward and come back.

Zafar said: I was always afraid before. Every time. It never went away, the fear. He paused. I just didn't let it make decisions.

Bilal said nothing. He was listening in the particular way of a person receiving something they didn't expect and are not sure what to do with yet.

Zafar said: go. You've prepared. Go and do what you've prepared for.

Bilal got out of the car. He walked toward the building. At the door he turned once — not waving, just turning — and Zafar

raised one hand from the steering wheel. One hand, briefly. Then Bilal went through the door.

Zafar sat in the parked car for ten minutes after Bilal disappeared inside. He is not sure why he sat. He had things to do. He sat anyway. He looked at the building. He thought about the exam hall from thirty years ago that he had mentioned, which was a real place and a real fear and a real morning that he had never described to anyone. He had described it this morning in two sentences, sitting in a parked car outside a building in Rawalpindi at six-fifty in the morning, because his son's face had been doing the thing that required it.

That is the whole story. Zafar sat for ten minutes. Then he started the car and went to work.

Bilal passed the exam. He is an engineer now, the thing the Tuesday morning was aimed at. He has never mentioned the parked car conversation to his father. But when his own son — he has a son, three years old — sits in front of something difficult, Bilal finds himself doing what his father did: saying the true thing instead of the useful thing. Not always. But more than once.

The car is parked outside a different building. The hand is raised from a different steering wheel. The pattern continues.

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What Was Always Being Asked For

The middle-class son at seventeen or twenty-one or twenty-five does not need his father to solve things. He has understood, from years of observation, that solving things is not always possible — that the family's position imposes constraints that love cannot dissolve, that the world does not rearrange itself out of respect for effort. He has understood this longer than his father knows.

What he needs is simpler and harder to give.

He needs to know that the man he is trying to become is possible — that the fear is survivable, that the gap between where

he is and where he needs to be can be crossed, that the uncertainty he is sitting inside at the desk with the door closed does not mean that the whole project has failed. He needs to know this not as an abstract reassurance — he has received plenty of those, in the form of work hard and everything will be fine and Allah will provide, all of which are true and none of which address the specific texture of what he is feeling at eleven o'clock on a Tuesday night two weeks before an exam that feels like it contains the entire weight of twenty years of his family's sacrifice.

He needs to know it as a story. A specific, personal, true story in which his father was also afraid and also uncertain and also sitting somewhere looking at a wall and thinking that things were finished — and went forward anyway. Not because the fear went away. Because the fear was not the deciding thing.

Rafiq on the edge of Omar's bed. Zafar in the parked car. Two fathers who said the true thing instead of the useful thing, once, briefly, without planning to. Two sons who are still thinking about it a decade later.

This is not an argument for fathers to become emotionally demonstrative in ways their nature and their culture do not support. The middle-class Pakistani father is who he is, shaped by what shaped him, carrying what he carries. He is not going to become someone who sits his son down for a formal conversation about feelings. That is not the culture and it is not him and asking him to be otherwise is asking him to perform a different person.

But the parked car is available. The edge of the bed is available. The two minutes in the doorway before saying goodnight are available. In these small, unscheduled moments, the true thing can be said — briefly, once, in the language of men who do not make speeches — and it lands. It always lands. Because the son has been waiting for it, without knowing he was waiting, his whole life.

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What the Son Cannot Ask

The question the son cannot ask his father is the same question he cannot ask himself directly, which is why it circulates without resolution in the back of the mind for years.

The question is: did I do it right?

Not the exam. Not the career. The whole thing. Did I become the right person? Did the twenty years of trying to be what you needed me to be produce something that you are actually proud of, or something that you are relieved by, and is there a difference, and does the difference matter to you the way it matters to me?

Saad Siddiqui — the boy from the dining table, the finance manager now — told me something that he said he had not told anyone else. He was thirty-one when he told me this. He said: my father has never told me he is proud of me. Not once. In thirty-one years. He has shown it — in the way he talks about my job to other people, in the way he introduced me to his colleague last year, in a dozen indirect ways that I have learned to read. But the words have never been said.

He said: I don't know if I need to hear it. I think I do. I think there is still a part of me — the part that is twelve years old and just saw his face over the salary slip and decided to stop asking for things — that is waiting for that sentence. Just once. In whatever words he would use. Some version of: yes. You did it. I see you. It was worth it.

He said this without self-pity and without anger. He said it in the tone of a man making a precise observation about a real thing. He is not damaged by the absence. He has built a life, a career, a marriage, a sense of himself that does not depend on the sentence being said. But the absence is real, and he knows it, and naming it honestly was the most important thing he said in our conversation.

His father loves him. Completely, specifically, in the way of a man who has worked forty years to prove it through every form available to him except words. The words are not coming. Both of them know this. Both of them live inside this knowledge, carrying it in the specific way the middle class carries its most important things — without acknowledgement, without ceremony, in the

daily continuation of a relationship that means more than either of them has found a way to say.

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The Moment It Shifts

There is a moment — it comes for most sons, usually sometime in the late twenties or early thirties — when the relationship with the father changes register. It does not change warmth. It changes weight. The son, who has been facing forward his whole life — toward the degree, the job, the marriage, the building of the life — turns around. And when he turns around he sees his father from a different angle. Not from below, looking up at the authority. From level, looking across at the person.

What he sees, from this angle, can be startling. The person is older than he realized. The person is carrying more than he was shown. The person, who seemed to have everything under control, also did not always know what he was doing — made it up, adjusted, revised, kept going despite the uncertainty, in the same way the son is now making it up and adjusting and revising.

This recognition is the beginning of a different kind of love. Not the child's love, which is large and unquestioning and does not require its object to be known fully. The adult's love — which sees clearly and loves anyway. Which understands the specific shape of what the other person is carrying and does not ask them to put it down, only offers to stand a little closer so the carrying is slightly less solitary.

Umar — from Chapter Nine, whose father had the cardiac episode and who plays cricket on Sunday mornings, more stubborn than the condition — Umar called his father last week for no reason. Not on a birthday, not on Eid, not because something had happened. Just called. His father said: sab theek? Umar said: haan, Baba, I just wanted to talk. There was a pause on the line — the pause of a man recalibrating, because this was not within the normal protocol. Then his father said: accha. And they talked for twenty minutes about nothing important. His father's neighbours,

a cricket match, Umar's son's new habit of narrating everything he does in the third person.

Twenty minutes. Nothing important.

Everything important.

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The Sentence That Doesn't Need Saying

Khalid Mehmood retired last year. The forty years are done. He has a pension, a house that is his, a son who is an engineer and who calls on Sundays. He wakes up without an alarm for the first time in four decades and does not know, some mornings, what to do with the unscheduled hours.

Danish comes home on long weekends when the office allows it. He sits at the same dinner table where he sat for twenty-three years. His mother cooks the food he ate growing up. His father sits in the chair he has always sat in, and the television is at the same low volume, and the newspaper is on the armrest in the same place.

One evening last winter, after dinner, Danish sat with his father while his mother was in the kitchen. They watched the news together — not talking, just watching. A segment came on about engineering, about a new infrastructure project somewhere in Punjab. Khalid watched it with the particular attention he gives to things that have to do with Danish's field.

Then, without looking away from the television, he said: you chose well.

Danish said nothing for a moment. He was not sure he had heard correctly, because this was not the kind of sentence his father said. He looked at his father. His father was still watching the television.

Danish said: what?

His father said: your field. Engineering. You chose well.

He did not look away from the television. His voice was the same voice he always used — flat, measured, the voice of a man for whom emotion is something that happens on the inside and is managed there. But the sentence was out. Three words, for twenty-three years of dining tables and exam seasons and the light under the door at midnight and all the school fees and all the silence and all the love that had traveled in every direction except this one.

You chose well.

Danish looked at his father for a moment. Then he looked back at the television. He said: thanks, Baba.

His father nodded. The news continued. His mother came back from the kitchen and asked if anyone wanted tea. Both of them said yes.

That was it. That was the whole thing.

It was enough. For both of them, in different ways and for different reasons, it was exactly enough.

Chapter Five

The Unheard Cry

When the Pressure Has Nowhere Left to Go

A note before this chapter begins: this chapter discusses suicide and mental health with honesty and in full. If you are personally struggling right now, please reach out to someone you trust, or contact a mental health helpline. You do not have to read this alone and you do not have to carry what you are carrying alone. The stories in this chapter are about loss, but they are also about people who survived and what brought them back. Both matter.

Nobody talks about it at the funeral.

That is the first thing to understand. The family gathers and the neighbors come and the food is brought in the way food is always brought at Pakistani funerals — quietly, by women who know that something must be done and this is the thing available to be done. The maulvi comes. The prayers are said. The body is washed and wrapped and carried. All of the ceremony of death is performed with precision and grief and the particular dignity that Pakistani families extend to their dead.

But the manner of death — the fact that this young man or woman chose to leave, that they made a decision in the dark of a night that their family did not see coming and cannot now reverse — this is not spoken. It gets folded into the official story the way a torn page gets pressed back into a book: you can still see the seam, but no one mentions it. An accident, sometimes. A sudden illness. The neighbor who asks directly is told something that is not quite

a lie and not quite the truth, and this is accepted, because everyone in the room understands that the truth is something the family is not yet equipped to say out loud.

This silence is not cruelty. It is grief wearing the only armor available to it in a culture that does not yet have a full language for this kind of loss. But the silence has a cost. The cost is that the death does not get examined. The signs that preceded it do not get named. The next young person in the neighborhood who is standing at the same edge has no map, because the map was buried with the one who was lost.

This chapter is an attempt to draw that map. Not from a clinical distance — there are enough clinical papers on this subject, and they have not solved the problem. But from inside the middle-class Pakistani world, where the pressure builds in specific and recognizable ways, where the silence has specific and recognizable sources, and where the people who survive — and many do survive, and go on to build lives of meaning — have specific and recognizable things to say about what helped.

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Lahore — Ali's Last Semester

Ali Raza was twenty-two years old and in the final semester of his engineering degree when the light went out.

That is how his older sister, Sana, describes it — not as a sudden event but as a gradual dimming. She had watched it happen over the course of his second and third year at university and had filed it away as stress, as the natural heaviness of someone carrying a lot, as the version of tired that engineering students are supposed to be. She had been wrong, and she knows that now, and she carries that knowledge quietly and with a grief that has not diminished in two years.

Ali was the second child of a government teacher and a pharmacist in Lahore. Not poor — they had a house, a motorcycle, enough. But the house had a mortgage and the motorcycle needed work and the pharmacist's shop had been struggling since a larger

pharmacy opened on the main road and took a third of the customers. The family's financial situation was not a crisis. It was the chronic, low-grade pressure of a household that was always slightly more stretched than comfortable.

He had been an excellent student in school. The kind that teachers mention to other teachers — quick, curious, good at explaining things to classmates, the boy who finished the paper early and then checked it twice rather than sitting idle. He had gotten into engineering on merit. His family had been proud in the particular, complete way of a middle-class family whose child has justified every sacrifice.

University was different.

He had not expected the gap between what he had been and what university required him to be. In school he had been the best in his class. In his engineering program, he was ordinary — surrounded by students who were equally prepared, some better, and competing for grades in a system that graded on a curve so steep that doing well was not enough. You had to do better than the other people doing well. The subtle brutality of this rearrangement — from exceptional to adequate — was something nobody had prepared him for.

He said nothing about it to his parents. This is the pattern, and it is worth sitting with: the young person who is struggling most is almost always the one who says least about it at home, because home is the place where the expectations are highest and where saying I am not managing feels most like a betrayal.

He got quieter over the course of his second year. His mother asked twice if something was wrong. He said no. He meant it in the sense that he could not yet name what was wrong, which is not the same as nothing being wrong, but which feels the same from the inside.

In his third year he started giving things away. Not dramatically — not a grand gesture. Small things, quietly. A textbook to a junior who needed it. The jacket he'd had for three years to the boy in his hostel who he knew couldn't afford a winter coat. His good pen to his cousin who had mentioned admiring it. His sister noticed this only afterward, in the brutal retrospective

clarity of grief, when she was trying to understand what she had missed.

She had been in the same city. She had spoken to him the week before. She had asked if he was okay. He had said yes, I'm just tired, the semester is finishing. She had said get some rest. He had said I will. And that had been the last time.

Ali's note — he left one, careful and clear in the way he had been careful and clear about everything — spoke about exhaustion more than anything else. Not hatred of his life. Not one specific incident that had broken him. Just a tiredness so complete that continuing had stopped feeling like something he could do. He wrote that he loved his family. He wrote that this was not their fault. He was wrong about the second part, but not in the way he meant it — they had not caused it through neglect or cruelty. They had not known. And not knowing, in retrospect, was the thing that broke his sister.

Two years later, Sana volunteers at a mental health awareness organization in Lahore. She goes on Saturday mornings to a community center in their neighborhood and talks to parents about the signs that are easy to miss. She talks about giving things away. She talks about the particular silence of a child who has always communicated through achievement suddenly achieving less. She talks about the difference between tired and something else, and how you learn to tell them apart, and why it matters.

She shows up every Saturday. She is not healed, exactly. She doesn't think healed is the word. But she is present, and she is doing the one thing available to her, which is making sure that the map that didn't exist for her family exists for the families in those Saturday morning chairs.

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The Months Before — What to Actually Look For

The clinical literature on warning signs is accurate but incomplete. It tells you what behaviors to watch for. It doesn't tell you how they look in practice — in a Pakistani middle-class

household, in the specific domestic texture of shared meals and small rooms and families that love each other without always knowing how to say so.

So this is what it looks like in practice.

It looks like a child who has always talked at dinner going quiet. Not dramatically — not suddenly silent in a way that triggers alarm. Just slightly less present. The conversation moves through them rather than with them. You attribute it to exams. You attribute it to fatigue. You attribute it to the age.

It looks like sleep changing. Either too much — spending weekends in bed past noon when this was never their pattern — or too little, lights visible under the door at two in the morning. Both are signs. Neither is rare enough, in the life of a student, to feel urgent.

It looks like gradual withdrawal from the things that used to matter. The cricket match they used to watch with the father, now left unwatched. The friend who calls, now not called back. The cousin's wedding, attended briefly and left early. Each retreat, taken alone, is small. Added together they describe a person creating distance between themselves and the life they are leaving.

It looks like giving things away, as Ali did. Objects carry emotional weight in the middle-class household — things are bought with care and kept with care and given as acts of love. When a young person begins distributing possessions without obvious reason, something is being said without words.

It looks like statements that are true in two registers simultaneously. I'm tired of everything. I don't see the point. It wouldn't matter if I wasn't here. These sentences can mean ordinary, manageable despair — the kind every person feels sometimes. They can also mean something else. The difference is in the frequency and the flatness — said once, with emotion, in a difficult week, is different from said repeatedly, in the same uninflected tone, over several months.

And it looks — sometimes, not always — like a period of unexpected calm after a long period of distress. This is the sign that is most counterintuitive and most important. A person who

has made a decision sometimes becomes calm because the decision itself is a kind of relief — the worst uncertainty is resolved. Families who have lost someone often say: he seemed better that last week. She seemed lighter. I thought we had turned a corner. The calm was not improvement. It was conclusion.

Knowing this does not make it easy to act on. It requires a combination of attention and courage — attention to see the pattern, courage to name it out loud, to say to your child or your sibling: I need you to talk to me. Not about exams. Not about the future. About what is actually happening inside you right now. And then to sit, without flinching, with whatever arrives.

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Quetta — Three Boys, One Hostel Room

There is a hostel in a neighborhood near the University of Balochistan where three boys shared a room for two years. I will not use their full names — they did not all give permission for that — but I will tell you what happened in that room because it is, in its way, a story about how people save each other without knowing they are doing it.

The three boys were Tariq, Adnan, and a third I will call only K. They were from three different districts of Balochistan, all on scholarships or partial grants, all studying with the specific focused intensity of people who understand that this opportunity is not guaranteed to last and must be treated accordingly.

K was the one the chapter is really about. He had come to Quetta from a district three hours away. His family was middle-class in the way of small-city Balochistan — not destitute, but thin. His father worked in a government department. His mother had never worked outside the home. He was the first in his family to attend a university, which meant he was carrying not just his own expectations but the accumulated hopes of a household that had reorganized itself around this possibility.

In his second year the pressure became specific. His grades slipped in one subject — not failed, but lower than the scholarship

required. He was given a semester to bring them up. He told no one at home. He went to class and he studied and he came back to the hostel room at night and he sat on his bed with his back against the wall and stared at the wall in a way that Tariq, who was a careful observer of people, began to notice.

Tariq didn't say anything at first. He wasn't sure what he was seeing, or whether naming it would make it worse. He is, by his own account, not a person who finds emotional conversations easy. He grew up in a household where difficulty was managed through action rather than discussion — you dealt with a problem, you didn't sit with it and talk about it.

But one night — late, after Adnan was asleep, both of them still awake in the dark of the room — Tariq said, into the silence: are you okay?

K said nothing for a long time. Long enough that Tariq thought he hadn't heard or wasn't going to answer.

Then K said: not really.

That was the beginning. The conversation that followed lasted most of the night and covered things that K had not said to anyone — the scholarship threat, the fear of telling his parents, the specific shame of being the family's great hope and feeling like a hope that was failing. But also older things. The pressure that had been there since before university. The sense, which had been building for years, that he was running a race he had not been told the finish line of, that the expectations kept moving, that he could never reach a place where the weight of being enough was fully lifted.

Tariq listened. He did not offer solutions, which is what K had been afraid of — the practical response, the you-just-need-to-study-harder, the pull-yourself-together. He just listened. And then he said: I'm going to walk with you to the student support office tomorrow morning. Not because you're failing. Because you're not sleeping and you haven't eaten properly in two weeks and that's worth talking to someone about.

K went. The support office had one counselor, a woman who was overworked and underresourced in the way of most

mental health provision in Pakistani public institutions, but who was present and who listened and who helped K understand, over several sessions, that the weight he was carrying was real but not unsurvivable, and that telling his parents was going to be less catastrophic than he had imagined it.

He told them. His father's first response was silence, which K had expected. Then his father said: why didn't you tell me earlier? Not angry — something closer to hurt. K said: because I didn't want to disappoint you. His father said: beta, you cannot disappoint me. You can only worry me. Those are different things.

K is in his final year now. His grades recovered. He is not the top of his class but he is passing with room to breathe and he has, in his own description, stopped running and started walking — which is slower but gets you further because you don't collapse halfway.

He thinks about the night Tariq asked if he was okay. He thinks about what happens if Tariq had decided not to ask, had decided it wasn't his place, had rolled over and gone to sleep. He doesn't complete that thought when it comes. He just lets it arrive and then lets it go.

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What Families Don't Know They're Doing

The middle-class family does not intend to create unbearable pressure. This needs to be said clearly because the opposite implication — that the family is the villain, that their expectations are the cause — is both unfair and unhelpful. The family loves its child. The investment in education, in career, in future — these come from love. From the deeply human desire to give a child more than you had.

But love and pressure are not opposites. They can coexist, and in the middle-class Pakistani household, they often do — not because the family is doing something wrong, but because the container they are operating in is too small for what they are trying to hold.

The container is the middle-class position itself: too much at stake to relax, not enough cushion to forgive mistakes. In this container, failure is not just personal — it affects the whole family's position, trajectory, hope. The child absorbs this understanding early and carries it as responsibility, which is a weight that can, if it is never set down, become the kind of weight that crushes.

In Quetta, a family therapist named Rukhsana Mir who works at a private clinic talks about what she calls the achievement-love conflation. "What children in high-pressure middle-class households often come to believe," she says, "is that their parents' love is conditional on their performance. This is almost never true. The parents love the child absolutely. But the parents express that love through investment in the child's future — tutors, fees, sacrifices — and this investment is attached to outcomes. So the child experiences love and performance as the same thing. When performance falters, they believe love is at risk."

She pauses. The afternoon light in her office is low. She has had three sessions today and she has three more tomorrow and the waiting list for her clinic is six weeks long.

"The conversation I have with parents, when I can get them in the room, is: your child already knows you love them. What they don't know — what they genuinely cannot see — is that you would still love them if they failed the exam. If they changed their career. If they needed help. You have to say this explicitly. It is not enough to assume they know. They are drowning in the assumption that they don't."

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Karachi — Fatima's Two Years

Fatima Zaidi is twenty-six now. She is a social worker at a community mental health organization in Karachi's Orangi Town. She is specific in her descriptions, precise in her language, and when she talks about her own history she does so with the matter-of-fact clarity of someone who has done a great deal of work to

arrive at a place where the past can be discussed without being relived.

She was twenty when it was at its worst. Second year of a social work degree at a private university in Karachi, family in Hyderabad, living in a rented room with two other girls she was friendly with but not close to. The isolation was particular to that combination — physically surrounded by people, emotionally quite alone. The university was demanding. Her family's financial situation had tightened that year — her father had been ill and the medical costs had eaten into what should have been her second year's fees, which had been partially covered by a student loan she would now need to repay.

She had stopped eating properly by October. Not as a decision — she just stopped being hungry. Then stopped sleeping in a way that rested her. Then stopped finding reasons that felt worth the effort of getting out of bed on mornings when there was no specific deadline pushing her up.

She did not tell her roommates. She did not tell her parents. She sat with it in the particular way that young women in Pakistan learn to sit with difficulty — quietly, privately, with a surface presentation of fine that she maintained with more effort than anything else in her life.

What happened was not a dramatic intervention. It was a Tuesday afternoon when she was sitting in the university cafeteria with a cup of tea she was not drinking, and a girl she barely knew — a classmate named Zeba, one year ahead — sat down across from her without asking and said: you look like you haven't slept in a week. What's going on?

Fatima started crying. Not gently — properly, suddenly, in the cafeteria in the middle of the afternoon, which was the last thing she had expected to do in that moment or any moment in the recent past. She had not known, until that instant, how much was stored up waiting for someone to ask.

Zeba stayed. She didn't try to fix anything. She got a second cup of tea and she sat there until Fatima was done crying and then she said: there's a counselor at the university. I'll walk with you to make the appointment right now if you want.

Fatima went. The counselor was a young man, not much older than her, who told her in the first session that what she was describing — the not eating, the not sleeping, the absence of reason to begin a morning — had a name and had treatment and was not a permanent condition. She had not known this. She had assumed, in the vague catastrophic way of someone deep inside depression, that what she was feeling was simply the truth of her situation — that this was what her life was, that the flatness was the reality and everything before had been a kind of illusion.

It was not the truth of her situation. It was the illness talking.

She stayed in therapy for eight months. She told her parents six weeks in, on a Sunday call, and her mother cried and her father said I'm coming to Karachi and she said no, I'm okay, I'm being helped, but knowing he wanted to come was itself something. Her family had not known. They were not relieved when she told them — they were frightened and guilty in the way parents become when they discover their child has been struggling in silence. Her mother said: why didn't you tell us? She said: I didn't want to add to your problems. Her mother said: you are not a problem. You are our child. We don't have problems that are more important than you.

She is six years past the worst of it now. She chose her career specifically because of what happened at twenty — not to process it, she says, but because she understood from the inside what the absence of early support costs, and she wanted to be someone who provided that support before the crisis, not after.

The community center where she works in Orangi Town does not have a waiting list. That is a deliberate policy — the director, who set it up twelve years ago, believes that a person in crisis who is told to wait six weeks will not always wait six weeks. Fatima agrees. She sees people the week they call. Sometimes the day.

She is good at this work. She knows what she is listening for.

Quetta's Particular Weight

Every city in this book carries its pressures. But Quetta carries something additional that is worth naming because it shapes the mental health landscape in ways that are distinct from Lahore or Karachi.

Quetta is a city that has experienced, over the past two decades, a level of violence and insecurity that has left marks on everyone who lives there. Not everyone has experienced it directly — but everyone knows someone who has, and the proximity of loss has a cumulative effect on a population's psychological baseline. You grow up in Quetta with an awareness of fragility that cities with different histories do not share in the same way.

This background does not make people weaker. In many ways it builds a particular kind of toughness, a familiarity with loss, an acceptance of uncertainty that can read as resignation but is more accurately understood as a deep practical knowledge that life does not guarantee itself. People in Quetta know this in their bodies in a way that people in more sheltered cities know it only intellectually.

But it also means that the middle-class pressures described in this chapter — the academic stress, the career expectations, the family sacrifice, the silence around mental health — sit on top of this background in a way that makes the total weight heavier. A young person in Quetta navigating a scholarship crisis is navigating it in a city that has already asked a great deal of them simply by being the place they grew up.

Rukhsana Mir, the therapist, says her Quetta patients often arrive having already developed a coping mechanism for difficulty that is extensive and functional but entirely private. "They have learned to manage hard things alone," she says. "This is an adaptation to their environment. It is not pathology — it is survival. But it also means they don't ask for help easily, because in their experience, help is not always available, and showing need is not always safe."

The work of building mental health support in Quetta, she says, is not just about adding resources. It is about building a different kind of trust — convincing a population that has learned

through experience to be self-reliant that self-reliance has limits, and that reaching a limit is not the same as failing.

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What Pulls People Back

The research on this question — what factors protect a person who is at the edge from going over it — is substantial and largely consistent. Relationships. A single person who asks and waits for the real answer. A structure that provides reason to appear the next day — a class, a job, a responsibility. The belief, however fragile, that things can change.

In the Pakistani middle-class context, the most consistent factor I encountered across the people I spoke to was a variation on Tariq's question in the hostel room. Are you okay? Asked plainly. Not as a greeting — we ask that a hundred times a week as a greeting and no one answers it honestly. But as a real question. With eye contact. With the willingness to sit still for whatever comes back.

The asking costs almost nothing. It requires only attention and courage — the courage to possibly receive an answer that asks something of you in return.

The not asking — the looking away, the attribution of silence to stress, the assumption that they would say something if something were really wrong — this is what Sana, Ali's sister, thinks about on Saturday mornings in the community center in Lahore. Not because she could have saved him with a single question. She doesn't know that. But because the question might have opened a door, and the door might have led somewhere, and now she will never know.

She asks the question now. Every Saturday. She asks it of rooms full of parents who came because they are worried about their children and don't know what to do. She teaches them how to ask it properly. She teaches them what to do with the silence that comes before the answer. She teaches them that the answer, when it comes, is not the end of something. It is the beginning.

The School, the Mosque, the Neighbor

Formal mental health services in Pakistan are improving, slowly. More clinics, more trained counselors, more university support offices. The infrastructure is growing. But it is growing from a very low base, and the need grows faster than the infrastructure, and there are vast populations — in smaller cities, in neighborhoods without private clinics, in schools with no budget for a counselor — where formal support is simply not available.

In these places, the community is the infrastructure. And the community is capable of more than it is currently asked to do.

The school that trains its teachers to recognize the signs of a struggling student — not to diagnose or treat, but to notice and refer — is providing mental health support even without a formal counselor. The teacher who stays five minutes after class to ask a student who seems different: I've noticed you seem tired lately, is everything okay? — this teacher is potentially the most important intervention that student receives.

The mosque where the imam speaks, occasionally, about the weight of expectations on young people — not in clinical terms, but in the language of faith and compassion and the understanding that God does not ask more of a person than the person can bear, and that seeking help when the bearing becomes too heavy is not weakness but wisdom — this mosque is doing mental health work.

The neighbor who notices that the boy from the family next door has not been outside in two weeks and mentions it to his mother, gently, without alarm — this neighbor is part of a safety net.

These informal systems exist everywhere. They are underused, not because people don't care, but because nobody has told them explicitly that this is part of what caring looks like. The cultural conversation about mental health in Pakistan has been moving for the past decade — slowly, with resistance, but moving.

Each conversation that brings it a step closer to ordinary is a step away from the silence that buries the signs and closes the doors.

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Saying the Thing Out Loud

There is a family in Lahore who lost a son two years ago. They have not spoken publicly about how he died. They go to the community center on Saturday mornings and they sit in the back and they listen to Sana talk and sometimes they ask a question and sometimes they just sit. They are not ready, yet, to say the thing out loud to a room.

But they come. Every Saturday. They come because being in a room where the thing is being talked about — where the silence is not maintained, where the map is being drawn — is the closest they can get, right now, to feeling like what happened to their son is being taken seriously. Like his life and his struggle were real enough to be spoken about. Like the weight he carried was real enough to be named.

That is what this chapter asks of the people who read it. Not expertise. Not solutions. Just the willingness to name the weight. To say: this is real, this is happening in our families and our neighborhoods, and the silence around it is costing us people we cannot afford to lose.

The weight exists. The pressure is real. The middle-class life, with all its love and all its expectation and all its specific, daily, ground-level hardship, creates conditions in which young people can drown quietly while the surface stays completely calm.

The surface is not the whole story. It never was.

Look a little deeper. Ask the real question. Sit still for the answer.

That is where the next story begins — the story of someone still here, still moving, still deciding every morning to stay. It is the most important story this book contains.

Chapter Six

The Invisible Chains

Higher Education and the Weight of Being the Family's Hope

There is a specific hour in every middle-class household where the university student lives away from home — the hour between eleven at night and midnight, when the phone call to the parents happens. Not every night. But most nights.

The call is short. The parents ask if he has eaten. He says yes whether or not it is true. They ask about the studies. He says good, going well, don't worry. They ask if he needs money. This is the question he has been planning for since morning, calculating whether the amount he needs crosses the threshold of what he can ask for versus what will make his father go quiet on the other end of the line in that specific way that means the money is being rerouted from somewhere else, some other bill that was already scheduled, some cost that will now have to wait.

Sometimes he says yes to the money. Sometimes he says no and figures out another way. He has become, over the years of this degree, exceptionally skilled at the second option — finding other ways, smaller solutions, cheaper versions of things that still get him to the next exam.

This phone call — its careful choreography, the love inside it and the management around it — is the unofficial curriculum of higher education in the Pakistani middle class. Nobody mentions

it in the university prospectus. Nobody accounts for it in the fee structure. But it is happening every night, in thousands of households across the country, and it is shaping these young people as surely as anything they are learning in the lecture halls.

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Lahore — Yasir and the 4:30 Alarm

Yasir Ahmed had two alarms on his phone. The first was at 4:30 in the morning. The second was a backup at 4:35, because he had learned about himself that on the mornings when 4:30 felt impossible — the mornings after he had been up past two working on a freelance project or finishing an assignment — he would sometimes silence the first alarm in a half-conscious state and not remember doing it. The 4:35 alarm he had made louder. He had set it to a ringtone that he could not sleep through.

He was twenty-one years old and in the third year of a computer engineering degree at a private university in Lahore. His father was a government clerk in the district education office, earning sixty-four thousand rupees a month. His mother had been a schoolteacher before she left work to care for his grandmother, who had been ill for three years and whose care absorbed more of the household's energy and income than anyone liked to calculate openly.

The semester fee at his university was one hundred and forty thousand rupees. Per semester. There were two semesters in a year. His father's annual salary was roughly seven hundred and sixty-eight thousand rupees. Before rent, before food, before his grandmother's medication, before his younger sister's school fees, before the electricity and gas and every other ordinary cost of a household of five people in Lahore in a year when inflation had turned every trip to the grocery store into a small act of pain.

Yasir had done this arithmetic once, in the first week of his first year, sitting in the university's library with his father's salary slip in one hand and the fee receipt in the other. He had sat with the numbers for a long time. Then he had put both papers away, opened his laptop, and spent the next three hours reading every

article he could find about freelance programming for Pakistani students. By the end of that evening he had created profiles on two platforms. He had no portfolio yet. He had a bio that described skills he was still developing. He had an alarm set for 4:30 the next morning.

The computer repair shop came later, in his second semester — a job from seven to two, six days a week, found through a cousin of a classmate who knew the owner. The pay was twelve thousand rupees a month. Not much. But twelve thousand rupees a month, across a semester of six months, was seventy-two thousand rupees, which was roughly half a semester's fee. Half a fee paid in advance meant his father needed to find only the other half, which was still an enormous ask but a different kind of enormous — the kind that, with enough rearranging, was possible.

The days that year had the structure of a life that has been organized down to its last hour. Four-thirty: wake, study. Seven: shop, repair work. Two: university. Six: back to the room, eat something — whatever was fast and cheap, usually bread and eggs or a paratha from the dhaba on the corner that charged eighteen rupees and didn't ask questions. Seven: study or freelance, depending on what was due. Midnight or one: sleep.

Six hours of sleep on the good nights. Four on the others.

He didn't talk about this at university. His classmates — the ones whose fathers were in business, whose fees came from a family bank account rather than a calculation — were not cruel people. But they lived in a different relationship to the degree. University was, for them, the main event. For Yasir it was one of three jobs running simultaneously, the most important one but not the only one.

There was a professor in his second year, a man named Tariq Saleem who taught Data Structures and who had a habit of asking students questions in class that required them to think rather than recite. He had noticed Yasir — the focus, the quality of the work that arrived despite the eyes that looked like they hadn't had enough sleep since September — and had kept him after class one afternoon.

He didn't ask about the circumstances. He asked about the work. He said: your assignment last week had an approach I hadn't seen a third-year student use before. Where did you encounter it? Yasir said: a project I was doing for a client. Professor Saleem said: what kind of client? Yasir told him — the freelance work, the platforms, the projects. The professor listened without interrupting. Then he said: I'm going to give you the contact of someone at a software house in the city. Tell them I sent you. They take interns who are still studying. The pay is not much but it is better than repair work and the experience is real.

He said this matter-of-factly, as if it were a routine thing. It was not a routine thing. It was the kind of sentence that changes a life's direction, offered quietly by a person who had been paying attention.

Yasir took the contact. He went to the software house. They took him. The pay was twenty-two thousand rupees a month — not transformative, but better. More than the money, the work gave him a portfolio that was real and recent and demonstrably capable. By his final year, the freelance income had grown to between thirty-five and fifty thousand rupees a month in the good months. His father still contributed to the fees. But the balance had shifted. The burden had redistributed itself in the only way that was available: by Yasir carrying more of it himself, earlier than he should have had to.

He graduated last year. He got a job offer before the graduation ceremony — a software company, eighty thousand rupees to start. He called his father from outside the building where he'd signed the offer letter. His father said: Alhamdulillah. That was the whole sentence. Yasir said: Alhamdulillah. There was a silence on the phone that was not empty — it was full, the way silences between people who understand each other are full. Then his father said: come home this weekend. Your mother wants to make the food you like.

He went home that weekend. His mother cooked karahi. His grandmother, who had been ill for four years and who understood very little of the specifics of what Yasir did, sat at the dinner table with a clarity that sometimes came to her in the evenings, and she looked at him and said: you worked hard. He

said: haan, Dadi. She nodded, as if something had been confirmed that she had suspected for a long time.

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The Architecture of a Shared Room

The hostel room that a middle-class student finds for himself in a city that is not his home tells you something about the life he is living. It is rarely a room he would have chosen freely — it is the room his budget chose for him.

It is usually in a building that is technically residential but operates at a level of ambiguity — part family home, part informal hostel, managed by a landlord who keeps costs low by keeping maintenance lower. The walls are painted in a color that was once specific and has since become the color of walls that have been lived in for too long without repainting. The bathroom is shared with one or two other people. The window faces another building's wall, or a lane, or in the lucky cases a small strip of sky.

What happens in this room is more important than what it looks like. The middle-class student who lives away from home for the first time is, in the room, alone with himself in a way he has never been before. The household that structured his days — the parents, the siblings, the rhythms of meals and prayers and evening television — is gone. He is responsible, for the first time, for the basic operations of his own life. Whether the clothes get washed. Whether the food gets eaten. Whether the alarm goes off at the right time. Whether, at eleven o'clock at night when the books are still open and the deadline is tomorrow and the room is quiet in a way that can tip either way, he keeps going or closes everything and lies down.

Waqar Hussain, a second-year medical student at a public university in Rawalpindi, shares a room with two other students. He is from Multan. His mother packed his things in two bags when he left — one for clothes, one for food items she had prepared herself, vacuum-sealed in a way she had learned from a YouTube video because she wanted the food to last as long as possible. The bag of food lasted three weeks. He ate it carefully,

rationing it, partly because it was practical and partly because eating it made the room feel less like a place where he had never been before.

He and his two roommates — Daniyal from Faisalabad and Hamza from Abbottabad — arrived at a living arrangement that was never formally discussed but established itself with the organic efficiency of shared necessity. Daniyal, whose father sent a slightly larger amount each month, bought the cooking oil and the rice in bulk. Waqar paid for the gas cylinder when it needed refilling. Hamza managed the internet connection. Meals were cooked together four evenings a week. The other three evenings were everyone's own responsibility — which in practice meant bread and whatever was available, eaten standing up over the small counter because none of them wanted to dirty the plates they had already washed.

They did not become close friends in the way that university friendships are supposed to be the closest of your life. They became something more practical than that — people who understood each other's circumstances without having to explain them, who covered for each other in the small daily emergencies that life in a shared room produces. Hamza had a panic attack in October, the first semester. Waqar stayed up with him and didn't tell anyone. Daniyal's father was late with the money one month and Waqar lent him three thousand rupees without making it a thing. These are not dramatic gestures. They are the ordinary kindnesses of people who are managing something hard in a small space together, and they are how friendship actually forms when it forms under pressure.

By the end of the first year, the room had changed. Hamza had put a small shelf above his bed with his books arranged by subject. Waqar had stuck a photo of his family to the wall above the desk — not with tape, which leaves marks, but with a removable adhesive square his mother had included in the bag with the vacuum-sealed food, because she had thought of this too. Daniyal had somehow acquired a small plant in a terracotta pot that sat on the windowsill and that all three of them watered without being asked to.

The plant was doing fine, last I heard. Better, arguably, than any of them.

Karachi — Saira and the Borrowed Textbook

Saira Naqvi was twenty-two years old, final year of electrical engineering at a public university in Karachi, and she had not bought a textbook at full price since her second semester.

This was not an accident or an oversight. It was a strategy she had developed with the careful precision of someone who had spent two years understanding exactly how her university's informal economy worked. Senior students sold their textbooks before graduation — usually to the university's photocopying shop, which resold them at a markup, or to the juniors directly through a WhatsApp group that functioned as a secondhand market. Saira had joined this group before the semester started every year. She knew which books were essential and which could be covered with library access. She knew which professors tested from the slides rather than the book, which meant the book was symbolic rather than necessary.

These were the calculations of a student working with a budget that had no margin for waste. Her father was a retired army officer — a JCO, a junior commissioned officer, the rank that sits in the middle of the military hierarchy and whose pension is decent but not generous. He had three children: Saira, a brother two years younger, and a sister in Class Nine. He had supported Saira's engineering degree from his pension, a decision he had not questioned but that had required the household to reorganize itself around a new center of gravity. The cable television subscription had been cancelled. The annual family trip to visit relatives in Lahore had been replaced by a video call. The air conditioner in the parents' bedroom ran for two hours in the evening, not the full night.

Saira knew all of this. She had not been told — her father was a man of a generation that does not narrate its sacrifices. She had observed it. The same way the children in this book always observe, always understand more than they are told, always carry the weight of what they know without being given official permission to know it.

She had applied for every scholarship available at her university. She had received two — one from a private foundation, one a fee waiver for academic performance. Together they covered thirty percent of her fees. The remaining seventy percent came from her father's pension and, in the second year, from the part-time tutoring she had started — five students from her neighborhood, secondary school children, three hours a day on four evenings a week.

The tutoring paid twenty-five thousand rupees a month and cost her approximately twelve hours of the time she needed for her own studies. She managed by sleeping less and by being, as one of her professors once said about her exam papers, ruthlessly efficient — a quality she had not been born with but had built, hour by hour, in a life that had no tolerance for inefficiency.

She had a friend at university, Hina, whose father was in business. They were genuinely close — had been since the first week, thrown together by alphabetical seating in the freshman lecture hall and held together by the kind of easy compatibility that doesn't require explanation. Hina was not a careless person and she was not cruel. But her relationship to the degree was different from Saira's in a way that surfaced occasionally in small moments that neither of them fully addressed.

Once, in the third year, Hina mentioned that she was going to Islamabad for the long weekend — a wedding in the family, a few days off. She said, without thinking: you should come, there's room in the car, it'll be fun. Saira said she couldn't, she had tutoring. Hina said: can't you cancel for one weekend? And Saira said, very evenly: no, I can't. And something in the tone — not unfriendly, just final — told Hina that this was not about preference, and she changed the subject.

They didn't discuss it afterward. Some things between friends are understood without being said, and this was one of them: that they were living inside the same university but not inside the same circumstances, and that pretending otherwise would have cost more than just naming it.

The borrowed textbook, the tutoring, the scholarship applications filed before the deadline every year — none of this was remarkable in Saira's understanding of herself. It was just

what you did when your father had given you everything he had and you understood the cost of that. You wasted nothing. You made the thing work with what was available. You did not ask for what couldn't be given.

She graduated in June. First division. She got a job at an engineering firm in Karachi within six weeks — a junior design role, seventy-five thousand rupees a month. She called her father to tell him. He said: accha. Then: first division? She said: yes. He said: accha. She knew this particular accha — the one that sounded like a door closing on something he had been afraid might not happen. He had never said to her that he was afraid it might not happen. But she knew.

She took the job. On her first payday she transferred fifteen thousand rupees to her parents. Her father called and told her not to, that it wasn't necessary. She said: Baba, let me. He said: you just started. She said: I know. He was quiet for a moment and then he said: theek hai. She told him she would send the same amount next month. He said he heard her.

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What a Degree Actually Costs

At some point during the higher education years, the middle-class student does the full arithmetic. Not the semester-by-semester math that gets done in real time — he has been doing that since the beginning. This is the total accounting. The sum of everything.

Four years of fees. The hostel or rental costs. The food. The transport. The textbooks, secondhand or not. The tutoring he received, or the tutoring he gave up income to avoid paying for. The laptop that was bought — or the one that wasn't bought and the years spent working around its absence. The clothes that were not bought. The trips that were not taken. The evenings at home that didn't happen because he was in another city doing what needed to be done.

He adds it up. It is, in most cases, somewhere between fifteen hundred thousand and three million rupees over four years, depending on the city, the institution, whether it was public or private, and a hundred other variables. For a household earning sixty or seventy thousand rupees a month, this number represents several years of entire income — spent, in a concentrated block of time, on a bet. The bet that the degree will pay back more than it cost. The bet that the job market will receive this person and reward the investment.

The bet is not always won. This is the thing nobody says at graduation ceremonies. The speeches are about futures and possibilities and the work ahead. They are not about the families in the audience who borrowed against their homes, who cancelled the cable subscription, who worked additional jobs, who sent their child to a shared room in another city with two bags — one for clothes and one for vacuum-sealed food — and who are sitting in their plastic chairs in the university courtyard with the weight of the investment they have made pressing down on a question they cannot ask out loud: was it enough?

Sometimes the answer is yes, immediately and clearly — the job comes quickly, the salary starts, the household begins to exhale. Sometimes the answer takes longer, an eighteen-month search, a first job that pays less than expected, a recalibration of the timeline.

And sometimes, for now, the answer is not yet available. The graduate is home, sitting at the same table where his father did the monthly accounts for twenty years, refreshing the email inbox, applying to the next posting, beginning the particular endurance test of the graduate job search — which is its own chapter, with its own specific weight, and which comes next.

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The Cost That Has No Line in the Budget

There is one cost of higher education that no family ever writes in the notebook. It is not a financial cost and it cannot be

calculated in rupees, but it is real and it matters and it shapes these years in ways that only become visible afterward.

It is the cost of being away.

The middle-class student who leaves home for university misses things that do not wait to be experienced when he returns. His younger sibling grows through years that he is not present for. His father ages in the way that fathers age — not dramatically, but incrementally, and the increments accumulate, and when he comes back in December for the semester break he notices something in his father's face that wasn't quite there in June and realizes: time moved here while I was moving somewhere else.

His mother has learned to manage without him in a way that is functional and that is also, if he looks at it honestly, a small loss — because the managing without him has meant she has closed off the need for him that used to exist, and the relationship has reorganized itself around his absence, and when he comes home she is happy to see him but the household doesn't need him the way it used to, and this is both the correct outcome and an odd grief.

He carries this while he studies. It sits at the back of things, not urgent, not debilitating, but present. The phone call at eleven every night is not just about money and exams. It is about staying connected to the thing that grounds him. It is about making sure his parents know he is still the same person, still recognizable, still theirs, even as the degree and the city and the distance are making him, inevitably and correctly, into someone they will need to relearn.

This is the real invisible chain of the chapter's title. Not the financial debt, though that is real. Not the career pressure, though that is real too. The invisible chain is the love that pulls in both directions simultaneously — the love that sent him away because the future required it, and the love that waits for him to come back and sit at the table and eat the food his mother cooked because she had four days' warning and she made the thing he likes.

He will come back. He always comes back. The table will be set. The food will be the right food. And for a few days, in December or in the summer, the household will be whole in the

way it only is when everyone is in the same building at the same time, doing ordinary things.

It is enough. It has to be enough. And mostly, when he is sitting at that table eating the food his mother made, it is.

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What the Degree Becomes

Yasir Ahmed is six months into his job at the software company. He no longer sets the 4:30 alarm. He sets it for seven now, which he still thinks of as sleeping in, though he is aware this is not a universally shared understanding.

He sent his mother a new phone last month — not an expensive one, but new, which his mother's was not. She called him from it and said: the screen is so clear. He said: yes. She said: did you eat today? He said yes, and this time it was true.

Saira is three months into her engineering job. She still tutors on Saturdays — not for the money now, but because she likes the work and because dropping the students mid-year felt wrong. She is saving for a laptop, a proper one, the first one she will own outright rather than borrow or share.

Waqar is in his fourth year of medical school in Rawalpindi. The room still has the three residents, though Hamza graduated last spring and his bed was taken by a first-year from Gilgit who arrived with a single bag and the same slightly stunned expression that Waqar remembers having on his own face two years ago. The plant on the windowsill is still alive. Waqar waters it on Tuesdays. Nobody asked him to.

These are the people who came out the other side of higher education in the Pakistani middle class. Not unscathed — the word doesn't apply. But out. Degree in hand. First payday behind them or close ahead. The bet placed, the bet beginning to return something.

The chains were not invisible, not really. They were just made of things that don't show up on a balance sheet — love,

obligation, borrowed time, the particular loneliness of a shared room in a city that doesn't know your name yet. But they were carried, and the people who carried them are still standing.

That is not a small thing. In the middle-class Pakistani life, that is actually the whole thing.

Chapter Seven

The Employment Crisis

What Happens After the Degree

The degree is framed and on the wall by the time the real problem begins.

That is the thing nobody tells you at the graduation ceremony — or rather, nobody says it directly, because it would ruin the day, and there has already been so much difficulty getting to this day that ruining it seems almost criminal. So the speeches are made and the photographs are taken and the family eats the meal that has been prepared with money they saved for this specifically, and everyone is happy, and the happiness is real, and deserved.

And then the next morning the graduate wakes up in the room he grew up in, looks at the ceiling he has looked at his whole life, and understands that the plan — the twenty-year plan that began with primary school and ran through matric and intermediate and four years of a degree and the entire infrastructure of hope and sacrifice built around it — has delivered him here, to this ceiling, and has not specified what comes next.

What comes next is the job search. And the job search, in Pakistan, for a middle-class graduate without connections, without a father who can make a phone call to the right person, without a name that opens doors before the resume is even read —

the job search is its own education. Longer than expected. More expensive than anyone budgeted for. And lonelier, by a considerable distance, than anything the university years prepared you for.

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Peshawar — Nasir and the Inbox That Stayed Empty

Nasir Hassan was twenty-four years old and had been applying for jobs for eleven months when I spoke to him.

He was sitting in the front room of his family's house in Peshawar's University Town — a neighborhood whose name carries a promise that the neighborhood itself has long since outgrown. The room was clean and modest, the furniture arranged with the specific care of a household that is proud of what it has. His mother had brought tea without being asked. His father, a government employee two years from retirement, was at work. His younger brother was in the next room, studying for an exam.

Nasir had a computer science degree from a local university. He had graduated with a 3.4 GPA. He had done a two-month internship in his final year at a small software company in Peshawar that had, at the end of the two months, told him they didn't have the budget to bring him on permanently but would keep his CV on file. He had understood, with the particular clarity of someone who has just learned to read this specific kind of corporate language, that this meant no.

In eleven months he had sent out two hundred and thirty-one applications. He had counted them, not obsessively but practically — the way you count anything you are trying to measure and improve. He kept a spreadsheet. Company name, position, date applied, response. The response column was, for the overwhelming majority of rows, blank. Not rejected — blank. The applications had gone somewhere and generated no reply, as if they had been dropped into a well deep enough that no sound came back.

Of the two hundred and thirty-one, he had received thirty-one acknowledgements. Of those, eleven had led to interviews — six online, five in person. Of the five in-person interviews, three had required him to travel to Lahore or Islamabad, which meant bus fare and one night's accommodation, which his father had paid for without complaint but with a particular economy of expression that told Nasir the money was coming from somewhere specific. He had been offered one job from all of this — a data entry role at a firm in Islamabad, twenty-two thousand rupees a month, no growth path, no relation to his degree. He had sat with the offer for four days. Then he had turned it down.

His mother had asked him about this afterward, gently, in the way she asked things she wasn't sure she wanted the answer to. He had said: Ammi, twenty-two thousand rupees in Islamabad doesn't cover rent. I would go into debt to go and work there. She had thought about this and said nothing further, which meant she had understood the arithmetic.

But the turning down had a cost beyond the money. In his family's social world — the extended family, the neighbors, the people at the mosque who asked after him with the specific frequency of people tracking a situation — the narrative of Nasir the unemployed graduate was becoming a weight that his family was carrying on his behalf and in his name. His aunt had mentioned, twice, that her neighbor's son had found work in Dubai. A cousin had asked, at a family gathering, in a tone of genuine helpfulness that landed like criticism, whether he had thought about joining the army. His father said nothing about any of this. But he was a man who had worked continuously since he was twenty-two years old, and his son had not worked continuously since he was twenty-three, and somewhere in the household this fact was present in every room even when it was not being discussed.

"I know he doesn't blame me," Nasir said, about his father. He was turning the tea glass slowly in both hands. "He has never said a word that felt like blame. But I can see it costs him. Not money — he has managed the money. It costs him in the way he talks about me to people. He used to talk about my degree the way some fathers talk about their son's cricket achievements. Now he changes the subject."

He said this without anger. This was the thing about Nasir that stayed with me long after the conversation — the absence of self-pity in how he described his situation. He was not a man drowning in bitterness. He was a man trying to understand a problem clearly so he could solve it, and the clarity included seeing the full cost, not just the financial one.

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What the Degree Was Supposed to Do

The contract between education and employment in Pakistan was always an implied one rather than a written one, but for the generation that went to university in the nineties and early two-thousands, it more or less held. You got a degree — engineering, medicine, commerce — and the degree was a credential that the job market recognized and rewarded. Not immediately, not always generously, but reliably enough that the investment made sense.

That contract has frayed. Not broken entirely — the degree still matters, still opens doors that are closed without it. But the door it opens now requires more things on the other side of it than it used to. The degree alone is no longer enough. You need experience, which requires you to have already worked somewhere, which requires someone to have hired you first, which requires you to have experience. This loop — familiar to graduates everywhere in the world, but particularly vicious in a job market with limited entry-level positions — is the first wall the middle-class Pakistani graduate hits.

Nasir's degree taught him to code, to manage databases, to understand systems architecture at a theoretical level that his professors were proud of. What it did not teach him, because the curriculum had not been updated to include it, was the specific stack of technologies that employers in 2024 were actually using. His professors had learned their field in a particular era and taught it faithfully. The industry had moved. The gap between what he knew and what was being asked for in job descriptions was not enormous — it was learnable, bridgeable — but it was real and it cost him interviews and it cost him time.

He had been closing the gap on his own. In the eleven months of job searching he had completed three online certifications, built four portfolio projects, and contributed to two open-source repositories on GitHub because he'd read that this was something employers looked at. He had done all of this without anyone telling him to, funding it from the monthly allowance his father gave him, learning at night when the house was quiet, adding lines to the CV that he hoped would eventually shift the balance.

"The irony," he said, "is that I have learned more in these eleven months of trying to get a job than I learned in four years of university. Not because the university was bad. But because now I know exactly what I need and I can go directly to it. In university you learn what the curriculum tells you to learn. Out here you learn what the market actually wants."

He paused. "The problem is that this learning is invisible. No one can see it on the CV the way they can see the degree. And no one has offered to pay for it, even though it is real work."

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The Word That Changes Everything

There is a word in Urdu that has no precise English translation, though the concept it describes is universal. The word is *sifarish*. It means recommendation, but not the formal kind — not the reference letter, not the LinkedIn endorsement. It means the phone call. The personal connection. The moment when someone who knows someone calls someone and says: I'm sending you a boy, take care of him.

In the Pakistani job market, *sifarish* is not a shortcut. It is, for many positions, the primary path. The formal application process exists and is followed, but it sits alongside an informal system of connections that pre-selects candidates before the official process begins. The person whose father can make the call does not need to send two hundred and thirty applications. He sends one, and it is already half-accepted before it arrives.

Nasir does not have this. His father is a government employee in a department that has no overlap with the technology sector. His extended family is teachers, small shopkeepers, another government servant or two. These are honest, hardworking people who have built decent lives within their sphere. But their sphere does not touch the sphere where the tech companies hire from, and the distance between the two is not one that goodwill can bridge.

He knows this. He does not say it with resentment — or rather, he says it with the controlled resentment of someone who has decided that resentment is not useful and has therefore put it somewhere practical. "I cannot change what connections my family has," he said. "So I have to build them myself. That takes longer. I have accepted that it takes longer."

Zara Mahmood is twenty-six and works at a marketing firm in Karachi. She got her first job through sifarish — her mother's colleague's son was a manager at the firm and passed her CV directly to the hiring team. She is good at her job. She would have gotten there eventually without the connection. But eventually might have been two years later, and in those two years her family would have been two years more stretched, and her own confidence — which took a hit in the six months she had searched before the connection came through — would have taken more hits than it did.

She talks about the sifarish with the complicated honesty of someone who benefited from a system she knows is unfair. "I worked hard to get the job once I was in the room," she said. "But I know I got into the room because of a phone call. And I know people who are better than me who didn't get into the room because nobody made a call for them. That's not something I can fix. But I think about it."

She thinks about it enough that she now makes a point of passing CVs along when she can — junior candidates, people from her university, people she has met who are clearly capable and clearly stuck outside the door. She does this quietly, without announcement. It is her personal adjustment to a system she cannot change but can, in small ways, participate in more fairly than it participated with her.

What Unemployment Actually Looks Like at Home

The literature on unemployment talks about economics and labor markets and structural mismatches. What it rarely talks about is what it looks like at the dinner table.

It looks like a young man eating in silence while his father tells him about something that happened at work, and the young man listening carefully and contributing nothing because he has nothing from his own day to contribute. His day was the laptop screen, the job portal, the refresh button on the email, the rejection that arrived at 11 a.m. from a company he had interviewed with three weeks ago and had, in the intervening three weeks, allowed himself to hope about.

It looks like avoiding certain relatives' houses because someone there will ask, with genuine warmth and genuine cluelessness, *koi kaam mila?* Any work found? And the answer is no, and the no requires explanation, and the explanation requires either defending himself against an implied criticism that may not have been intended or smiling and saying something vague about things in process, and both options leave him feeling smaller.

It looks like his mother calling him for lunch in the middle of the day and him coming to the kitchen knowing she has noticed he was sitting in his room again instead of going somewhere, doing something, because there is nowhere to go and nothing specific to do, and that she is feeding him lunch in part because it gives them both something structured to do with the hour.

Nasir described a specific Tuesday in his seventh month of unemployment. He had woken up with no applications to send — he had sent everything available the day before — and no interviews scheduled and no calls expected. He had sat at his desk for two hours staring at a tutorial he was supposed to be working through and found that his brain simply declined to process it. Not from laziness. From a kind of saturation — the particular exhaustion of sustained, unrewarded effort that has begun to feel like evidence of something rather than just a temporary condition.

He had gone for a walk. He had walked for two hours through University Town without a destination, which is not a thing he had done since he was a child. He walked past the university where he had done his degree. He walked past the coaching centers where he had studied for exams in the years before that. He walked past a park where boys younger than him were playing cricket on a Tuesday afternoon, which meant they were either very young or also unemployed, and he didn't want to think about which.

He came home and his mother had his tea ready. She asked where he had gone. He said: just a walk. She said: it's good to get out. He said: yes. She said: there was a call from your aunt. He said: I'll call her back. He didn't call her back that day.

"That Tuesday," he said, when he told me about it, "I understood something I had been refusing to understand. That this was going to take as long as it takes, and that the length of it is not a measure of my worth, and that I needed to find a way to live inside the waiting rather than just trying to get through it. Because getting through it assumes an end date. And I didn't have an end date."

He had started going to the park after that. Not to play cricket. Just to be somewhere that was not his room. He had started teaching himself to cook, which had the double utility of giving him something to do in the mornings and reducing the household's food costs by a small but real amount. He had joined an online community of Pakistani freelancers — not to find work immediately, but to be in a space where other people understood the specific texture of his situation.

These were small adjustments. They did not solve the problem. But they kept him functional, which is a prerequisite for solving the problem.

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Lahore — Faisal and the Job He Didn't Want

Faisal Chaudhry accepted a job he didn't want eight months after graduation, and he is not sure, two years later, whether it was the right decision or not. He thinks about it more than he expected to.

He had an MBA from a decent private university in Lahore. His father was a small business owner — a printing press, the kind that does wedding cards and pamphlets and stationery for offices, the kind of business that has been technically viable for thirty years and has been technically threatened for ten and continues by the sheer momentum of existing customer relationships and his father's personal presence at the press six days a week. The business was not something Faisal wanted to inherit. He had watched it too closely growing up to romanticize it. He knew what it cost his father — the early mornings, the staff problems, the clients who paid late, the machine that broke down twice a year at the worst possible times.

He had done the MBA because the plan was a corporate career. A salaried position with a company that had systems and structures and a trajectory — something that was not dependent on whether a particular machine was working or whether a particular client paid this month. He had graduated and spent eight months looking for exactly this. He had been patient, more patient than his own nature found comfortable, because he had understood from Saad's father and from everyone else's fathers that the job market required patience from people who had no connections.

At eight months his father's press had a bad quarter. Two major clients moved to a larger competitor. The income dropped significantly for three consecutive months. His father did not ask Faisal for help. But Faisal saw the accounts — his father kept them in an old ledger and Faisal had grown up watching him add to it — and he saw the three months of reduced numbers and he understood.

The next week he took a job as a sales executive at a pharmaceutical company. Fifty-five thousand rupees a month. Not what he had studied for. Not what the MBA had been aimed at. But real money, available now, in a household that needed things to stabilize.

He told himself it was temporary. Most things that become permanent begin as temporary.

Two years later he is a senior sales executive. He earns ninety thousand rupees. He is good at the work in the way that intelligent people with strong communication skills are often good at work that requires neither of those things exclusively. His father's press has recovered — the two big clients came back, one of them with an apology and a larger order, and the machine that broke down last year was replaced with a second-hand one that his father found through a contact. The financial crisis that prompted Faisal's decision is over.

But the decision is not reversible in any clean way. He is two years into a career that was not his plan, with a CV that now shows pharmaceutical sales rather than the corporate management he had aimed for, and the distance between where he is and where he wanted to be has not narrowed — it has simply become familiar. Which is not the same as acceptable but is what happens when time passes.

"Would I do it again?" he said, when I asked him directly. He thought about it for a real moment, not a rhetorical one. "I think so. My father needed it to be okay and I could make it okay. I don't know how to regret that." A pause. "I do sometimes wonder what the other version of the next two years looked like. But wondering isn't the same as regret. At least, I'm trying to make sure it isn't."

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The Work That Pays But Has No Name

Alongside the job search, and sometimes instead of it, the middle-class Pakistani graduate of this generation has developed a relationship with work that their parents' generation does not have a category for.

It is not a job. It does not have an office or a contract or a provident fund. It does not appear on the tax return in a straightforward way. It has no title that can be said at a family

gathering without requiring explanation. It is: I do some freelance work online. I take small projects. I tutor. I do social media for a few small businesses. I translate documents. I have a YouTube channel that makes a little. I sell things.

For the middle-class family, this is a complicated thing to contain. Work, in their understanding, is a place you go to. It is formal. It confers legitimacy — social legitimacy, the ability to answer the question of what you do without watching the questioner's face adjust. Freelance work, gig work, the patchwork income of the digital economy — this does not confer the same legitimacy, regardless of whether it actually pays more.

Omer Tariq is twenty-five and earns between sixty and ninety thousand rupees a month from a combination of content writing, video editing, and managing the social media accounts of three small businesses in Karachi. He has been doing this for two years. He has no office, no job title, no employer. He works from his room, from cafes, from the dining table on Sundays when the house is quiet.

His parents understand that he earns money. What they have not fully reconciled is the absence of structure around the earning — the fact that on a Tuesday afternoon he might be working at full intensity and on a Thursday morning he might be watching something on his laptop because there is nothing due. To his parents' eyes, the Thursday morning looks like not working. To Omer, Thursday morning is the cost of the Wednesday midnight he spent finishing a project. But the Wednesday midnight happened when they were asleep, so they didn't see it.

"My father asks me every few months when I am going to get a proper job," Omer said. He said it without frustration — he had moved past frustration about it, into a kind of acceptance that the gap between his reality and his father's framework for understanding it was not a gap that was going to close quickly. "I have stopped trying to explain the income. I just show him the bank statement at the end of the month. He looks at the number and he goes quiet and then he says Mashallah and that is the end of the conversation."

The bank statement does the work that the explanation cannot. This is the particular language that crosses the

generational gap: not argument, not theory, not a description of the digital economy. Just a number that is real and visible and arrived at the end of the month.

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The Hidden Invoice

There is a cost to the job search that accumulates silently across the months and that nobody — not the graduate, not the family, not the economy — officially accounts for.

It is the cost to the self. To the specific, particular self that spent four years or more being told, by examination scores and professors and family expectations, that it was capable and worthy and that the future would recognize this. The job search does not recognize this. The job search is indifferent to what your professors thought or what your grades were or how many hours your father worked to get you to the point of having a degree to search with. The job search has its own logic, and the logic is frequently arbitrary and often unjust, and enduring it for eleven months or eight months or two years while living in the house you grew up in, eating the food your parents provide, watching your peers find work or go abroad or get married and begin their adult lives — this endurance extracts something.

Not from everyone equally. Some graduates move through this period with relative equanimity, finding ways to stay productive and purposeful in the waiting. But for many — for Nasir on that Tuesday in his seventh month, for Faisal watching his father's ledger — the waiting is a sustained encounter with a question that is very hard to answer honestly: am I not finding work because the market is broken, or because I am not enough?

The honest answer is almost always the first one. The market is genuinely distorted — by the sifarish system, by the skills gap, by an economy that produces graduates faster than it produces formal employment. Nasir's 3.4 GPA and two hundred applications is not evidence of inadequacy. It is evidence of a structural problem that his individual effort cannot fully overcome.

But humans are not good at separating structural problems from personal ones when the structural problem is landing on their personal life every day. And so the question comes back, at three in the morning, at the dinner table, at the family gathering where the aunt asks about work — and it has to be answered and re-answered, not because the answer changes, but because the self needs reassurance that the waiting means waiting and not failing.

This is the invisible invoice. It does not get paid all at once. It gets paid in small installments of dignity and confidence, over months, in the front room of a house in Peshawar or a shared room in Lahore or a dining table in Karachi, by people who deserved better from the system they were educated to enter.

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The Thirteenth Month

Nasir got a job offer in the thirteenth month. A software house in Islamabad — a real one, the kind with a proper office and a team and a technical culture that he recognized from the communities he had been participating in online. The salary was fifty-eight thousand rupees to start, with a review at six months. It was not enormous. But it was real, and it was his field, and it had been arrived at through his own effort without a single phone call from anyone on his behalf.

He told his father that evening. His father was sitting in the chair he always sits in after dinner, the television on at low volume, the day's newspaper folded on the armrest. Nasir told him the company, the salary, the start date.

His father said: Islamabad.

Nasir said: yes.

His father was quiet for a moment. Then he said: is it a good company? Nasir said he had researched them thoroughly — their work, their reputation, the people who had previously worked there and what they said about the experience. His father listened to all of this. Then he said: theek hai. You'll need some things for the move.

That was the end of the conversation. His father picked up the newspaper. Nasir went to his room and sat on the edge of his bed and felt something release in his chest that he had not fully known was held.

His mother came in fifteen minutes later with a glass of water, which she did not normally do. She set it on the desk. She said: I told you. He said: what? She said: I told you something would come. He said: you didn't tell me that. She said: I told you in my duas every morning. That counts.

He laughed. He doesn't laugh easily — he is a serious person by temperament, shaped by a year of difficulty into someone even more precise and measured than he had been. But he laughed at this, genuinely, and his mother laughed too, and for a minute the front room of the house in University Town, Peshawar, was simply a place where good things happened.

He moved to Islamabad the following month. His father drove him to the bus station. They did not speak much on the way — they are not a family that fills silences with words that are not necessary. But when the bus was announced and Nasir stood up to go, his father stood with him and put a hand on his shoulder for a moment. Just for a moment. Then he said: jaao. Go.

Nasir went.

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What This Chapter Is Really About

The employment crisis in Pakistan is real. The numbers behind it are staggering — the gap between graduates produced and formal jobs available, the skills mismatch, the sifarish system that pre-selects candidates before the official process begins, the economy's inability to absorb the talent it has spent two decades training.

But a book about the middle class is not a policy document, and this chapter is not a list of solutions. Other people are writing those documents. Some of them are even being read.

What this chapter is about is what it actually costs, at the level of a person, to be twenty-four years old in Pakistan with a degree and no job and a family that loves you and needs you to succeed and is trying not to show you that they are afraid it might take longer than any of you planned for.

It costs more than people who have not been through it understand. It costs confidence, slowly. It costs the relationship between effort and reward — a relationship that school built carefully over sixteen years and that the job market dismantles in a matter of months. It costs the graduate's sense of time, which starts to feel like it is moving in the wrong direction.

And then, in the thirteenth month or the eighth month or the eighteenth month, something happens. A job appears. A freelance client becomes regular. A contact comes through. A professor makes a phone call. Something shifts, and the person who was waiting begins moving.

They move differently from how they moved before the waiting. More carefully. With less of the easy confidence that the degree had given them and more of something harder and more reliable — the knowledge, absorbed through lived experience, that they can endure. That the inbox can stay empty for months and they can keep sending the applications. That the ceiling they grew up looking at can be looked at again without defeat.

This is the specific gift the employment crisis gives to the people who survive it. It is not a gift anyone asked for. But it is real, and it lasts, and in the years that follow — in the job taken and the career built and the family eventually supported — it shows.

Nasir is nine months into his job in Islamabad. He has had his six-month review. The salary went up by twelve thousand rupees. He called his father to tell him. His father said: *accha*. Then: are you eating properly? Nasir said yes. His father said: good.

The conversation was two minutes long. It contained everything.

Chapter Eight

Love and Life

Twenty to Twenty-Five

The phone buzzed on the table and he looked at it and he knew.

Not because the message said anything final — it said only: can we talk? But the way they had been for the past three weeks, the shortening of her responses and the growing length of the pauses between them, had been telling him something that he had been choosing not to fully understand. He picked up the phone. He set it back down. He picked it up again.

He was twenty-three years old and his name was Raza Qureshi, and he was sitting in the small room he rented in Lahore while working his first job, and he had known this girl for two years, and the knowing of her — the specific, daily, accumulated knowing that happens when two people are woven into each other's ordinary lives — was about to become past tense.

He called her. The conversation was twelve minutes long. He has not forgotten a single minute of it.

She said it carefully, with the kindness of someone who has rehearsed. She said: Raza, my family. She said: they have been asking. She said: you know I care about you. She said: but I can't keep asking them to wait when I don't know what we are waiting for.

He said: I just started this job. I am building something. Give me time.

She said: I know. I know you are. But — and here she stopped, and in the silence before she continued he heard the whole argument, already concluded, that had happened in her parents' house without him — but time isn't something I have the same way you do.

He did not argue after that. Not because he had nothing to say, but because he understood, in the way you understand things that have already been decided before the conversation begins, that the argument was already over and had been over before she dialed. He said: okay. She said: I'm sorry. He said: I know. And they stayed on the line for another minute without saying anything, and then she said his name once, softly, and he said goodbye, and that was the end of two years.

He sat in his room for a long time after. The light outside changed the way light changes in Lahore in the evening — orange first, then the blue that comes just before dark. He didn't eat. He didn't call anyone. He just sat there, in the specific company of himself that you are forced into at the end of something that mattered.

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What Love Costs When You Are Middle-Class

Love in the Pakistani middle class at this age is not simply an emotional experience. It is a negotiation conducted on multiple fronts simultaneously, and the middle-class young man — particularly — enters it at a structural disadvantage that is rarely named directly but is felt in every interaction.

He is twenty-one or twenty-two. He has a degree that cost his family years of sacrifice. He may have a job, or may be searching for one, or may be in the early months of one whose salary is not yet what it needs to be. He is not established. Establishment — the job with genuine security, the savings with genuine weight, the life with genuine ground under it — is something he is working toward but has not reached.

And he is in love, or he is falling in love, or he is being introduced to someone through the family's network, and in all three of these situations the same question is present: what can he offer? Not as an insult. As a practical inquiry, asked by families who love their daughters and who understand, from long experience, that love without ground under it eventually becomes a different kind of suffering.

The question is not unfair. That is the hardest part of it — the question is not unfair. A family that asks about financial stability before agreeing to a marriage is not being mercenary. They are being protective, in the way that families have learned to be protective across generations of watching marriages strain and break under economic pressure. They have seen what happens when love begins without foundation. They are trying to prevent the version of the story where love is not enough because the rent is due and the children need school fees and two people who started with the best intentions are now looking at each other across a table with the particular bitterness of people who feel they were promised more than they received.

But for the twenty-two-year-old man in the early months of a first job, standing at the threshold of a feeling that is real and specific and tied to a particular person — the question lands differently. It lands as: you are not ready. You are not enough. Come back when you have become something more than what you are.

And he has to figure out, in real time, without a guide, whether that assessment is correct or whether it is a wall he can argue with, and what the arguing costs, and what giving up costs, and which cost he is willing to pay.

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Lahore — The Months That Followed

Raza did not talk about the breakup to anyone for three weeks. This is not unusual. Middle-class Pakistani men of this generation have inherited a specific silence around romantic grief — a silence that comes from a culture that does not formally

acknowledge that the relationship existed in the first place, which means that its ending also cannot be formally mourned.

His friends knew something had changed. He was quieter at work, less present in the group chats, eating his lunch alone in a way that was new. His closest friend, Bilal, asked once, directly: bhai, sab theek hai? Raza said yes and Bilal, who knew him well enough to know when not to push, nodded and changed the subject. It was the correct decision and also, in some way, a small additional loneliness.

After three weeks he told Bilal. Not everything — not the twelve minutes or the orange light or the sitting in the dark. The outline. She ended it. Family pressure. The job is too new.

Bilal listened. Then he said: yaar, the same thing happened to my cousin. He was twenty-four and he had a decent salary and her family still said no because he rented and didn't own. He said it without bitterness — as a fact about the world, an observation about how the world works, not a condemnation. And somehow that framing — not this is unfair but this is how it is — helped more than sympathy would have.

This is how grief travels in the Pakistani middle-class male world. Not through direct expression, not through the language of feeling, but through the comparative anecdote. My cousin, my friend, my colleague. The thing you are carrying has been carried before. You are not alone in it. Nobody will say you are not alone — they will tell you about someone else who was also not alone, and you will understand the same thing by a different route.

Raza threw himself into work. This is the available option, and he took it the way you take the available option — not as a cure but as a container. He worked harder. He learned things outside his job description. He saved, carefully, with a specificity that was new — not because he had a clear plan but because saving felt like doing something about a problem that no amount of effort could directly address.

Six months after the end of two years, he was still thinking about her. Not constantly. Not in the way of the first weeks. But she was there, in the specific way that first serious love stays — not

as a wound exactly, more like a scar that you forget about and then catch yourself touching when something reminds you.

He saw on a mutual contact's social media that she had gotten engaged. He stared at the photograph for a longer time than was probably healthy. The man in the photograph had the look of someone settled — older, established in the way that Raza was not yet. He closed the app. He went back to the code he had been writing. He worked until midnight.

He doesn't blame her. He said this to me with an evenness that felt earned rather than performed — not the evenness of someone who has made peace with something but the evenness of someone who has genuinely understood it, which is a different and harder thing. "She made the practical choice," he said. "The practical choice is not the same as the wrong choice. I just happened to be the impractical one."

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The Rishta Season

At some point in the middle twenties — usually around twenty-three for women, twenty-four or twenty-five for men in the middle class — the rishta season begins. This is not a formal announcement. It announces itself through a shift in the household atmosphere, a new frequency of aunts calling and relatives visiting, a sense that something has been added to the household's agenda that wasn't there before.

The rishta process in the Pakistani middle class has its own specific economy, its own protocols, its own weight. A girl's family receives biodata — a document that is part resume and part commercial, listing height, complexion, education, father's profession, and family background in a standardized format that reduces a human being to a set of searchable attributes. The boy's family presents similarly. There are meetings, formal and careful, where everyone is dressed slightly better than usual and where the conversation moves in a register that is not quite natural — politely investigative, searching for information while appearing to be simply making conversation.

Kamran Malik went through this process for the first time at twenty-four. His mother had been building toward it for a year — mentioning girls she had heard of, asking his opinion on various hypothetical qualities in a wife in a way that he understood was not hypothetical. He was not opposed to the idea of marriage. He was aware, in the practical way of a middle-class young man who had been paying attention to the economics of his life, that the timing was difficult. He was earning seventy thousand rupees a month. Marriage in Pakistan — the wedding itself, the setting up of a home, the first year — costs what it costs, and what it costs for a middle-class family attempting to meet the social expectations of the occasion is roughly three to five times a year's salary, most of which is borrowed.

He went to three meetings in three months. The first was in a house in Gulberg where the drawing room was recently redecorated and the girl's father asked him, within the first ten minutes of formal conversation, where he saw himself in five years. He gave an answer that was honest and also, he suspected, insufficiently certain to satisfy a man whose primary concern was his daughter's financial security. He was not called back.

The second was better. The girl was quiet and observant and she asked him, when they were briefly alone in the way that these meetings sometimes permit, what he liked to do in the evenings. He said: I read, usually, or work on side projects. Sometimes I go for a walk if the week has been heavy. She said: what do you read? He named a few books. She nodded. She had read one of them. They talked about it for four minutes, which was the most natural conversation he had had in months. He thought about her for a week afterward.

He was not called back from that one either. The reason, relayed through his mother with the gentle indirectness of these communications, was that the girl's family had concerns about his earning potential relative to their daughter's family background. He received this information on a Tuesday evening and went to bed earlier than usual. He lay in the dark for a while thinking about the four-minute conversation about a book, and about the particular cruelty of a system in which that conversation — its ease, its mutuality, the small recognition in it — counted for nothing in the calculation.

The third meeting he cancelled. He told his mother he wasn't ready. She looked at him for a moment with the expression of a woman who has a great deal to say and is choosing not to say it, and then she said: theek hai, when you're ready. She made him tea. He drank it. They watched the news together in the comfortable silence that lives between a mother and a son who understand each other well enough not to require everything to be spoken.

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The Loneliness That Has No Name

There is a specific loneliness that belongs to the Pakistani middle-class man in his early twenties, and it is almost never talked about directly, which is part of what makes it specific.

He is at an age when the emotional needs are real — the need to be known, to be understood, to be in proximity to another person who sees him as more than his salary or his job title or his family's position. The need that, in other cultures and contexts, is met through a range of relationships and conversations and forms of social intimacy. But in his world, the infrastructure for meeting this need is thin.

He cannot talk to his parents about heartbreak — they are the people whose hopes he is trying not to disappoint, and romantic difficulty feels uncomfortably close to personal failure in a household that has invested so much in his success. He cannot talk to most of his male friends — not because they are unkind, but because the masculine culture of his generation does not provide easy language for this kind of conversation. The language available is the comparative anecdote: my cousin, my friend. The direct statement — I am struggling, I am lonely, I miss someone, I am afraid I am running out of time to become the person I need to be to be loved — this language sits in the throat, untranslated.

Asim Baig is twenty-four and works in a bank in Karachi. He grew up in Hyderabad and moved to Karachi two years ago for the job, which means he is in a city where his social world is largely professional and his evenings are largely solitary. He has

colleagues he likes. He has a group chat from university that is active and warm and that he participates in from a distance of four hundred kilometers. He has not told anyone in his life that he is lonely, including the people in the group chat.

"Lonely is the wrong word, actually," he said, when I used it. He thought about it. "It's more like — I'm busy, I'm not sitting alone feeling sorry for myself. I go to work, I go to the gym, I call my mother on Sundays. But there's a kind of — fullness that isn't there. Like a frequency that isn't being received. Do you understand what I mean?"

I said I did. He nodded, as if this confirmation mattered.

"I think about getting married and then I think about what I am earning and where I am living and I think: not yet. And then I think: but when is yet? What is the number? What is the thing I need to have before yet becomes now? Nobody tells you the number." He paused. "My father got married at twenty-four. He had nothing. They built it together. But my father's nothing was a different nothing from my nothing. His nothing could still become something on one salary. My nothing needs both of us working for three years before we can afford to breathe."

He said this without drama. It was a precise description of a material reality, delivered in the same tone he would use to describe a calculation at work. But inside the precision there was something else — a kind of tiredness that was not from work, a patience stretched thin in a direction that had no clear end.

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Karachi — What She Was Thinking

The story told in this chapter so far has been told from inside the male experience. This is partly because the book's perspective runs that way — the middle-class boy, his arc, his carrying. But the rishta season and the economics of love do not happen only to one side of the table. The woman sitting across from Kamran in the Gulberg drawing room has her own version of this story, and it is not simpler.

Sana Farooq was twenty-three when her parents began the process. She was a graduate of a public university in Karachi, working as a junior accountant at a mid-sized firm, earning forty-eight thousand rupees a month. She was, by every practical measure, a capable and independent person. She was also, by the logic of her family's social world, a girl whose time was a resource that required management.

The managing of her time was not cruel. Her mother spoke about it with genuine love — you are not getting younger, we want you settled, we want to know you are safe and cared for. These are not sinister motives. They are the motives of a woman who loves her daughter and whose understanding of safety and care is grounded in a generation's experience of what women without stable marriages can be exposed to.

But Sana was not afraid of being unsettled. She was not afraid of managing her own life. The thing she was afraid of — and she had not said this to her mother in these words — was ending up across a drawing room table from a man she didn't know and being asked to decide, in the space of an hour of formal conversation, whether she could build a life with him.

She had gone to four meetings in four months. She had found the experience, each time, disorienting in a way that she could not easily explain. Not unpleasant exactly — the men had been decent, polite, presenting their best selves with the careful attention of people who understand the stakes. But there was something in the format that made genuine connection almost impossible. The drawing room, the arranged chairs, the tea that appeared at exactly the right moment, the parents in the adjacent room who could hear everything — all of it conspired to make real conversation very difficult.

At the second meeting, a man had asked her what her hobbies were. She had said: I read, and I run, and I've been learning to cook properly, which I did not do when I was studying. He had nodded and said: cooking is important in a home. And something in the specific weight he put on the word cooking — the way it carried the assumption that the cooking he was thinking of was her cooking, in their home, for him — had told her something about how their life together would be organized.

She had not said no immediately. She had sat with it for a week, turning the conversation over, trying to be fair — maybe she had read too much into a single sentence. But the sentence stayed. The week passed. She told her mother she didn't feel a connection.

Her mother said: connection is something you build.

Sana said: I know. But you have to have a starting point.

This is the conversation that repeats itself in hundreds of Karachi and Lahore and Islamabad households every year, across the drawing rooms of the rishta season. The mother who believes connection is built. The daughter who believes you have to have a starting point. Both of them right, in different ways, about different things, and the distance between their rightnesses is not large but it is enough to make the conversation difficult every time it happens.

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What Getting Married Actually Costs

When two middle-class families decide to go forward with a marriage, the first formal discussion between the families is, almost always, about money. Not love — they assume love will sort itself out, or develop, or be sufficient. Money requires immediate negotiation.

A middle-class wedding in urban Pakistan — Lahore, Karachi, Islamabad — has an average total cost that sits somewhere between eight hundred thousand and two million rupees when you add all the events honestly: the mehndi, the nikah, the walima, the clothes for all of these, the jewelry, the dowry, the gifts, the hall, the food, the decoration, the photographer, the car, the honeymoon that is increasingly expected as a line item. For a family earning sixty to eighty thousand rupees a month, this is a year's income or more — frequently borrowed, frequently the source of a debt that sits on the new couple's beginning like a tax on hope.

The boy's side pays for the wedding events. The girl's side provides the jahez — the dowry of household goods, furniture,

appliances, sometimes cash — whose scale has inflated over the past two decades into something that middle-class families strain significantly to provide. A refrigerator, a washing machine, a dining table, bedroom furniture, kitchenware, bedding, and in many cases a television and a microwave and items whose inclusion or exclusion is tracked and noted and discussed among extended families with a specificity that would be darkly funny if the financial consequences weren't so real.

Bilal Zafar, Raza's friend, got married at twenty-six. He and his wife Madiha both worked. Combined income at the time of the marriage: one hundred and forty thousand rupees a month. The wedding cost approximately one point two million rupees — roughly nine months of combined take-home after expenses. They borrowed four hundred thousand from his father, who borrowed it from his brother. It took them two years to repay.

"I don't regret the wedding," Bilal said. "Madiha's family had expectations and my family had face and both of those things are real. I'm not going to pretend the expectations were wrong. But I wish—" He stopped. "I wish we had been able to start our life together without starting it already in debt. The first year was hard enough without that."

Madiha, when asked the same question separately, said: "The wedding was one day. The debt was two years. I have asked myself several times which one mattered more." She said it with humor rather than bitterness, which is how the middle class tends to process the things that are genuinely too expensive to be angry about.

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What Love Looks Like When It Works

This chapter has spent considerable time in the difficulty. It should spend some time in what actually holds.

Because love does hold, in the middle class. Not always easily, not always prettily, but with a durability that the economics tries to puncture and mostly fails to. The couples who make it are

not the ones who had the easiest beginnings. They are usually the ones who arrived at a shared understanding, early, that the life they were building together was going to require them to build it — actively, daily, in the unsexy practical way that building anything requires.

Raza, two years after the twelve-minute phone call, met a woman through his family's network. Her name was Hira. She was a schoolteacher from Lahore, two years younger, the daughter of a civil servant, practical and direct in the way of people who have thought carefully about what they want and don't want. Their first formal meeting lasted ninety minutes instead of the usual forty-five, because the conversation was real from the beginning — she asked him questions that required actual answers, not the performed version of himself he had been carrying to these meetings, and he found himself answering honestly, which surprised him.

On the way home he called Bilal and said: bhai, I think this one is different. Bilal, who had heard approximately this same sentence twice before, said: what makes it different? Raza said: she asked me what I was afraid of. Bilal was quiet for a moment. Then he said: that is a different kind of question.

They were engaged four months later. The wedding was small — both families agreed on this, partly from necessity and partly from a shared pragmatism that Raza found, as a quality, extremely attractive. The debt from the wedding was manageable. Not comfortable — there is no comfortable debt — but manageable.

What Raza remembers about the first year of marriage is not the romance of it, though there was that. What he remembers is the specific ordinary pleasure of being in a home with another person who is building the same thing you are building. The Sunday mornings when the finances were reviewed together — not with dread but with the shared focus of two people who have agreed that this is their shared project. The evenings when one of them was tired and the other made the dinner without being asked. The arguments, brief and resolved, about the small things that arguments in new marriages are always about, beneath which was the larger agreement about the larger things.

"She is my partner," he said. "Not in the performance of it. Actually. She knows what we earn. She knows what we owe. She knows what we are building toward. I don't carry that alone anymore." He paused. "I didn't know what that would feel like — to not carry it alone. I had been carrying it alone since I was about twelve years old."

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What These Years Are Really For

The years between twenty and twenty-five are not, in the middle-class Pakistani life, years of leisure or freedom or the easy self-discovery that certain books from other cultures suggest they should be. They are working years, in every sense — working at the job, working at the debt, working at understanding what you want from a life that is starting to become real in ways that the plans you made at seventeen did not fully anticipate.

Love arrives in these years in forms that are rarely simple. It arrives as a university relationship that ends because the girl's family has made a decision. It arrives as a rishta meeting in a drawing room where the chairs are arranged at precisely the wrong angle for genuine conversation. It arrives as the loneliness of a new city and a new job and a group chat that is warm but distant. It arrives, eventually, as something that holds — a person, a conversation, a shared understanding that this is worth building.

The middle-class young person who arrives at twenty-five on the other side of all of this is not the person who entered at twenty. Something has been lost — some lightness, some of the confidence that the future was simply going to arrive in the form it was hoped for. But something has been built too. A realism that is not cynicism. A patience that was not naturally present but had to be developed. An understanding of what actually matters, purchased at the going rate.

Raza is twenty-seven now. He has a job that is going well, a wife who is his partner in the actual sense of the word, a rented apartment in Lahore that is not large but is theirs. He still thinks about the twelve-minute phone call sometimes — not with pain

exactly, more with a kind of retrospective understanding. The person he was at twenty-three, sitting in the orange light of an evening that was changing, carrying something he had no language for and no one to give it to — he knows that person. He was necessary.

He does not wish that person away. He just no longer has to be him.

Women in the Middle

The Load-Bearing Walls

The household runs. This is the fact that everyone inside it takes for granted and that nobody has formally assigned to anyone. The meals appear. The children are dressed. The school bags are packed, the medication is refilled, the birthday of the mother-in-law is remembered and the call is made and the gift is sent. The relationship with the neighbor who had the falling-out three years ago is managed with a precision that prevents escalation without requiring surrender. The budget is tracked, not in a notebook on the kitchen counter but in a mental spreadsheet that runs continuously, updated in real time, consulting itself at the grocery store and at the school fee counter and at the moment the salary arrives and is immediately redistributed into its obligations.

None of this is invisible to the woman doing it. She sees it completely. What is invisible — what has been rendered invisible by the assumption that it is simply what women do — is the cost of it. The cognitive weight. The sustained, daily, unacknowledged labor of holding the household in her head at all times, in every room, even when she is at work, even when she is supposedly resting, even when she is sitting in a meeting at the office that requires her full professional attention and she is giving it her full professional attention and simultaneously remembering that the school sent home a form last week that needs to be signed and returned by Thursday.

The middle-class Pakistani woman carries the household the way a load-bearing wall carries a building: without announcement, without credit, from a position so fundamental to the structure that her presence is noticed only in the imagination of her absence. If the wall were removed, everything above it would fall. Because the wall holds, no one thinks about the wall.

This chapter thinks about the wall.

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Lahore — The Second Job That Has No Salary

Nadia Shaheen leaves for work at eight in the morning. She is thirty-one years old and a lecturer in the English department of a private university in Lahore. She teaches four courses a semester, holds office hours twice a week, sits on two departmental committees whose meetings extend reliably past their scheduled end time, and is currently writing a research paper that she works on between ten and midnight when the house is finally, briefly, quiet.

Before she leaves for work at eight she has made breakfast for her husband Wasim and their daughter Lina, who is four. She has settled a dispute about which shoes Lina is going to wear, which began at seven-fifteen and was resolved through a negotiation that required more strategic patience than any committee meeting she has sat in. She has reminded Wasim that Lina's pediatric appointment is Thursday at three and that he said he would take her because Nadia has a departmental seminar she cannot miss. He said he remembered. She made a note on the shared calendar anyway.

Wasim is an architect. He earns more than Nadia. He works long hours and brings genuine dedication to his work and he is, by any measure she would apply honestly, a good husband and a present father. He does his share of the visible domestic labor — dishes some evenings, Lina's bath on certain nights, grocery runs on Saturdays. He does his share of the visible work.

The invisible work is distributed differently.

Nadia holds the household in her head. Not because Wasim couldn't — he is an intelligent man with excellent organizational capacity, demonstrated daily in his professional life. But because she always has. Because in the early years of their marriage she had been the one with the more flexible schedule, and the one who had grown up watching her mother hold the household in her

head, and the one who had absorbed, through years of observation, the specific skill of domestic management that is passed from middle-class mothers to daughters with the same unconscious transmission as language. She learned it without being taught. She does it without being asked.

She does not resent Wasim. This is important to say plainly because the narrative about women's invisible labor sometimes requires a villain and Wasim is not a villain. He is a man who does not carry what he does not know he isn't carrying. This is not malice. It is the specific blind spot produced by a society that has organised domestic labor along gender lines for so long that the organization has become invisible to the people it benefits.

What Nadia sometimes feels — not resentment, not anger, but something more like a low, sustained tiredness that does not fully resolve with sleep — is the weight of being the person who holds the thing that cannot be put down. Wasim can leave for work without remembering Thursday's appointment because Nadia will remember. He can focus on his deadline because she will hold the rest of it. The household is held because she holds it. And the holding is constant, and it has no off switch, and it is never done.

She told me this one afternoon in her office at the university, between office hours and a committee meeting, eating a sandwich she had brought from home because the university cafeteria's food did not agree with her and cooking something the night before was faster than explaining this to anyone. She said: I love my life. I want to be clear about that. I love my work, I love Lina, I love Wasim. I am not unhappy. She paused. But I am tired in a way that is different from the tired that sleep fixes. It is the tired of never being fully off. Of being the one who holds the thing. She looked at the half-eaten sandwich. I don't know how to explain it to someone who has not felt it. I don't think it can be explained. It just has to be lived to be understood.

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Faisalabad — The Eldest

Huma Rashid is twenty-eight years old and she has been the head of her household since she was twenty-two. Not officially — there is no title, no ceremony, no formal transfer of responsibility. It happened the way most important things happen in middle-class Pakistani households: gradually, through necessity, without anyone deciding it.

Her father had a stroke when she was twenty-two and in the final year of her Commerce degree. He survived. He recovered partially — well enough to manage the ordinary requirements of daily life, not well enough to return to the work he had been doing, which was running a small import business that had been the household's primary income for fifteen years. The business needed management. There was no one else.

She had a younger brother, Rehan, who was seventeen and in the middle of his matriculation exams. She had a younger sister, Saba, who was fourteen. Her mother was a woman of great personal strength who had managed the household magnificently for two decades but who had never been involved in the financial or business side of the family's life and who was now, in the aftermath of her husband's stroke, learning simultaneously how to be the emotional anchor of a frightened household and how to understand documents she had never needed to understand before.

Huma stepped in. She graduated. She did not go to the accounting firm that had offered her a position. She went to her father's office instead.

She learned the business from scratch in six months — the suppliers, the clients, the margins, the documentation, the specific language of small import-export commerce that her father had acquired over twenty years and that she acquired by sitting in the office every day reading everything, asking questions of the two remaining staff members, calling the suppliers herself and explaining the situation and asking them to work with her while things stabilised.

Some of them did. Some of them did not. The business contracted. It did not collapse. This was its own achievement.

She has been running it for six years now. Rehan has a job — he completed his degree and is working at a bank in Lahore. He sends money home monthly, reliably, and this contribution is real and she is grateful for it. Saba is in her final year of university. Their father has improved to the point of active daily life, though not to the point of return to the business. Their mother manages the household with a competence that has grown, over the years, into a quiet authority that was not visible when the father was the household's official axis.

Huma has not married. She is twenty-eight. In the middle-class social world she inhabits, this is noticed. It is mentioned, not cruelly but consistently, by relatives who ask with genuine warmth and genuine obliviousness whether there is anyone on the horizon. She says: not at the moment. She says it without the defensiveness that the question sometimes produces in women her age who have not married from choice. She says it because it is simply true: there is not anyone at the moment. There has not been anyone at the moment for six years, because the moment has been fully occupied by the business and her brother's education and her sister's education and her father's medical management and her mother's learning and the business's slow stabilisation.

She does not describe herself as sacrificing. The word implies a cost that was consciously chosen, a thing given up with full knowledge of the giving. What she did was respond. A wall in the structure developed a fracture. She moved to support it. The building held. She is still there.

What she thinks about, sometimes, is what she would have done if the stroke had not happened at twenty-two. The accounting firm job. A career built over years in a professional environment. Travel, possibly — she had wanted to see places, she had this wanting since she was a girl and had not lost it, only deferred it. A marriage, perhaps, arrived at in the ordinary way rather than indefinitely postponed by the household's claims on her time and presence.

She does not think of these things with bitterness. She thinks of them the way you think of roads not taken — with a certain wistfulness that is honest but not consuming. The road she is on is real. The business exists. Her family is stable. Her father is alive and improving. Her siblings are building lives. These things

happened because she did what she did. She is thirty years old. The deferred life is not necessarily the cancelled life.

She keeps her passport current. She renews it every ten years without fail. She has never used it. It sits in the drawer with the business documents and the medical records and the insurance paperwork that she manages with the same systematic precision she brings to everything else.

It is there. The passport is there. That is sufficient, for now.

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The Drawing Room, From the Other Chair

The rishta meeting looks different depending on which chair you are sitting in.

Chapter Eight described it from the boy's side — the formal drawing room, the arranged chairs, the tea that appeared at the right moment, the conversation that moved in a register that was not quite natural. It described Kamran's experience of the four-minute conversation about a book, and the particular cruelty of a system in which that conversation counted for nothing in the final calculation.

From the girl's side, the meeting has a different texture. Not easier — different. The boy is being evaluated for his earning potential, his family background, his trajectory. The girl is being evaluated for all of these things and also for her appearance, her manner, her perceived disposition toward the domestic arrangement that the marriage will require. She is being assessed for suitability in a way that has more dimensions than the boy's assessment and that touches, more directly, on who she is as a person rather than what she has achieved.

Zara Anwar is twenty-five and has been to six rishta meetings in eight months. She has a master's degree in economics from a good university. She works at a research organization in Islamabad and earns sixty-eight thousand rupees a month. She is, by any measure, a capable and independent person who has built something real in the years since her degree.

She described the meetings with a precision that suggested she had spent time understanding exactly what was happening in them.

At the first meeting, she said, the boy's mother spent forty minutes asking her mother about the family's background, property, and connections while Zara and the boy sat across from each other making careful conversation that they both understood was being evaluated from the adjacent room. She felt, during this conversation, like a person being assessed for a position whose requirements had not been fully disclosed.

At the third meeting, a boy asked her directly what her plans were regarding work after marriage. She said she intended to continue working. He said: of course, of course, but perhaps part-time once children come? She said she had not thought about it yet. He said: it's just that my mother feels it's important for the children to have the mother present. She said: I see. She went home and told her own mother that she had not felt a connection.

At the fifth meeting, she met someone who asked her about her research. They talked about it for twenty minutes. He was interested — genuinely, not performatively. She drove home thinking that this one might be different.

He called her family back and said he admired her ambition but his family was looking for someone who was settled in her priorities. Her mother relayed this with the gentle indirectness of these communications. Zara sat with it for a day. She understood that settled in her priorities meant willing to place his family's priorities above her professional ones, and that her ambition had read as a risk rather than an asset.

She is still going to meetings. She has not given up on the process — she is pragmatic enough to understand that this is how marriages are made in her world and that withdrawing from the process is not a solution. But she goes to each one now with a specific clarity about what she is and is not willing to negotiate, and this clarity has made the meetings both more efficient and more lonely. Efficient because she can identify earlier which ones will not work. Lonely because efficiency is not what she was hoping the process would feel like.

What she wants — and she says this directly, without the apologetic framing that women of her generation sometimes use when stating what they want — is a person who looks at her full life and sees it as complete rather than as something that will need to be partially dismantled to fit the shape of a marriage. She does not think this is an unreasonable want. She also knows, from eight months of meetings, that it is not the easiest want to satisfy in the market she is working within.

She is twenty-five. The meetings continue. She goes, she listens, she drives home, she considers. She is patient in the way of a person who knows what she wants and has decided that patience is more useful than compromise on the things that matter.

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Karachi — What She Wanted Before

Rukhsana's mother, Nasreen Akhtar, is fifty-four years old. She taught primary school for eleven years and left when Rukhsana's younger brother was born and the logistics of two children and a teaching job and a household in a city where domestic help had become unreliable and expensive simply did not add up to a manageable life. She has not worked since.

This is a fact she states without drama. She has had twenty-three years to arrive at a relationship with this fact, and the relationship she has arrived at is complicated in the way of things that have been lived with long enough to develop multiple dimensions.

She had wanted to be a principal. This was not a vague ambition — it was specific and grounded. She had been a good teacher, the kind who remembered her students' names twenty years later and who had an instinct for which child needed what kind of attention. Her school's principal had mentioned, in the year before she left, that Nasreen was the kind of teacher the school would want to keep and develop. She had understood this as a door opening.

Then she left. The door, she assumed, remained behind her, available if she returned.

She did not return. The years arranged themselves differently from how she had imagined they would arrange themselves when she told herself she would go back when the children were older. When they were older, the gap in her CV was significant. The education sector had changed. The confidence that had been intact when she left had, over years of not working, undergone a quiet erosion that she had not fully noticed until she sat down once to write an application and found that her hands were not entirely steady.

She did not send the application.

What she built instead was a household of extraordinary quality — not in the material sense, though it was comfortable enough. In the relational sense. Her children grew up in a house where they were seen and known and understood with a precision that required the full-time attention of a person of her intelligence. Rukhsana, her daughter, is the woman she is in significant part because of what Nasreen created in those years. This is real. It is not nothing. It is, in certain ways, more than a principalship.

But it is not the principalship.

Nasreen thinks about this in the way of a person who has made peace with something without being entirely at peace with it. She thinks about it when she is at Rukhsana's house and Rukhsana comes home from the university where she teaches, the university where she is doing things that Nasreen had the ability to do and did not get to do, and she watches her daughter with a love that is uncomplicated and also, in a register so quiet she does not always hear it herself, with something that is not quite envy and is not quite pride but lives in the space between them.

She told me this on a Tuesday afternoon. She had come to Rukhsana's apartment to watch Aiza while Rukhsana and Zubair went for their evening walk. Aiza was asleep in the other room. The apartment was quiet. Nasreen held her tea with both hands.

She said: I think I would have been a good principal. She said it simply, without self-pity, the way you state a fact about

yourself that is true and has always been true and that the world simply did not fully use. I think I would have been very good at it.

I said: I think you're right.

She nodded. She drank her tea. From the other room came the small sounds of Aiza shifting in her sleep.

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The Question That Finally Has Time

There is a moment that comes for the middle-class woman in her mid-forties — if she is lucky enough to reach it with the primary demands of the household reduced, the children grown toward independence, the most acute phase of the juggling behind her — when she is sitting somewhere quiet and she hears, for the first time in years, the sound of her own thinking.

It is disorienting. She has been thinking constantly for twenty years, but the thinking has been about other things — the children, the budget, the household, the management of the ten directions the family pulls simultaneously. The thinking that she hears now, in the quiet, is different. It is personal. It is the thinking that was always there but could never get the floor.

Samia Baig is forty-six. Her children are nineteen and sixteen. Her husband Khalil is a government officer, stable and present in the careful, economical way of men of his generation. The household runs. The crisis years — the early childhood years, the school fee years, the simultaneous management of work and household and aging parents and children's education — those years are not entirely over but they have passed their peak. There is more room than there was.

She has started painting again.

She had painted before marriage — not casually, but seriously, with the focused attention of someone for whom the work was real. She had won a competition at university. She had had a professor who told her she had something genuine and that she should pursue it. She had understood, at twenty-two, that

pursuing it in the way the professor meant was not compatible with the life she was also choosing — the marriage, the household, the middle-class trajectory that required both of them earning and neither of them taking extended time for things that did not pay.

She put the painting away. Not permanently — she told herself it was temporary, the way you tell yourself the things you are putting away are temporary. For twenty years it was temporary. The canvases were in the storage room behind the winter clothes.

Last year her younger child, Amir, started university. The house got quieter. Samia went into the storage room for something unrelated and found the canvases behind the winter clothes and stood there looking at them for a long time.

She set one up in the bedroom. She bought new paint — the old ones had dried solid in their tubes. She sat in front of the blank canvas for three evenings without touching it, reacquainting herself with the feeling of being in front of a blank thing that was waiting for her specifically.

Then she painted. It was bad — technically unsteady, the hand not remembering what it knew twenty years ago. She didn't mind. She painted over it and started again. The second one was better. The third one she kept.

Khalil looked at the third painting on the bedroom wall and said: that's good. She said: you think? He said: yes. He went to change his clothes for dinner. He did not elaborate. She did not need him to elaborate. She knew it was good. She just wanted to hear that he saw it.

She is painting every week now. Not every day — the household still requires the things it requires, and she is still the person who holds most of them. But every week there is an evening that is hers. An evening where the canvas is set up and the paint is out and the thing she was before she became everything else is allowed to be present.

Her daughter, who is nineteen and visiting one weekend, saw the paintings lined up against the bedroom wall — there were seven of them now — and said: Ammi, you're actually good. Samia

said: I used to be better. Her daughter said: you could get better again. Samia said: yes. Her daughter said: then why don't you? And Samia looked at the seven paintings and thought: why don't I.

She has enrolled in an evening class at a studio in the city. It starts next month. She has not told anyone yet except her daughter. She is not sure why she has not told anyone. Perhaps because the class is hers, and some things are better held privately until they are certain, until the claiming of them is complete.

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The Load-Bearing Wall

The women in this chapter — Nadia and Huma and Zara and Nasreen and Samia — are not exceptional. They are the middle-class Pakistani woman in her ordinary forms: the professional managing two jobs with one salary, the daughter who became the household's axis when the axis broke, the woman navigating the rishta process with intelligence and patience and a private fury she has learned not to show in the room, the mother who gave up the principalship, the woman who found her paintings behind the winter clothes.

They are extraordinary in the way that ordinary people doing extraordinary things without recognition are extraordinary. They are the load-bearing walls. They hold the structures that the rest of this book has been describing — the structures of households and marriages and children's educations and aging parents' care and extended family relationships and all the invisible infrastructure of a life that appears, from the outside, to simply work.

The book has spent nine chapters inside the middle-class life without fully acknowledging who is doing the most essential work of holding it together. This chapter is that acknowledgment. Not as a corrective and not as an accusation — not a verdict on the men in the book who have been the primary lens, and not an argument that the women are victims, because they are not. They are the most capable people in the story.

It is an acknowledgment of what is true. The household runs because she holds it. The children are who they are because she gave them the kind of attention that requires a person of her quality to be entirely present. The marriage has the texture it has because she has managed, alongside everything else, the emotional maintenance of a relationship that two people are building simultaneously while both of them are also doing five other things.

She does this because she loves her family. Because the culture shaped her toward it. Because in many cases there is no one else. Because the alternative — a household that nobody holds, a structure without a load-bearing wall — is not something she is willing to allow. She is not willing to allow it because the people inside the structure are the people she loves most.

This is the middle-class woman's particular position. She is the wall. She is also the person living in the building. She holds it because she is inside it, because letting it fall would mean letting herself fall too, along with everyone she has built her life around.

The wall does not ask for recognition. It is too busy holding.

But it deserves to be seen. To be named. To have someone say: I know what you are carrying. I know it is not nothing. I know the house stands because you do.

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What Comes Next

Nadia finishes her committee meeting and goes home. She picks up Lina from her mother-in-law's. She makes dinner — quickly, with the efficiency of someone who has learned to cook the way she does everything, without waste of time or motion. She and Wasim eat together after Lina is asleep. They talk about their days. He tells her about a project. She tells him about the paper she is trying to finish. He says: when is it due? She says: end of the month. He says: is there anything I can do? She thinks about this for a real moment. She says: if you could do school drop-off on Thursdays that would help. He says: done. She says: thank you.

These negotiations — small, practical, arrived at through the slow accumulation of two people learning to see each other more clearly — are how things change. Not through grand declarations. Not through a single conversation that resolves everything. Through the small adjustments. The Thursdays. The done.

Huma renews her passport in April. The business is running. Saba graduated last year with a good result. Their father had a good month — better mobility, better energy. Huma sat with him on the roof one evening last week and they talked about the business, which he follows now from a distance with the specific attention of a man who built something and handed it to someone and is watching it continue. He said: you've done well. She said: I learned from you. He said: no. He shook his head. You learned yourself. You figured it out yourself. She didn't argue. They sat in the warm evening and the city was loud below them and neither of them said anything else for a while.

Samia's evening class starts in three weeks. She has told Khalil. He said: good. She said: you don't mind? He said: why would I mind? She said: I don't know. I suppose I thought — He said: go. Paint. It's your time.

It's your time. Four words from a man of his generation who did not grow up in a household where women's time was a concept that was formally named. He said it simply, as a fact. She stored it carefully, in the place where she stores the things she is going to need.

Nasreen is at Rukhsana's apartment every Tuesday and Thursday, watching Aiza. She brings biryani sometimes, the kind she makes better than anyone, the recipe from her own mother that she has been making for thirty years and that fills the apartment with a smell that Aiza associates with Tuesdays and Thursdays and will associate with them, probably, for the rest of her life.

Aiza wakes from her nap and finds her grandmother in the kitchen. She climbs onto the counter stool and watches Nasreen work. She says: Nani, what are you making? Nasreen says: can't you tell from the smell? Aiza says: biryani. Nasreen says: very good. Aiza says: will you teach me? Nasreen stops. She looks at her

granddaughter — this child with her mother's eyes and her father's precise attention and her own particular quality of presence that is entirely hers. She says: yes. I will teach you everything.

She means the biryani. She means everything else too.

Chapter Nine

The Building Years

Twenty-Five to Thirty

The first real argument about money happens earlier than either of them expected.

Bilal and Madiha had been married for four months. They were living in a rented apartment in Gulshan-e-Iqbal — two bedrooms, one of which they used as a bedroom and the other they called a study but which was mostly where things went when they didn't know where else to put them. The apartment was on the third floor of a building where the lift worked sometimes and the water pressure dropped without warning in the evenings, which Bilal had known before they moved in and had not mentioned prominently in his description of the place. Madiha had found out about the water pressure on the third day.

The argument was about the refrigerator. Specifically, it was about whether the refrigerator that Madiha's family had included in the jahez — a ten-year-old Dawlance that hummed at a frequency Bilal found deeply irritating — should be replaced with a new one or whether they should wait until their savings were in a better position. Bilal said wait. Madiha said the humming is affecting her sleep. Bilal said it's a sound, you get used to sounds. Madiha said she had been getting used to things her whole life and

she was tired of getting used to things. Bilal said that was not a fair way to frame a conversation about a refrigerator.

The refrigerator stayed. They did not speak to each other in complete sentences for two days, which in a two-bedroom apartment with a humming Dawlance is its own specific form of claustrophobic suffering. On the third day Madiha came home from work with a roll of foam weatherstripping she had found at a hardware shop, which she applied to the back panel of the refrigerator after watching a YouTube video. The humming reduced by approximately sixty percent. She did not announce this as a victory. She made dinner. They ate. He asked how her day was. She told him. That was the end of it.

Later — much later, years later, when they had a different refrigerator in a different apartment and the foam weatherstripping story had become one of the small legends of their marriage — Bilal said: that is when I understood who she was. Not the arguing. The weatherstripping.

This is what the building years look like from the inside. Not dramatic. Not the version that gets told at family gatherings, where the narrative runs from wedding to success with a few vague gestures at difficulty in between. The real version is smaller and more specific and more human than that. It is the humming refrigerator and the two days of incomplete sentences and the foam weatherstripping and the dinner eaten together on the third evening, which was both ordinary and, in its quiet resumption of the life they had agreed to build, something like grace.

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The Decade That Decides

The years between twenty-five and thirty are when the middle-class Pakistani life stops being a preparation and starts being a thing itself. The degree is done. The first job is behind. The question of who you are going to marry has been answered or is being answered or is being actively deferred for reasons that feel sound in the moment. The abstractions of ambition — I will have, I will become, I will build — are beginning to collide with the

concrete reality of what is actually possible with the income that actually exists and the costs that actually accrue.

This collision is the defining experience of the building years. It is not always comfortable. The gap between what was planned and what is happening is, in many cases, considerable. The career that was supposed to be advancing is advancing more slowly than expected. The house that was supposed to be owned is still being rented. The savings that were supposed to be growing have been partially consumed by the wedding debt or the medical expense or the family obligation that arrived without appointment and left a mark on the budget that is still being absorbed.

And yet things are also genuinely being built. Not at the pace that was imagined, not in the shape that was drawn in the notebooks of the teenage years. But built. A professional identity that is real and specific. A marriage that is discovering its own language. A household that has, despite its rental status and its secondhand furniture and its refrigerator that was foam-weatherstripped into submission, become home.

The middle-class person at twenty-eight is, if they have been paying attention, considerably wiser than the person they were at twenty-two. They know what they can and cannot do. They know what they will and will not sacrifice. They know the difference between a problem that needs solving and a discomfort that needs enduring, and they have developed, through the specific curriculum of the past six years, a reasonably accurate ability to tell the two apart.

This wisdom is not free. It was purchased with failed plans and revised expectations and the particular education of living inside a budget that does not always cooperate with life's calendar. But it is real, and it is theirs, and in the decade ahead it will be the most useful thing they own.

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Lahore — The Notebook on the Kitchen Counter

Zubair Ahmed and his wife Rukhsana kept a notebook on the kitchen counter. It was a plain notebook, spiral-bound, the kind sold at any stationery shop for forty rupees. In it they wrote down everything: income, expenses, what was owed and to whom, what was being saved toward and how far they had gotten.

They had started the notebook in the third month of their marriage, after the first real financial disagreement — not the refrigerator level, something larger, involving a hospital bill for Rukhsana's mother that had arrived without warning and consumed the money they had set aside for two months of loan repayment. They had argued, briefly and without resolution, about whose fault this was, which was the wrong argument because it was nobody's fault, and they had both understood this mid-argument and stopped, and sat at the kitchen table, and Zubair had said: we need to see it all in one place.

The notebook became the most important object in the apartment. Not sentimentally — practically. On the first of every month they sat at the kitchen table together and went through it. Income: Zubair's salary from the pharmaceutical company, ninety-four thousand rupees. Rukhsana's salary from the school where she taught, forty-two thousand. Total: one hundred and thirty-six thousand. Rent: thirty-eight thousand. Loan repayment: twenty thousand. Groceries: approximately twenty-two thousand, varying by month. Utilities: twelve to sixteen thousand depending on season. Both sets of parents received money monthly — Zubair's five thousand, Rukhsana's three thousand, non-negotiable line items that predated the marriage and would continue until circumstances changed. School fees for Rukhsana's younger brother, which her family could not cover alone: eight thousand.

After all of this, in a good month, they saved between fifteen and twenty thousand rupees. In a bad month — and there were bad months, months when the car needed work or someone got sick or a relative's wedding required a gift beyond what was planned — they saved nothing, or dipped into the savings account that was supposed to be growing and found it growing more slowly than the notebook suggested it should be.

They had a goal written on the inside front cover of the notebook. It said: own a home before thirty-five. Zubair was

twenty-seven. Rukhsana was twenty-five. The goal required a down payment of roughly two million rupees for the kind of property they were considering — a modest apartment in a decent area, nothing grand. At their current savings rate, optimistically, they would reach two million in approximately eight years. Which would make Zubair thirty-five. Which was, by the inside-cover standard, just barely possible.

They did not discuss this mathematics often. It was there, visible, in the notebook, available whenever either of them needed to look at it. But staring at it too long produced a particular kind of low-grade despair that was not useful, and they had both learned, by the third year of the notebook, that some things are better acknowledged and filed than dwelt upon.

What they dwelt upon instead was the incremental. The month the savings account crossed five hundred thousand for the first time. The month Zubair's salary was reviewed and increased by fourteen thousand — they wrote it in the notebook in pen and then Rukhsana drew a small star next to the number, which was not a thing she had planned to do, it just happened, and which Zubair still thinks about when he opens to that page. The month they paid off the last of the wedding loan, which they celebrated by eating at a restaurant they had been meaning to go to for two years but kept deciding was not the right time.

"The restaurant was fine," Rukhsana said, when she described this evening. She said it with a smile that was specifically fond, the kind that belongs to memories that are not grand but are yours. "The biryani was honestly not as good as the one I make at home. But we sat there for two hours and we talked about things that weren't the notebook, and that felt — I don't know. Like something we had earned."

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What Renting Means and What It Doesn't

There is a specific social weight attached to renting in Pakistan's middle-class world that is worth examining directly,

because it shapes these years in ways that go beyond the purely financial.

In the cultural understanding of the middle-class household, home ownership is not simply a financial milestone. It is a statement of arrival. It means the family has a place — a permanent, unchallengeable place — in the physical landscape of the city. The owned home is different from the rented home in a way that has nothing to do with the quality of the walls or the size of the rooms. It has to do with what it represents: stability that is not contingent, ground that cannot be taken away, the right to put a nail in the wall without asking anyone's permission.

The person who still rents at twenty-eight or twenty-nine is, in some social circles, understood to be still en route. Not arrived. Renting is a transitional state, in this understanding, and the length of the transition reflects something about the person's trajectory.

Imtiaz Hussain is twenty-nine and has been renting in Rawalpindi for four years. He is not bothered by renting in any practical sense — his apartment is comfortable, his landlord is reasonable, and the rent is what it is. What bothers him, he says, is what he has to do with the question at family gatherings. Specifically his father's side, where there is a cousin who bought a plot in a housing scheme three years ago and mentions it with the regularity of someone who has found a subject that reflects well on them.

"He doesn't say anything directly," Imtiaz said. "He talks about his plot. How the value has gone up. What he's planning to build. He asks about the area I'm renting in with this specific interest that is not actually interest." He paused. "My father doesn't say anything either. But I know he feels it. He worked his whole life so his son would own something. I am thirty in five months and I own nothing that can't fit in a car."

He said this without self-pity — the middle-class person, by twenty-nine, has had enough practice with situations like this to describe them without collapsing into them. But the feeling was real and it was there and it occupied space in his life that he would have preferred to use for something else.

The truth about renting — the truth that the cultural understanding does not fully accommodate — is that in a city like Rawalpindi or Lahore in 2024, the decision to rent rather than buy is frequently not a decision at all. Property prices in urban Pakistan have risen at a rate that has consistently outpaced middle-class salary growth. The plot that his cousin bought three years ago in a housing scheme cost four million rupees then. It is worth six million now. Imtiaz's salary has grown by twenty percent in three years. The gap between where he is and where property ownership begins has not narrowed — it has widened, while he has been working as hard as he knows how to work.

This is not a failure of Imtiaz. It is a failure of the gap between a generation's expectations and the economy they were handed. His father owned a house. His father's generation bought property in cities that were growing rather than exploding, at prices that bore a comprehensible relationship to salaries. The generation now in its late twenties was handed a different city with different mathematics and the same cultural expectation of arrival.

Imtiaz is saving. The notebook equivalent in his household is a spreadsheet on his phone that his wife Samia updates weekly. They are not giving up. But they have quietly renegotiated, between themselves and without announcing it to anyone, the timeline of the inside-cover goal. Thirty-five is no longer the target. Forty might be more honest. They have not written this revision anywhere. Some revisions are better held in the mind than committed to paper.

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The Baby at the Budget Meeting

When the first child arrives, the notebook on the kitchen counter acquires new urgency.

Zubair and Rukhsana's daughter, Aiza, was born in the fourth year of their marriage. She was born healthy and small and with the specific, demanding quality of a person who has arrived in the world and requires it to reorganize itself immediately. The

household did reorganize — sleeping schedules, meal times, the distribution of energy that had previously been divided between two people and their individual needs and was now divided between three people, one of whom had needs that acknowledged no system and respected no prior arrangement.

The financial reorganization was also immediate. Rukhsana went on maternity leave — two months paid, then a third unpaid. During the third month, the household ran on Zubair's salary alone for the first time. He had known this was coming. He had planned for it, in the notebook, three months in advance. The planning helped and was also insufficient, which is the consistent experience of planning in the middle-class household: it helps and is also insufficient.

The things they had not planned for: Aiza's minor health issue in her third week that required two visits to a private pediatrician because the government hospital's outpatient department had a three-hour queue and the baby was sick and the three-hour queue felt untenable. Each visit: four thousand rupees. Not enormous. But not in the notebook.

The things they had not planned for: the cost of infant formula after Rukhsana's milk supply proved insufficient — a gap she had not been told to expect and that she took much harder than anyone anticipated, quietly, in the way women take things that feel like personal failures and are not personal failures but feel that way anyway in the hormonal upheaval of new motherhood. The formula: eight thousand rupees a month.

The things they had not planned for: the sleep. The specific, accumulated deficit of sleep that changes the quality of everything — the patience available for each other, the capacity for the ordinary emotional labor of marriage, the ability to sit at the kitchen table on the first of the month and go through the notebook with the focus and goodwill that the exercise requires. The sleep deficit has no line in the budget. It costs nothing in rupees and everything in the person.

Three months after Aiza's birth, Rukhsana went back to work. The decision was not difficult in the sense of being hard to make — they needed the income, the calculation was clear. It was difficult in the sense of being something she had not fully

imagined feeling until she felt it: leaving a ten-week-old with her mother-in-law in the morning and going to a classroom and teaching other people's children with the specific divided attention of a woman who is professionally present and privately somewhere else entirely.

Her mother-in-law was a good woman who loved Aiza without qualification. This helped enormously and was also, somehow, not quite enough — not a failure of the grandmother but a reflection of what Rukhsana had not known she would feel, which was the feeling of missing the thing you chose to leave, even when the leaving was right.

She taught her classes. She came home. She fed the baby. She ate dinner, usually standing up because Aiza was in her arms and the sitting felt complicated. She slept in the segments that Aiza allowed. She went back to work the next morning. This was the building year in its most concentrated form: not building upward, not building toward, but building the capacity to hold everything at once without dropping the thing that mattered most.

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The Career That Is Also Happening

Alongside the marriage and the baby and the notebook and the rented apartment and the refrigerator and the plot-owning cousin at the family gathering — alongside all of this — the career is also happening.

The career in the building years looks different from what it looked like in the early twenties. The urgency has shifted. In the early twenties, the career question was: can I get work? In the building years, the question is: is this work taking me somewhere? The distinction matters because the answer requires a different kind of honesty.

Hassan Mirza is twenty-eight and has been at the same firm for four years. He is good at his job. He has been told he is good at his job, in the specific but ultimately uncommitted way that Pakistani organizations tell their employees they are valued —

praise at the performance review, a raise that beats inflation if he's lucky and that does not beat inflation in the years when the organization is having a difficult time, which is more years than not. He is not promoted. He is not exactly passed over — there is no position that exists to be passed over for. He exists in a horizontal plane that he is good at navigating but that does not go up.

He has thought about leaving. He has thought about leaving approximately once a week for the past eighteen months. What stops him is a combination of things that he lists, when asked, with the methodical honesty of someone who has spent considerable time understanding his own situation: the health insurance that covers his wife and son, which he could not easily replicate in the uncertainty of a job switch. The relationship with his manager, who is a decent person who would take it personally. The three months it might take to find something, during which the notebook would be under pressure. The general inertia of a life that is running, if not beautifully then adequately, and the very real cost of disrupting something adequate in search of something better.

"I know I should probably move," he said. He was sitting in the cafeteria of his office building during his lunch break, eating a paratha he had brought from home in a tiffin box because the cafeteria food is expensive and not particularly good. "I know the market would pay me more somewhere else. But knowing and doing are different things when you have a mortgage — well, rent — and a kid in nursery school and parents who need something from you every month."

He paused. He looked at the tiffin box. He said: "My father worked at the same government office for thirty years. He used to say: don't change boats in the middle of the river. I think about that. And then I think: but what if the boat isn't going anywhere? How long do you wait to see if it moves?"

He did not have an answer for this. He went back to work after lunch. He is still at the same firm. Last month he had a conversation with a recruiter who reached out through LinkedIn. He replied. He has not told his wife yet that he replied. He is not sure why not. Perhaps because replying is not yet a decision, and he needs to understand what it is before he can explain it.

Becoming the Parents

Somewhere in the building years, without formal announcement, the middle-class person crosses a threshold. They become, fully and without residual ambiguity, the adult generation. Their parents are older now, more visibly so, in ways that sometimes arrive as a surprise even though they should not.

The father who was the authority, the solver of problems, the man with the salary slip and the notebook — he is now sometimes the one who phones with a question about something he doesn't understand, something digital or bureaucratic or medical, that his son or daughter has the language for and he does not. The mother who managed the household with a precision that her children absorbed and took for granted — she is now, occasionally, managing something that is harder than a household, which is the business of getting older in a body that does not always cooperate.

Umar Siddiqui is twenty-seven and his father had a mild cardiac episode last year. Mild — the doctors used that word, and it is accurate, and Umar is grateful for it. But mild did not mean without cost. The immediate cost was the hospital — the tests, the nights, the private room that the government ward could not provide in the way his family needed it to be provided, the cardiologist whose fee is the kind of fee that middle-class people pay and then do not discuss at the dinner table because discussing it would require acknowledging exactly how much the margin for error has narrowed.

The ongoing cost is different. It is the awareness, daily, that his parents are not going to be fine indefinitely. That the people who were the structure of his world are now, in some partial way, depending on the structure he is building. His mother asks him about things she used to handle alone. His father takes medication that must be tracked and purchased and refilled and that Umar has set reminders for on his phone because he knows his father will not set the reminders himself.

He does this without resentment. This needs to be said clearly, because the narrative of the burdened child sometimes implies resentment, and in Umar's case — in most of the cases like his that I encountered — the resentment is simply not the primary feeling. The primary feeling is something more like tenderness, and something more like purpose, and underneath both of those, if he is honest, something more like fear: the specific fear of love that knows its object is not permanent.

"My father," Umar said, after a pause that was not rhetorical but genuine — the pause of someone arriving at something they have not fully put into words before. "He worked forty years so I could have choices he didn't have. I think about that a lot. Not as pressure. Just as — I want the choices to have been worth it. For him. I want him to see something from all of that work."

He looked at his hands on the table. Then he looked up. "He's fine, alhamdulillah. He plays cricket with the neighborhood boys on Sunday mornings. Cardiac episode and he plays cricket." He almost laughed. "He's more stubborn than the condition."

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What the Building Is

By the end of the building years — by twenty-nine or thirty, when the next decade begins its own accounting — the middle-class person sits down, metaphorically, and looks at what exists.

It is rarely what was planned. The timeline has shifted. The apartment that was supposed to be owned is still rented. The savings are real but not yet at the inside-cover number. The career is moving, but not at the speed that was imagined at twenty-two when the imagining was not yet constrained by reality.

But there is something there. Something that was not there five years ago.

There is a household — specific, functional, known. There is a person who sleeps in the same bed, who knows the budget and the worry and the hope, who weatherstripped the refrigerator

when the alternative was spending money they didn't have. There is, in many cases, a child who is growing and who has no awareness of the financial machinery that keeps the house running and who asks for a story before sleep with a confidence that someone will tell it that is the most complete form of trust that one human being can show another.

There is professional knowledge — not the theoretical knowledge of the degree but the real, specific, hard-earned knowledge of someone who has been working for five or six years inside a field and knows now what they didn't know then: what the work actually is, what they are good at, where the edges of their competence are, what the next five years might look like if they make the right moves.

And there is a self — a more accurate, less romantic, more durable self than the one that entered these years. The self that knows its own patterns. That knows what it can carry and what it needs to set down. That has been humbled in the specific ways that life humbles people who are paying attention, and that has also been strengthened in the ways that humbling produces strength rather than defeat.

Zubair and Rukhsana's notebook is in its fourth volume. The first three are in the drawer of the bedside table — Rukhsana keeps them, though neither of them could explain exactly why. The fourth is on the kitchen counter with the pen clipped to the cover. The savings are at one million, two hundred thousand rupees. They are three years from the down payment on the inside-cover goal. Aiza is three years old and she has her mother's face and her father's habit of examining things closely before forming an opinion, which at three years old looks like standing in front of the refrigerator for a long time before deciding what she wants.

The refrigerator does not hum anymore. A repairman they found through a neighbor replaced a worn compressor gasket two years ago, and the foam weatherstripping is still there, doing its part, and the refrigerator runs quietly now, the way a good thing runs when it has been tended to.

The Foundation That Does Not Look Like One

The building years do not announce their own significance. They happen in kitchens and offices and rented apartments and hospital waiting rooms and at dining tables where the first of the month means the notebook comes out. They happen in the two days of incomplete sentences after an argument about a refrigerator and in the evening on the third day when dinner is made and eaten and the ordinary resumption of a shared life is its own kind of statement.

They are not glamorous. They are rarely the stories that get told at celebrations — those stories tend to begin later, once the building is visible enough to be pointed at. The building years themselves, the years of foundation, are mostly invisible to everyone except the people doing the building.

But the foundation is real. It is the most real thing in the middle-class life — more real than the aspirations that preceded it, more real than the milestones that will follow. It is built from the actual material of a life: the compromises and the adjustments and the revised timelines and the foam weatherstripping and the notebook that grows to four volumes and the refrigerator that stops humming and the child who asks for a story before sleep with the confidence of someone who has never had reason to doubt that the story will come.

The building years end, as all years do, not with a ceremony but with the simple arrival of a different morning. Thirty comes. The decade turns. The notebook goes into the drawer with the others, and a new one is started.

What is being built is a life. And a life, at thirty, is far enough along to be seen — to be recognized as the specific, irreplaceable, hard-won thing it is. It is not everything that was planned. It is better than nothing in the way that real things are always better than planned things — because it is actual, because it happened, because it belongs to the people who built it in the only way that anything ever truly belongs to anyone: by being made from what they had and what they chose and what they refused to stop doing even when it was hard.

The kitchen counter. The notebook. The pen clipped to the cover.

Next month's accounting is waiting. They will sit down and do it together.

Chapter Ten

The Mid-Life Balance

Thirty to Thirty-Five

At thirty-two, Zubair Ahmed sat at his kitchen table on a Sunday morning — the table he and Rukhsana had bought secondhand in the second year of their marriage and that still had the mark on the left corner where he'd set a hot pan without thinking — and looked at the notebook.

He had been doing this first-of-the-month accounting for seven years. He knew the ritual so well that his hand moved through it before his mind fully engaged — income column, fixed expenses, variables, what had changed, what the number at the bottom said about the month ahead. He knew his own handwriting the way you know something you've repeated ten thousand times: fluently, without attention.

But this morning he stopped halfway through.

He stopped because Aiza had come into the kitchen while he was writing and had climbed onto the chair across from him — the chair where Rukhsana usually sat for this ritual — and was watching him with the specific focused interest of a seven-year-old who has decided that whatever the adult is doing is probably interesting. She had her mother's eyes. She had her own very particular way of sitting, cross-legged on the chair with her elbows on the table, that was entirely hers.

He looked at her. She looked at the notebook.

She said: what are you writing?

He said: I'm counting.

She said: counting what?

He thought about how to answer this for a moment. Then he said: everything we have and everything we need. To make sure we have enough.

She thought about this with the seriousness that seven-year-olds bring to questions that turn out to be simple. Then she said: do we have enough?

He looked at the notebook. The number at the bottom of the column was not what he had hoped it would be this month — a car repair in the third week had eaten into it, and his mother's annual medical check had cost more than he'd estimated. But the number was not nothing. It was enough for what was necessary and a smaller amount toward what was hoped for. He had been doing this calculation for long enough to know the difference between a bad month and a bad situation.

He said: yes. We have enough.

She nodded, satisfied, and climbed down from the chair and went back to whatever she had been doing before she came in. He watched her go. Then he looked at the notebook again, at the column of numbers, at the life they described — imperfect, ongoing, genuinely his — and finished the accounting.

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The View From Thirty

Thirty arrives in the Pakistani middle-class life with a particular weight that is different in kind from the weights that preceded it. It is not the weight of fear — not the panic of a twenty-two-year-old standing at the edge of the job market for the first time, or the anxiety of a twenty-six-year-old managing the first year of marriage and its attendant finances and adjustments.

Thirty is a different kind of heavy. It is the weight of perspective. The weight of having enough past to look back at.

At thirty, the middle-class person can see the shape of the journey in a way they could not at twenty-five, let alone at seventeen sitting in an exam hall with the whole future arranged before them like an unresolved equation. The shape is not what they drew. Very few lives at thirty resemble the blueprint that was sketched at seventeen or twenty-two. The apartment is rented, not owned. The career has a different form than the one that was planned. The family has a texture that was not anticipated — the specific way a marriage becomes, over years, its own country with its own language and its own customs, knowable only from the inside.

The question at thirty is not the question at twenty. At twenty the question was: who am I going to become? At thirty the question is quieter and harder: who have I become, and is this the right person, and what do I do with what's left?

This is not a crisis question. It is a reckoning question, and there is a difference. A crisis implies that something has gone wrong. A reckoning implies that things have gone — that they have happened, that time has passed, and that the time's passage deserves honest examination. Most of the thirty-year-olds in the middle-class Pakistani world who are doing this examination with any honesty find that what they have is more than they sometimes give themselves credit for, and that what they have lost or not achieved deserves acknowledgement but not collapse.

What they have, almost always, is more than their parents had at thirty. This is not a comfort to be waved away — it is a genuine measurement of something. The middle class exists, in part, to produce upward movement across generations. When it is working, the thirty-year-old is standing on ground that the parent built, and is beginning to build ground for the child. This is not glamorous. It is the quiet, continuous work of a class that does not get parades.

Islamabad — The Boy He Was

Tariq Mehmood is thirty-four years old and teaches secondary school English in Islamabad. He is Omar from Chapter Four's older version — not literally, but in the way that the person who made the quiet decision to teach rather than pursue the more prestigious path becomes, a decade later, a particular kind of person. Settled in the right thing. Not wealthy. Not remarkable by the standards the world uses most loudly. But present in his life in a way that people who chose the wrong path for the right reasons sometimes take decades to achieve.

He thinks about the younger versions of himself. Not obsessively — he is not a man given to extended retrospection. But he has students in his Class Nine who remind him of the boy he was at fourteen, and the reminding is instructive.

The boy he was at fourteen was performing. Performing capability, performing confidence, performing the specific version of okayness that middle-class children learn to perform because the household needs them to be fine and they understand this and cooperate with the need. He was good at it. His parents had never known, fully, the weight he was carrying — not because they were inattentive but because he was skilled at the performance. This is not their failure or his. It is what the middle-class childhood produces: children who are fluent in the language of fine.

At thirty-four, he is no longer performing. This is the primary difference between himself now and himself then, and it took longer to arrive than he expected. It came gradually, through the accumulation of years in which the performance was neither possible nor necessary. Years of teaching, which requires an authenticity that audiences — even twelve-year-old audiences — detect the absence of immediately. Years of a marriage with a woman named Saima who was not interested in the performance and said so, early and clearly, in the way of someone who has decided that she does not have the time or the patience for versions of people. Years of becoming a father to a son who looks at him with the unfiltered attention of a five-year-old who simply wants to know who this person is.

He cannot perform for his son. His son would know. So he stopped performing, first for his son, and then, gradually, everywhere.

What is underneath the performance — what has always been underneath it, covered by the carefully maintained surface of okayness — is a person who is sometimes tired and sometimes uncertain and occasionally afraid, and who has learned that these are not failures of character but conditions of being alive in a demanding world, and that admitting them to the right people at the right time is not weakness but the precondition for being genuinely known.

He is genuinely known, now, by Saima and by a handful of people who have been in his life long enough to see through the performance and who have stayed anyway. This is not a small thing. This is, in the accounting he does of his life at thirty-four — an accounting that has no notebook, that happens in the unstructured time of long drives or Sunday mornings before the house wakes — this is one of the most significant entries on the right side of the column.

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What the Career Has Become

The career at thirty-two or thirty-three is a different entity from what it was at twenty-five. It has scar tissue. It has the accumulated knowledge of what doesn't work and the more valuable knowledge of what does. It has the specific confidence that comes from having survived the things that seemed unsurvivable in the early years — the bad review, the job loss, the period of uncertainty that resolved itself eventually and proved, in the resolving, that uncertainty can be survived.

It also has constraints that were not present at twenty-five. The career at thirty-three belongs to a person who has a mortgage payment or a rent and a child's school fees and aging parents and a set of monthly obligations that make risk-taking structurally more expensive than it was in the years when the only person affected by a bad month was the person themselves. The

entrepreneur who would have launched a business at twenty-six without a second thought thinks twice at thirty-three, because the second thought now involves people who depend on the outcome.

Saad Siddiqui — the boy who watched his father at the dining table with the bills, who stopped asking for extra things, who grew up with a precision about money that was not natural but built — is thirty-one now. He is a finance manager at a manufacturing company in Lahore. He has been at this company for four years. He earns one hundred and seventy thousand rupees a month, which is more than his father earned at the same age, in the same city, adjusted for nothing because adjustment is complicated and the number itself is what matters to the part of him that still remembers the dining table.

He is good at his job in the way that people are good at things they were trained for by their whole childhoods. Numbers make sense to him. Not just the arithmetic of them — the story they tell, the gaps they reveal, the version of reality that they describe when you know how to read them. He has known how to read them since he was twelve, sitting on his bed after seeing his father's face over the salary slip.

He has thought about starting something. A consultancy, perhaps — small businesses in Lahore need financial guidance that they cannot afford to hire full-time. He has the knowledge. He has seen, from the inside of a large organization, the specific mistakes that organizations make when the financial function is not taken seriously. He has imagined, more than once, what it would look like to do this work for himself rather than for a company whose priorities he cannot fully control.

He has not done it yet. He may do it. The window is not closed — he is thirty-one, not sixty-one, and the consultancy that was imagined at thirty-one can still become real at thirty-five or thirty-seven. What he has learned from the years of the dining table and the notebook and the careful management of a life that had no margin for error is that timing matters. That the same move made at the right time is an opportunity and at the wrong time is a crisis. He is watching the timing. He is building the thing on the side, quietly, the way the middle class builds things — without announcement, without guarantee, with the patient faith

that the accumulated effort will eventually reach a threshold where it becomes real.

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The Generation Above

By thirty-two or thirty-three, the parent who was the architecture of the world has become, in some essential way, a person. Not just a parent — a person, with a history that preceded the child and with a present that the child is now old enough to see clearly.

The father who seemed to know everything at the dining table — who seemed to inhabit his role as provider with a completeness that left no visible seam, no gap between the man and the function — is now visible as someone who did not always know, who was sometimes afraid, who made the decisions he made from the same position of incomplete information and insufficient resources that his child is now navigating in his own household.

This recognition is one of the most significant experiences of the early thirties. It arrives not as a revelation but as a slow focusing of a lens that has been adjusting for years. The child who became an adult who became a parent looks at the parent and sees, perhaps for the first time, the full dimensions of what was carried. Not just the financial carrying — the emotional carrying. The fear that was managed. The uncertainty that was never shown. The specific courage of a person who goes to work every morning not because the work is glorious but because the family needs the income and the family is the point.

Amna Raza — who studied by battery lamp in Rawalpindi, who had the tutor her father paid for out of money she now knows was borrowed — is thirty now. She is a doctor, the thing the battery lamp was for. She works at a hospital in Rawalpindi, the city she grew up in, in a department that sees the kind of patients her family was always a medical emergency away from becoming. She is not wealthy. She is a junior doctor whose salary is not yet proportionate to her training and will not be for some years.

But she is a doctor. The thing the battery lamp was aimed at exists.

She talks to her father differently now. Not because they weren't close before — they were always close, in the quiet, economical way of a father and daughter who understood each other without requiring extensive explanation. But the closeness now has a different texture. She understands what he did. She understands the specific quality of love that expresses itself as a tutor paid for in borrowed money and a battery lamp's battery checked every evening before she sat down to study. She understands it because she is now doing the version of it for her own household — managing the money, making the calculation, deciding what can wait and what cannot.

Last year her father had a knee problem. Surgery was the recommendation — not urgent, but indicated. The cost was two hundred and eighty thousand rupees at a private hospital. Her father had begun to research the government option, which would require a waiting period of several months and a quality of care that was technically adequate and practically insufficient.

Amna paid for the private surgery. Not from savings — she did not have enough savings. She arranged it. She managed it. Her father said: Amna, it's too much. She said: Baba, let me. The same words Saira had said to her father in Chapter Six. The middle class's language for the reversal of the carrying, passed from generation to generation.

Her father said: theek hai. He did not say thank you. He didn't need to. She understood the theek hai the same way Saira understood her father's, the same way Nasir understood his father's jaa at the bus station. Some acknowledgements in this world travel in single words that carry the weight of full sentences, and the people who need to understand them do.

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What Balance Actually Means

The word balance is overused in discussions of this life stage, and it is overused because it implies a stasis, an equilibrium — as if the goal of the early thirties is to arrive at a point where everything is steady, where all the competing demands have found their proper weight and settled into arrangement.

This is not what balance is. Balance in the middle-class Pakistani life at thirty-two or thirty-four is not stasis. It is motion. It is the motion of a person carrying multiple things simultaneously and adjusting continuously — shifting weight from one side to the other as circumstances require, never fully still, never fully off-balance, moving through the days with a practiced management of competing demands that has become, through years of practice, largely unconscious.

Rukhsana teaches school, manages the household budget, raises Aiza, calls her parents twice a week, supports Zubair in the moments when the pressure accumulates in him in the particular way that he doesn't always have language for, and does all of this in a body that has not had an uninterrupted eight hours of sleep since Aiza was born. She does it with competence and occasional desperation and a specific dark humor that has become, over the years, her primary mode of processing the distance between the life she lives and any version of an easier life that she might have imagined at twenty.

"I am not balanced," she said, when I used the word. "I am juggling. There is a difference. Balanced suggests I have found the right configuration. I haven't. Every week the configuration is different because every week something is different. I just try not to drop the things that would break."

She paused. She was grading papers at the kitchen table — the same table with the pan mark on the left corner. Aiza was in the next room doing something that involved a lot of shuffling and occasional singing.

"The things that would break," she said, "are not the same things I thought they were at twenty-five. I used to think everything would break if I didn't hold it perfectly. Now I know the things that actually break and the things that just bend." She marked a paper. "Most things bend. You'd be surprised how much most things bend."

The Body Begins Its Own Accounting

Something else happens in the early thirties that nobody schedules and nobody warns you about. The body, which has been largely cooperative through the years of university and early career and marriage and the particular physical demands of early parenthood — the body begins to send notes.

Not catastrophic notes, usually. Not the acute crises of illness but the chronic, low-grade messages of a system that has been running under sustained pressure and is beginning to record the cost. The back that didn't used to hurt. The sleep that doesn't restore the way it once did. The headache that used to be occasional and is now occasional in a more frequent sense. The blood pressure number at the routine check that is slightly higher than it was three years ago and that the doctor says is fine but to watch.

Zubair went for a check-up in the month he turned thirty-two. His first proper check-up in four years — not because he had been avoiding it but because there had always been something more urgent, some other demand on the time and money that a check-up requires. The doctor found nothing alarming. He found something worth monitoring — cholesterol slightly elevated, blood pressure on the high end of normal. He said: you need to exercise more, sleep more, reduce stress.

Zubair sat in the doctor's office and thought about what reducing stress would require. It would require: not having a child, not having a rent payment, not having the notebook, not being the eldest son of parents who needed some portion of him every month, not being in the middle of a career that required things of him that he was not always certain he had to give. It would require not being the person he was, living the life he was living, in the city and the time he was living in.

He said: I'll try. The doctor said: that's all you can do. He said it with the practiced sympathy of a man who says it to a hundred people a month and means it for all of them.

Zubair started walking in the evenings. Not far — thirty minutes, through the neighborhood, at a pace that was more purposeful than his usual walking but less than exercise in any technical sense. He did it four evenings a week and skipped it when the evening did not permit, which was often. He considered this sufficient. It was probably not sufficient and was certainly better than nothing and was what was available.

Rukhsana started walking with him on the evenings when her mother could stay with Aiza. They did not always talk during these walks. Sometimes they talked about Aiza, about the notebook, about something that needed attention. Sometimes they walked without talking in the comfortable silence that a marriage that has enough years in it develops — the silence that is not absence but presence, the silence that means: we are here, we are still here, we are walking in the same direction.

These walks became, over months, the part of the week both of them protected. Not aggressively — they missed them without guilt when life required it. But they noticed when they missed them. The noticing was a sign of what the walks had become: not exercise exactly, not even conversation exactly. Just thirty minutes in which the management of everything stopped being managed and two people who had agreed to build a life together walked in the direction of the same destination, in the dark, in the city that was theirs.

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What Aiza Is Learning

Aiza is seven years old and she knows more than her parents think she knows. This is not unusual. This is the condition of children in attentive households — they absorb more than the adults intend to transmit, through proximity and attention and the specific sensitivity of people who are still forming their understanding of the world and therefore observing it with a precision that adults, who have already formed their understanding and stopped looking quite so carefully, no longer bring to it.

She knows that the first of the month is when Baba gets out the notebook. She knows that some months he finishes and is quiet in a way that is not the usual quiet, and some months he finishes and there is something easier in his face. She has not been told to notice this. She notices it the way she notices everything — naturally, without effort, filing it away in the part of herself that is assembling a picture of how the world works.

She knows that when her parents walk in the evenings they come back different. Slightly lighter. She has heard them laugh on those walks from the window of her room where she does her homework. The laugh her father has on those walks is different from his daytime laugh — it comes from somewhere deeper, less managed.

She knows that her grandmother — Rukhsana's mother, who comes to stay when they go walking — makes tea a specific way that nobody else in her life makes it, and that this specific way of making tea is something she associates with safety, with the feeling of a house that has known her since before she could remember.

She knows that money is a thing that requires attention. Not because anyone has explained this to her explicitly, but because the attention itself is visible — the notebook on the counter, the conversations that pause when she enters the room and resume after she has been redirected somewhere else, the careful way her parents consider certain things before saying yes and the immediate ease with which they say yes to other things. She is mapping the territory of what is easy and what is considered, and the map, without anyone intending it, is teaching her the economics of the household.

She will carry this map. Not as a burden — as knowledge. The child raised in a household where money is treated with honest, careful attention learns something about the world that children raised in either extreme — scarcity or abundance — often don't. She learns that resources are real and finite and require management, and that the management is an act of love, and that the people doing the managing are doing it for her, and that she should one day be able to do it for someone else.

This is the inheritance that doesn't appear in any will. It is the inheritance that the middle class passes silently, through behavior and habit and the notebook on the kitchen counter, to the next generation. It is arguably the most important thing passed. Certainly it is the most durable.

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What Thirty-Four Feels Like

Tariq Mehmood is thirty-four. He is teaching a Class Nine English lesson on a Wednesday morning. He has been teaching for eight years. He knows this material in the way you know something you have given yourself to completely — not as information but as texture, as the feel of a thing that has become part of you through sustained contact.

He has a student in this class who reminds him, specifically, of himself at fourteen. Not in appearance. In a quality of attention — the way the boy listens, the way his face moves when he encounters an idea that is new to him, the specific look of someone for whom language is not just a subject but a way of organizing the world. Tariq has been teaching for eight years and he has had perhaps three students who looked at words this way. He makes time for this boy. He gives him things to read that are not on the syllabus. He tells him, when the boy stays after class to talk, what he found in books at his age and what it did for him.

He does not tell the boy what to become. He has been the child who was told what to become and he knows the cost of that. He tells the boy: read everything. Stay curious. The path sorts itself out if you keep moving.

The boy asks: did your path sort itself out?

Tariq thinks about this with genuine honesty, the way he approaches everything now. He thinks about the CSS form he didn't submit. About the father whose silence lasted two months. About the first class he taught, eight years ago, in a room with forty students and one overhead fan and the feeling of having arrived at precisely the right place through precisely the wrong

door. About Saima, who asked him who he was and waited for the real answer. About his son, five years old, who looks at him with the unfiltered attention of someone who has not yet learned to look away.

He says: yes. Not in a straight line. But yes.

The boy nods. He writes something in the margin of his notebook. Tariq doesn't see what it is. He moves on to the next student, the next question, the next hour of a Wednesday that is, in most of its details, entirely ordinary.

This is what thirty-four looks like from the inside, on a Wednesday. Ordinary, ongoing, real.

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What Was Always True

This book began with a kitchen table — or rather, with the decision made at a kitchen table between two people who were calculating whether they could afford to love someone they hadn't met yet. It began with the cost of a birth, the cost of a first decade, the cost of an education and a career and a marriage and the particular, ongoing cost of being in the middle — not poor, not wealthy, but fully and completely alive in a life that asks everything of you and gives back something that is not always what you asked for but is, in the accounting that matters, enough.

We have followed these people — Saad and Amna and Raza and Nasir and Bilal and Rukhsana and Zubair and Tariq and all the others, named and unnamed, in Lahore and Karachi and Rawalpindi and Islamabad and Peshawar — through the years from birth to their mid-thirties. We have sat at their dinner tables and in their shared hostel rooms and at their rishta meetings and in the bathrooms where they sat on the edge of the bathtub counting twenty-two minutes on their watches. We have listened to them describe their fathers' faces and their mothers' duas and their children's questions and their own late-night reckoning with who they have become.

What I want to say, at the end, is this.

The middle-class Pakistani life is not a tragedy. It contains tragedy — loss and failure and the specific suffering of wanting more for your children than you can give, of watching a system that should hold people up put obstacles in the path of people who deserve better. These are real. They should be named, and argued with, and worked against.

But the life itself is not a tragedy. It is, in the most honest accounting I can offer, an extraordinary exercise in the human capacity to love under pressure. The families in this book — in all their ordinariness, in all their careful management of insufficient resources, in all their performance of okayness and their private notebooks and their foam weatherstripping and their evening walks in the dark — these families are not surviving despite their love. They are surviving because of it. The love is the infrastructure. It is the thing that holds when the budget doesn't, when the plan fails, when the year is worse than the year before it.

Muzamil Khan, from Hanna Urak, is somewhere in his mid-twenties now, finishing a degree, carrying a UNICEF scholarship, having stood in rooms where once he would not have been expected to stand and spoken in a language he taught himself in a city that did not initially welcome him. He is not the rule. But he is not a miracle either. He is what happens when a person refuses — clearly, consistently, over years — to accept the version of themselves that their circumstances suggest is the ceiling.

Zubair sits at the kitchen table on the first of the month. The notebook is open. The pen is moving. Aiza has climbed down from the chair and gone back to the other room, and her singing drifts through the apartment in the unfocused, tuneless way of children who sing not for anyone but because the sound is in them and needs somewhere to go.

He finishes the accounting. The number at the bottom is enough. He closes the notebook. He goes to find his daughter.

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A Final Word

I want to say something directly, from myself, before this book closes.

I wrote this book because I have spent years watching this life from close range. I know what the accounting at the kitchen table looks like from the doorway. I know the specific expression on a parent's face when the month does not quite reach. I have sat across from the people in these pages and listened to them describe wanting more than the available, planning carefully inside a budget that does not always plan back, carrying the hope of families that have given everything they have.

I wrote it because I believe that this life — the middle-class life, the life in the middle, the life that asks too much and gives not quite enough and keeps going anyway — deserves to be looked at directly. Not with pity. Not with the particular condescension of a social study. With the respect that you give to something that is genuinely hard and genuinely worthwhile and genuinely human.

The people in this book are real, in the ways that matter. Their situations are composites, their names are changed, their stories are assembled from the dozens of conversations that went into this writing. But the experience they describe — the kitchen table, the notebook, the battery lamp, the foam weatherstripping, the two days of incomplete sentences, the hand on the shoulder at the bus station — this experience is real. It is happening right now, in thousands of households across Pakistan, in the ordinary daily labor of people who love their families and are doing what can be done with what they have.

They deserve to be seen. This book is my attempt to see them.

If you recognise yourself in these pages — in Saad's careful precision, in Amna's battery lamp, in Nasir's two hundred and thirty-one applications, in Raza's twelve-minute phone call, in Zubair's notebook and Rukhsana's weatherstripping — then I have done what I set out to do. You have been seen. Your life is not invisible. Your effort is not nothing.

It is, in fact, everything.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

A book about the middle class is, by definition, a book about what is built collectively and invisibly over time. Writing it has required the same kind of collective, often invisible support that its subjects rely on every day. I am grateful to everyone who contributed to it.

The People Who Spoke

First and most importantly, to everyone who spoke to me for this book — who described their lives, their families, their kitchen tables and notebooks and salary slips, their successes and their failures and the long spaces in between. You trusted me with the true version of your lives, which is the only version worth anything. I hope I have been worthy of that trust. Your names have been changed. Your truth has not.

Muzamil Khan

To my cousin Muzamil Khan, from Hanna Urak, Balochistan — who allowed me to tell his story and who has been, throughout the writing of this book, its conscience. You are the proof of what this country's children can do when they are given half a chance. You gave yourself more than half a chance. The parts you had to give yourself were not yours to have to give. I am proud of you in a way that I do not have adequate words for, and I have spent considerable time trying to find words.

Your journey from Hanna Urak to the University of Balochistan to a UNICEF scholarship to the stage at IBA Karachi is not a journey that should have required what it required of you. It is a journey that should be ordinary. The fact that it has been extraordinary is a failure of the system and a triumph of you. I hope the book honours both.

The People of Quetta, Lahore, Karachi, and Everywhere Else

To every family in every city whose story is in this book in some form — the families of Quetta's Satellite Town and Pashtoonabad and Jinnah Town, the families of Gulshan-e-Iqbal in Karachi and University Town in Peshawar and Gulberg in Lahore and G-10 in Islamabad. You did not know you were in a book. You were simply living your lives with the honesty and the endurance that the middle-class Pakistani life demands. That honesty is what the book is made of.

The Writers Who Showed the Way

To Muhammad Hanif, whose fiction about Pakistan taught me what it looks like to write this country from the inside without flinching. To Khaled Hosseini, whose novels about ordinary people under extraordinary pressure demonstrated that the domestic and the political are not separate subjects. To Aravind Adiga, whose *White Tiger* showed that class can be the subject of literature without apology. To Barbara Ehrenreich, whose *Nickel and Dimed* remains the standard for immersive, honest nonfiction about working-class life. These writers did not write this book. But they showed me that it was possible to write it.

A Note of Gratitude

To everyone who read early drafts and told me the truth — which is harder to give and more valuable to receive than any other form of editorial feedback. To the teachers in government schools across Pakistan who showed up every day in conditions that should have defeated them and did not. To the students who kept studying despite everything. To the parents who kept paying the fees despite everything.

To the middle class of Pakistan, which asks everything of itself and tells nobody. This book is yours.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Dolat Khan is a Pakistani writer who has spent years in close observation of the middle-class life — the families, the kitchen tables, the salary slips, the specific and daily arithmetic of a life that asks everything and gives back something that is never quite what was hoped for and always, somehow, enough.

He has spent years observing and writing about Pakistani society, with a particular focus on the lives of ordinary people who do not typically appear in literary accounts of the country — not the very poor, whose suffering has its own extensive literature, and not the wealthy, who have no shortage of representation. The middle class: the class that holds the country together from inside an impossible position and receives almost no acknowledgement for doing so.

The Surviving Age is his second book. His first, The Power of Minor Shift, explored how small deliberate changes produce lasting results in work and life. It grew from a conviction that the middle-class Pakistani life deserved to be looked at directly — not with pity, not with the condescension of sociological distance, but with the specific, human, ground-level attention that reveals a world of extraordinary love and endurance operating inside very ordinary circumstances.

His cousin Muzamil Khan, whose story appears in Chapter Three, is a BS Mass Communication and Media student at the University of Balochistan, a UNICEF scholar, and one of the most determined people Dolat has ever had the privilege of knowing.

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A NOTE ON SOURCES

This book is a work of narrative nonfiction. The stories, characters, and situations in it are drawn from real life — from interviews, conversations, and the author's own observation and experience of the Pakistani middle-class world over many years. All identifying details including names, locations, and specific professional and family circumstances have been changed or composited to protect the privacy of the individuals involved. No character in this book is intended to represent any single specific person.

On Economic Figures

The salary figures, school fee ranges, medical costs, property prices, and other economic data cited throughout the book reflect conditions in urban Pakistan broadly between 2022 and 2025. These figures are derived from the author's research and interviews rather than from single official sources, and are intended to give the reader a grounded sense of the economic reality of middle-class Pakistani life rather than to make statistical arguments. Readers seeking precise current data are directed to the Pakistan Bureau of Statistics, the State Bank of Pakistan's annual reports, and the annual reports of the Pakistan Institute of Development Economics (PIDE).

On Mental Health

The material in Chapter Six concerning suicide, depression, and anxiety is informed by the author's research and interviews, as well as general reading in the field of South Asian mental health. Readers seeking support for mental health issues in Pakistan are encouraged to contact:

Umang Pakistan Helpline: 0317-4288665

Rozan Counselling Helpline (Islamabad): 051-2890505

Umang (Karachi): 0311-7786264

Pakistan Association for Mental Health: pamh.org.pk

These resources are available to anyone who is struggling. The stories in this book are about loss and survival simultaneously. If you are carrying something heavy, you do not have to carry it alone.

Further Reading

Readers interested in the broader context of middle-class life, economic inequality, and social mobility in Pakistan and South Asia may find the following works useful:

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